THE PIANO BUTLER



Handbook

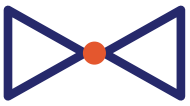
Everything behind the music you play: reading, rhythm, expression, scales, chords, harmony, shape and style, from your first lesson to Grade 8.

WITH THE WORKBOOK, THE APP AND READ & LISTEN

This book belongs to

My teacher

I started on



THE PIANO BUTLER

Handbook

Music theory for pianists,
from the first lesson to Grade 8

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thepianobutler.com

The Piano Butler Handbook

Draft edition, November 2026

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The music examples are drawn from works in the public domain (traditional tunes and composers who died more than 70 years ago), newly engraved for this book.

Piano Butler is independent. It is not affiliated with, or endorsed by, any examination board. Grade levels in this book are a guide to the order in which ideas are usually met.

The Read & listen narration uses computer-generated voices.

ISBN: to come

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THE PIANO BUTLER HANDBOOK

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Welcome

This book explains the music you play: what the signs on the page mean, why a piece sounds the way it does, and how to play it well. It is the whole picture in one place, for you to dip into whenever a piece asks a question.

Who it is for

1. **Students** from the first lesson to Grade 8, reading with a teacher or a parent, or on their own.
2. **Adults** coming back to the piano, who want the reasons, not only the rules.
3. **Teachers** who want one clear explanation of each idea, with exercises to match.

Three promises

A picture first.	Every idea starts with something you can see, then something you can play.
Said once, clearly.	Each idea has one home in this book. Other pages point to it instead of saying it again.
Always at the piano.	Every chapter ends at the keys: a ten-second Try it, a tune you know, a game.

THINK OF IT A good butler keeps the whole house in order, so that you can simply enjoy living in it. This book keeps the theory in order, so that you can simply enjoy playing.

ABOUT THIS BOOK

How the pieces fit

The Handbook is the centre. Everything else is cut from it, so an idea always looks and sounds the same wherever you meet it.

The Handbook
the whole picture, by topic

The Workbook
two pages to write in for every chapter: Learn, then Use

Read & listen
every chapter read aloud, the page moving with the voice; scan a code or open it in the app

The house
in the app: the chapters in the order you need them, a floor for each level, a room for each step, with drills

Level books
one floor of the house in print: one spread per room, then practise

Which one when?

WHEN YOU WANT TO…	USE
understand an idea, or look it up	**the Handbook**
check you really know it	**the Workbook**
hear it explained, at home or on the bus	**Read & listen**
know what to learn next	**the house**, or your **Level book**
practise it until it is easy	**the drills** in the app

ABOUT THIS BOOK

The levels

The house in the app puts the chapters in the order you need them, one floor for each level. Here are the floors, with the Handbook pages for each room. The floors follow the usual exam grades: Beginner, Prelim, then Grade 1 to Grade 8.

Beginner

Sitting and hands, the keyboard and the staff, beat and note values, loud and soft, and fingering.

Posture and hand shape	18–20
The keyboard	22–26
Fingering	163–164
The staff and the clefs	27–28
Pulse, tempo and the bar	50–52
Notes: crotchet and minim	53–55
Notes: three beats and the semibreve	53–55
Loud and soft	76–78

Prelim

How to practise, reading the notes, how long a note lasts, time signatures, repeats, touch, major and minor scales, and your first chords.

Practising well	165–166
The staff and the keyboard	29–31
Reading the notes	32–35
How long is a note?	56–58
Time signatures	59–61
Repeats and road signs	71–73
Touch: smooth, short, strong	79–81
Major scales	93–95
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Chords and triads	110–112
Review	

Grade 1

Ledger lines, sharps and flats, intervals, key signatures, 6/8, speed words, four kinds of triad and sight-reading.

Ledger lines	36–38
Sharps, flats and naturals	39–41
Counting intervals	42–44
Keys and key signatures	99–101
Compound and irregular time	62–64
Speed words	82–84
Four kinds of triad	113–115
Sight-reading	167–168
Review	

THE LEVELS · CONTINUED

Grade 2

Major, minor and perfect, upbeats and triplets, finding the key, the pedals, chords in a key, motifs and phrases.

Major, minor and perfect	45–47
Rhythm: groups and upbeats	65–67
Finding the key	102–104
The pedals	85–87
Chords in a key	116–118
Motifs and phrases	148–149
Review	

Grade 3

The circle of fifths, ornaments, inversions, repetition and sequence, and listening.

The circle of fifths	105–107
Ornaments	88–90
Inversions	119–121
Repetition and sequence	150–151
Listening	169–170
Review	

Grade 4

Off the beat, cadences, chords under a melody, texture and changing key.

Rhythm: off the beat	68–70
Cadences	139–141
Chords under a melody	142–143
Texture	152–153
Changing key	154–155
Review	

Grade 5

Form, styles through time, chords from outside the key, progressions and performing.

Form	156–158
Styles through time	159–160
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Notes outside the chord	175–176
Performing	171–172
Review	

Grade 6

Seventh chords and slash chords, and cadences by ear.

Seventh chords	122–124
Slash chords	131–133
Review	

Grade 7

Colour chords (Extra), and every earlier chapter a step further.

Colour chords	125–127
Review	

Grade 8

Tall chords: 9, 11, 13 (Extra), and every earlier chapter a step further.

The tower: 9, 11, 13	128–130
Review	

A room marked with a second title, such as “a step further”, comes back to a chapter you have met before and goes one step deeper. The rest of the chapter can wait for its own level.

ABOUT THIS BOOK

Meet the cast

You will hear these voices in Read & listen and meet them in the Think of it boxes. Each one stands for an idea, so the idea is easy to remember.

The Butler
YOUR GUIDE

Explains every chapter, calmly, one step at a time. He is never in a hurry.

Clara
THE STUDENT

Asks the questions you might be thinking, and sometimes gets them wrong, so you do not have to.

The Queen
THE TREBLE CLEF

Rules the high notes. Her curl wraps round line 2, the note G.

The King
THE BASS CLEF

Rules the low notes. His two dots sit either side of line 4, the note F.

The Doorkeeper
THE KEY SIGNATURE

Stands at the start of every line and reads out the sharps or flats for the whole piece.

The Guest
AN ACCIDENTAL

Arrives in one bar wearing a sharp or flat hat, and leaves at the bar line. A natural: the hat comes off.

The Stationmaster
THE TIME SIGNATURE

Checks the ticket: how many beats in each carriage, and that every carriage is full.

ABOUT THIS BOOK

For parents

You do not need to read music to help. Ten minutes, twice a week, is enough.

Each week

1. **Listen together.** Scan the code on this week's page, or open Read & listen in the app. Most rooms take three to five minutes.
2. **One page to write.** The Workbook or Level book page for the same room. The first answer is always done, as an example.
3. **Ask one question.** "What is the secret?" If your child can say the red box in their own words, the room is learned.

Good to know

IF…	TRY THIS
the page looks hard	Read only the secret and play the Try it. The rest can wait for the lesson.
your child is tired	Listen only, no writing. Hearing it once already helps.
you missed a week	Do nothing extra. The teacher will pick it up in the lesson.
your child asks something you cannot answer	Write it down for the teacher. A good question is worth more than a right answer.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Ask: "Show me."

After any page, ask your child to show you the idea at the piano. Teaching it to you is the best practice there is.

ABOUT THIS BOOK

For teachers

The book is built so that theory happens at home and the lesson stays at the piano. Set one room a week; check it in two minutes.

In a 30-minute lesson

WHEN	IF THE ROOM WAS DONE AT HOME	IF IT WAS NOT
First 2–3 min	Check the page; ask for the secret in the student's own words.	Read the secret and the Example together (3 min).
Next 2 min	Find the idea in the piece being learned.	The same: always in the piece.
The rest	Pieces and technique.	Pieces and technique.
Last minute	Send the next room.	Send the same room again, with the next.

Good habits

Five minutes at most. If theory was not done, it never takes more than five minutes of the lesson.

Always in the piece. The idea is found in the music the student is playing, every week.

One room at a time. The house orders the rooms; a Level book prints one floor.

Reading the boxes in a lesson

BOX	USE IT FOR
The secret	the two-minute check: can the student say it in their own words?
Example	the three-minute catch-up when the room was not done
Try it	a warm-up at the start of the lesson
Game	a group lesson, or the last two minutes
Trap	when the same mistake comes back in a piece

Not sure where a new student fits? Use the **Handbook check** in the app, a short quiz that names the first chapter to read, or **Where do I start?** on p. 14.

ABOUT THIS BOOK

Where do I start?

You do not have to start at page 1. Find your place, then read from there.

IF YOU ARE…	START AT
brand new to the piano	**Before you play**, p. 18, then the Beginner floor
reading simple pieces already	the **Handbook check** (free, in the app): it names your first chapter
preparing for a grade	your floor in **The levels**, p. 9
stuck on one thing in a piece	the **Glossary and index**, p. 179, or the Tips page at the end of each part
coming back after years away	each Part's **opening map**: read the secrets only, and stop where they stop making sense

The part openers

Each Part opens with a map: every chapter in one line, with its secret. Read a map in two minutes and you know what the Part holds.

A good week

1. **One room.** Listen once, read the page, write the Workbook page.
2. **Find it in your piece.** The idea is somewhere in the music you are playing.
3. **Drill it for five minutes** in the app, on two or three days.

THINK OF IT A map does not walk for you, but it stops you walking in circles.

ABOUT THIS BOOK

My practice week

Copy this page, or draw your own. Tick a box each day you practise.

	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
30-second check	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Warm-ups	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
This week's room	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Scales	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
My piece	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Something just for fun	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

This week

Room

Piece

One thing to fix

My teacher says

ABOUT THIS BOOK

My questions

Write down anything you want to ask in your next lesson.

BEFORE YOU PLAY

How to read this book

Every chapter walks the same path: one big idea, a picture of it, then ways to see it, play it and check it. Each box has its own job, so once you know the boxes you can find your way around any page.

1 The secret · 2 Picture · 3 Learn it · 4 Example · 5 Try it, Game · 6 Trap · 7 See also

The picture and the main lesson come next; these are the boxes around them. Some pages also have **You know this**, **Think of it**, **Extra**, **How to**, **The rule** or a **Tip**.

THE SECRET

The whole chapter in one sentence. It sits at the top of every chapter, beside the opening words. Read it first, and again at the end.

EXAMPLE

A question worked through

1. Read the question.
2. Follow the numbered steps.
3. Check the answer underneath.

The answer, and why.

YOU KNOW THIS

A tune you already know

The new idea is marked in **red**, so you can hear it in real music.

GAME

A puzzle

Play it on your own or with a friend.

Answer: printed upside down, so you can check yourself

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

Try it at the piano.

Ten seconds, one small thing to feel in your hands.

THINK OF IT A picture to keep in your head, so the idea is easy to remember.

TRAP

× The mistake most people make, and how to avoid it.

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Beyond your level

Skip it for now if you like; it will still be here later.

Use the book in any order: start with the chapter your piece needs. Every chapter can also be heard in the app, in **Read & listen**.

SEE ALSO
Other pages on the same idea, with their page numbers

PRACTISE IT
Matching Workbook pages, and drills in the app

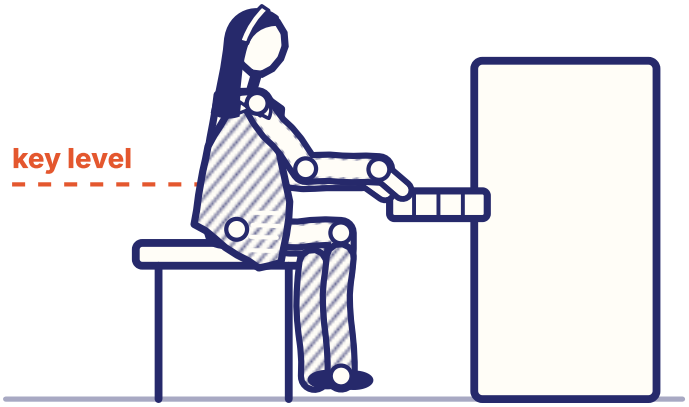
BEFORE YOU PLAY

Posture and hand shape

How you sit and how you hold your hands decide how easy everything else will be. Set them up before the first note, check them every time you sit down, and they soon look after themselves.

THE SECRET

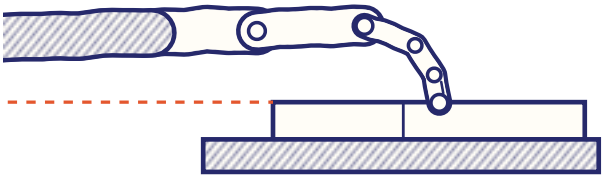
Sit tall, forearms level with the keys, a round hand on the fingertips: then let the arm's weight do the work.



1. **forearms level with the keys**
   wrist neither dropped nor lifted
2. **elbows a little in front of you**
   not pinned to your sides
3. **sit on the front half of the stool**
   opposite Middle C
4. **feet flat on the floor**
   the right foot near the pedal
5. **back tall, shoulders loose**
   lean a little towards the keys

Tall back, level arms, flat feet

A round hand



knuckles up like a bridge, the wrist level, the sound from the **fingertip**

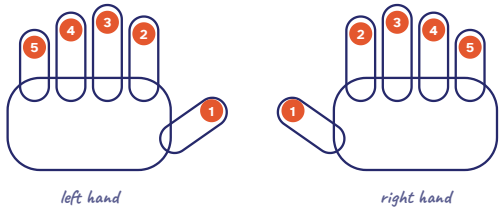


the shape a hand makes resting on a ball

PART OF THE HAND	WHAT IT DOES
fingertips	play the keys, just behind the nail (keep nails short)
knuckles	stay up, like a bridge: they never sink in
thumb	plays on the side of its tip, relaxed, not stretched out
wrist	level with the hand, loose, never resting on the wood

BEFORE YOU PLAY · CONTINUED

Finger numbers



Every finger has a number, **the same in both hands**: the thumb is **1**, then 2, 3, 4, and the little finger is **5**. Music often prints these numbers above or below the notes.

More on choosing fingers: Fingering p. 163.

Six warm-ups



1 · Rag doll

Flop forward, arms hanging heavy. Shake them loose. Float the hands up onto the keys.



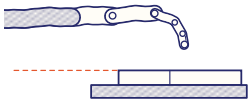
2 · Elbow wings

Elbows free, not stuck to your body. Float them out like wings, then back.



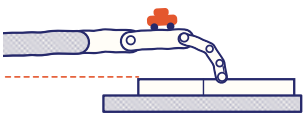
3 · Arm glide

Skate the whole arm along the keys. The round hand rides to the next group of keys.



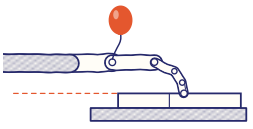
4 · Arm drop

Lift the whole arm and let it drop into a key on finger 3: firm tip, soft wrist, a round sound.



5 · Knuckle bridge

Your knuckles are a bridge a little car can drive over. Press one key slowly and hold for 3.

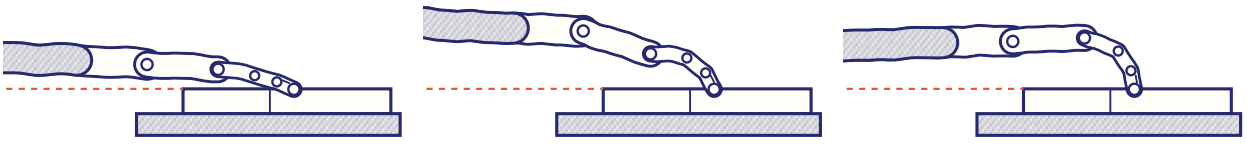


6 · Wrist balloon

As the key goes down, a balloon lifts the wrist back up to level. The fingertip stays on the key.

EXAMPLE 1

Which hand is round?



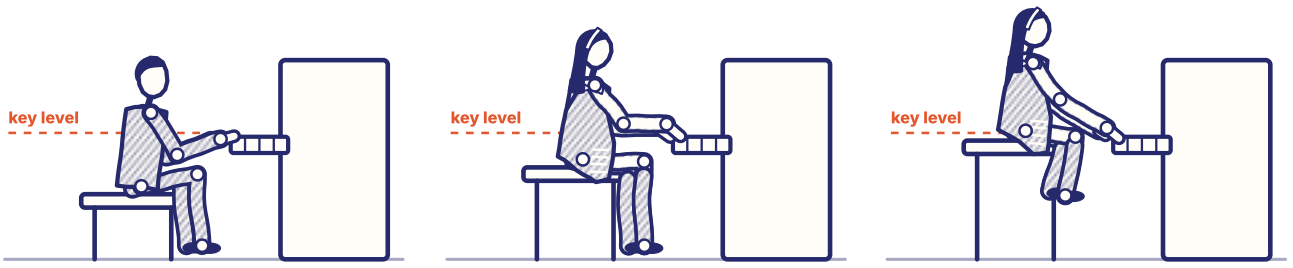
1. **Look at the knuckles:** up, or sunk in?
2. **Look at the tips:** does the finger stand on its tip?
3. **Which hand** could play all day?

C: knuckles up, curved fingers, standing on the tips. A is flat; B's knuckle has caved in.

BEFORE YOU PLAY · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Is the stool right?



A B C

1. **Follow the forearm** from the elbow to the keys.
2. **Uphill or downhill?** Then the stool is too low or too high.
3. **Which one** is level?

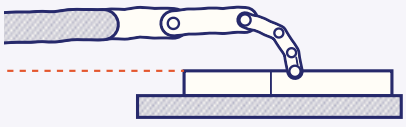
B: the forearm is level. In A the stool is too low (raise it, or add a cushion); in C it is too high.

HOW TO

The 30-second check, every time you sit down

1. **Stool:** forearms level with the keys, opposite Middle C.
2. **Body:** front half of the stool, feet flat, back tall.
3. **Shoulders:** lift them, then let them drop.
4. **Hands:** a soft ball under each palm, knuckles up.
5. **Breathe out**, then play.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



The ball test.

Hold a small ball or an orange, then put the hand on the keys without changing its shape. That is your playing hand.

THINK OF IT A good posture is like a well-tuned bicycle: you stop noticing it, and every ride gets easier.

TRAP

- × Wrists that sink below the keys, or rest on the wood: keep them level and loose.
- × Shoulders creeping up to the ears: let them drop between pieces.
- × Flat fingers, or a knuckle that caves in: stand on the fingertips.
- × Sitting too close, elbows squashed against your body: move the stool back a little.

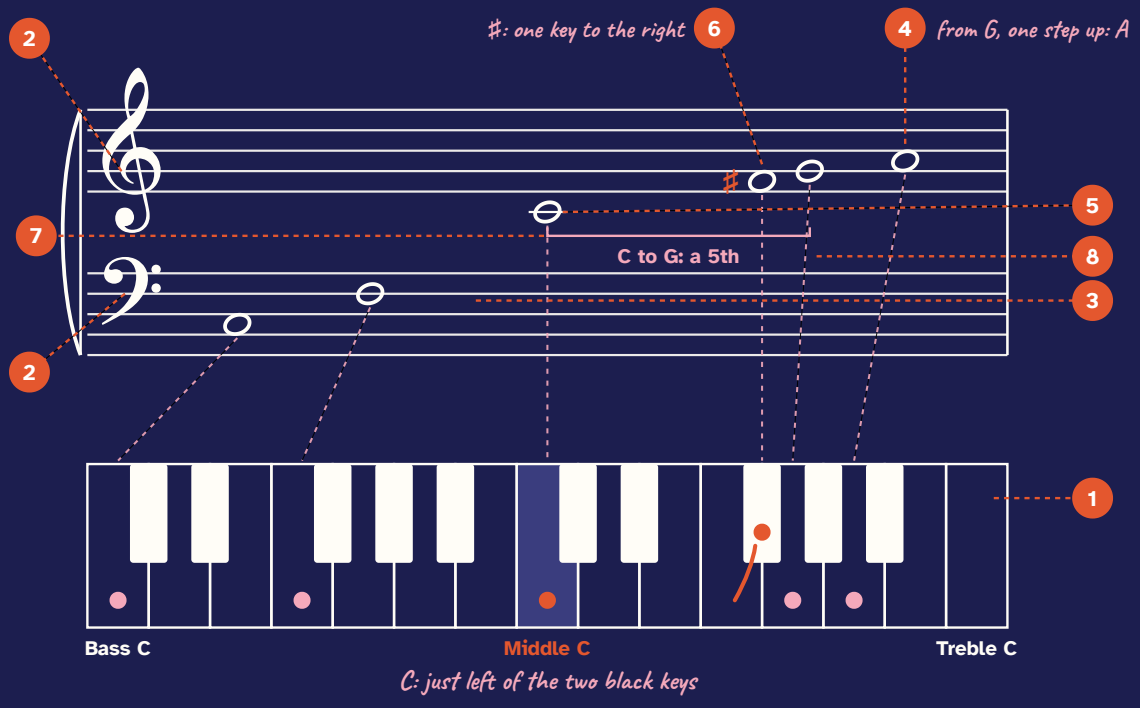
SEE ALSO
Fingering p. 163 · Practising well p. 165

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 1–2 · Online: Posture & Hand Shape

PART I · WHICH NOTE

Pitch

High or low? That is the first question every note answers. Start with the keys under your fingers, find where they live on the staff, see how sharps and flats move them, then measure how far apart two notes are. Everything in this part is in this one picture.



1 **The keyboard** p. 22
two and three black keys; C is left of the two

2 **The staff and the clefs** p. 27
the treble clef names G, the bass clef F

3 **The staff and the keyboard** p. 29
every line and space is one white key

4 **Reading the notes** p. 32
start from a clef note, then step or skip

5 **Ledger lines** p. 36
step out from the staff; Middle C has its own

6 **Sharps, flats and naturals** p. 39
a sharp moves one key right, a flat one key left

7 **Counting intervals** p. 42
count the notes, both ends: C to G is a 5th

8 **Major, minor and perfect** p. 45
count the keys between: 6 make a perfect 5th

★ **Tips: when a note reads wrong** p. 48

PART I · PITCH · 1

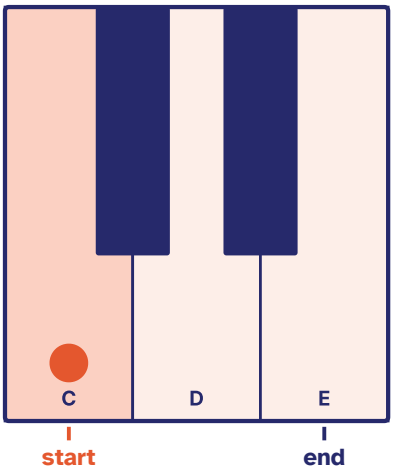
The keyboard

Eighty-eight keys look like a lot, but they repeat one small pattern again and again. Learn the pattern once and you can find any key without counting. Left is **low**, right is **high**.

THE SECRET

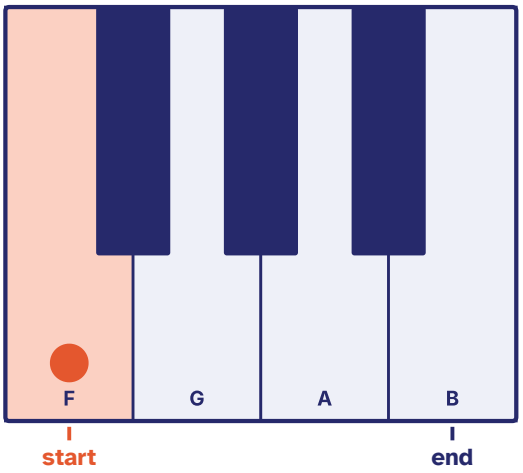
Two black keys: start on C. Three black keys: start on F. Then walk on.

2 black keys: C D E



on the piano E and F touch

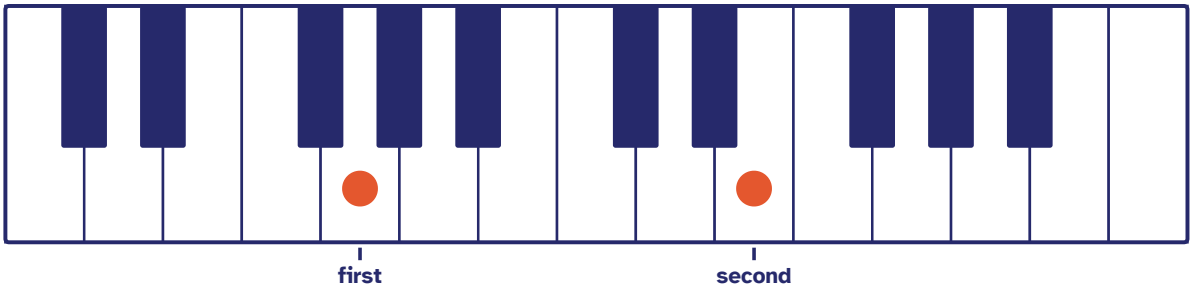
3 black keys: F G A B



Pulled apart: each family has a first key (start) and a last key (end)

EXAMPLE 1

Higher or lower?



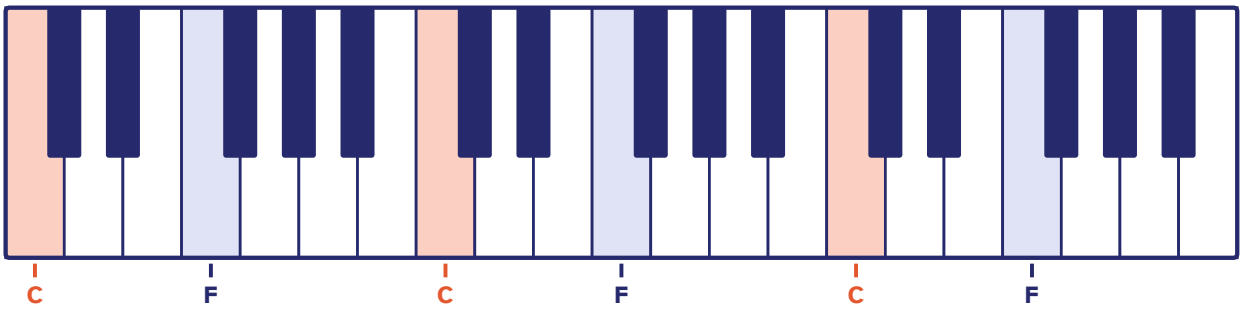
1. **Find the two red keys.**
2. **Which one is further right?**
3. **Right means higher:** play both and listen.

The second note is **higher**: it is to the right. Left is always lower, right always higher.

PART I · PITCH · 1 · CONTINUED

THE RULE

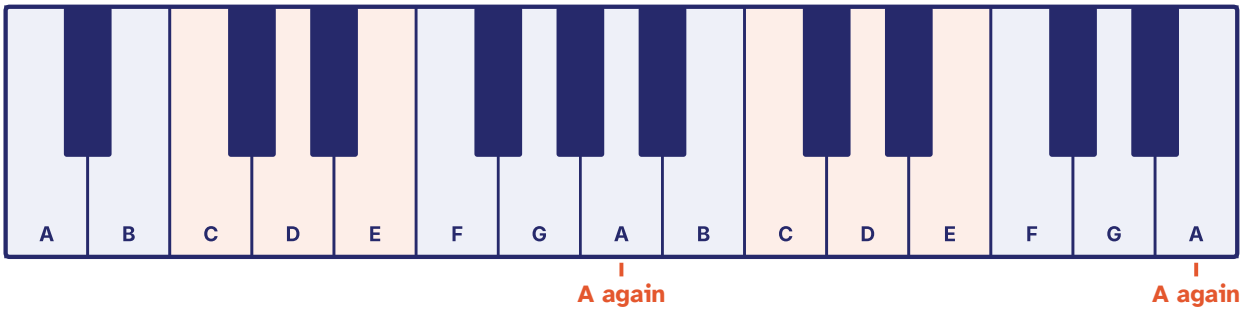
Find the group, then its first key. **Looking for D or E? Find two black keys and start on C. Looking for G, A or B? Find three black keys and start on F. You never have to count from far away.**



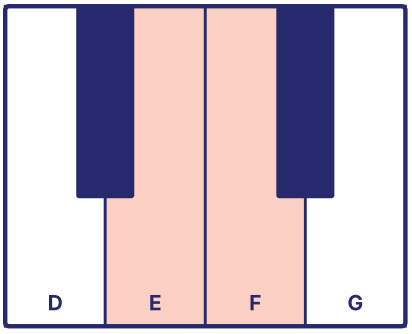
The pattern repeats all the way along: every two starts on C, every three on F

Seven letters, round and round

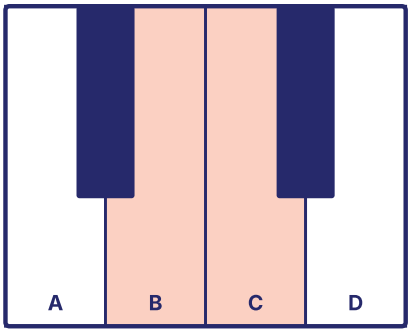
The white keys use only seven letters: **A B C D E F G**. There is no H. After G the next key is **A** again, and the seven letters go round and round, like the days of the week, all the way up the keyboard. **C D E** always sit round the two black keys, **F G A B** round the three. **E–F** and **B–C** have no black key between.



A B C D E F G, A B C D E F G, A …: after G, back to A



E–F: no black key between



B–C: no black key between

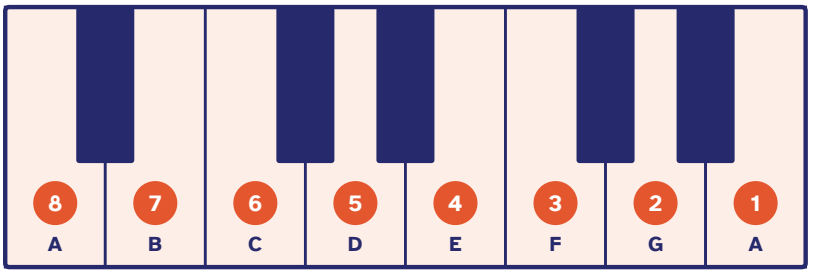
The only two pairs of white keys that touch: E–F and B–C

PART I · PITCH · 1 · CONTINUED

Going down: say it backwards

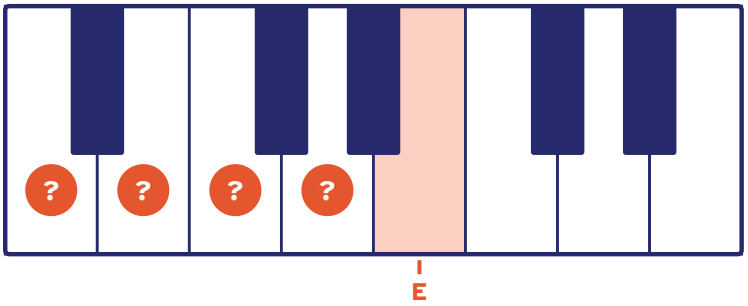
Walking **left**, down the keyboard, the letters run **backwards**: G F E D C B A, then G again. Practise saying them backwards until it is as quick as forwards: reading music that goes down depends on it.

← walk left: A G F E D C B A



EXAMPLE 2

Walk down from E

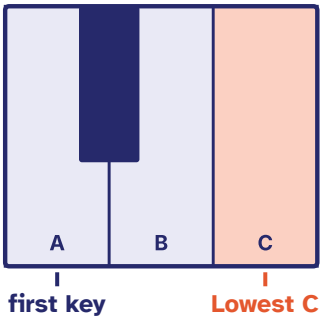


1. **Start on E**, between the two black keys.
2. **Step left** one white key at a time: name each one.
3. **Fill the gaps** out loud too: G _ E _ C.

E **D C B A**: backwards. And G **F** E **D** C.

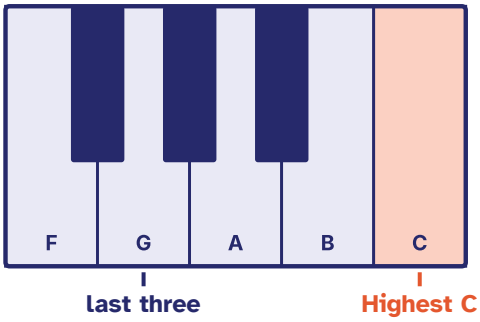
Where the keyboard starts

The very first key, bottom left, is an **A**. Look at the black keys there: only **one**, on its own. It is a group of three that has been cut off: only its end is left. The end of F G A B is **A B**, so the piano starts on A. After A and B comes the first full group of two, and its first key is **Lowest C**.



Where it ends

The very last key, top right, has **no black key** after it. Look left: the last group is **three** black keys, F G A B. After B comes C, the first key of a new group of two that was never built. So the last key is a **C**: **Highest C**.

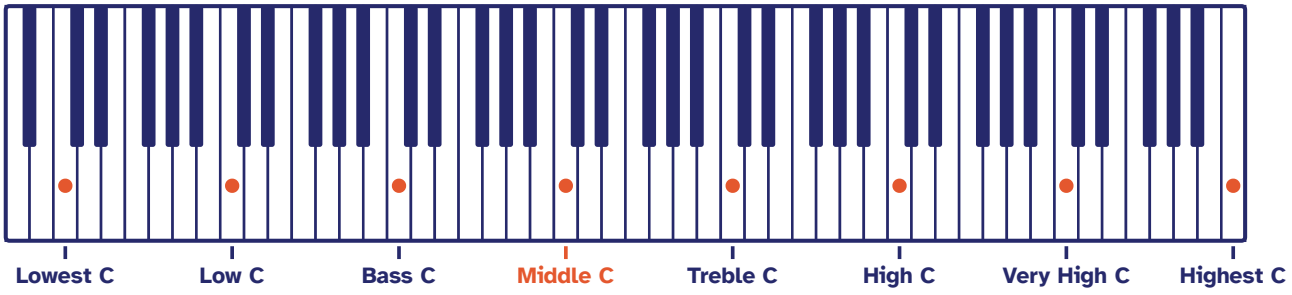


PART I · PITCH · 1 · CONTINUED

The eight Cs have names

Count the Cs from the bottom and there are eight. The C nearest the middle is **Middle C**. Either side are **Bass C** and **Treble C**; further out, **Low C** and **High C**. At the ends: **Lowest C** at the bottom; at the top, **Very High C**, then **Highest C**, the very last key. (No Very Low C: the piano starts on A.) From one C to the next is an **octave**: C D E F G A B C, eight notes, both Cs counted.

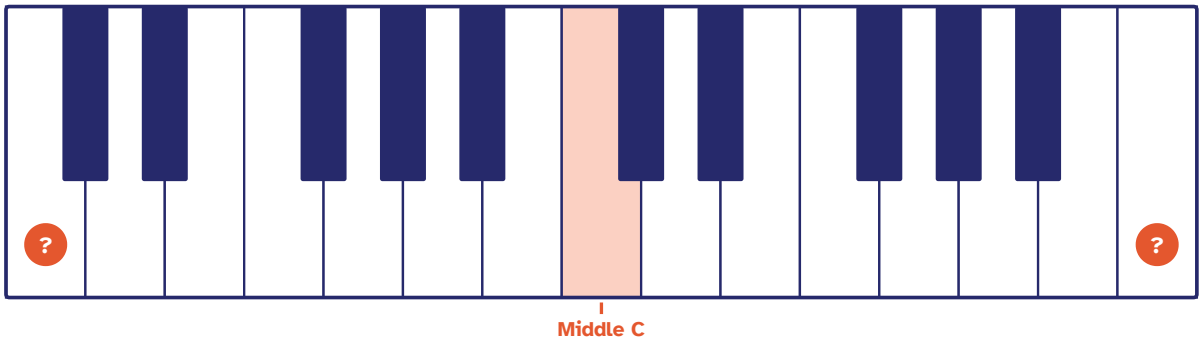
Theory books and apps number them from the bottom instead: C1 is Lowest C, C4 Middle C, C8 Highest C.



All 88 keys, eight Cs: the five in the middle, Low C to High C, are the ones you will use most

EXAMPLE 3

Find Bass C and Treble C



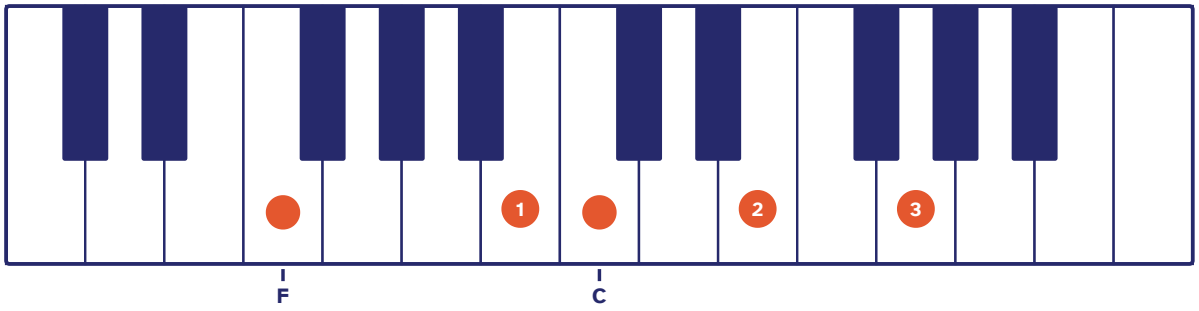
1. **Start on Middle C.**
2. **Walk left** to the next pair of black keys. The C just left of it is one **?**.
3. **Walk right** the same way, to the next pair: the other **?**.

Left **?**: **Bass C**. Right **?**: **Treble C**. Each is one octave, eight notes, from Middle C.

PART I · PITCH · 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 4

Find three keys: B, E and G



1 **Which family?** C D E sit round the **two** black keys; F G A B round the **three**.

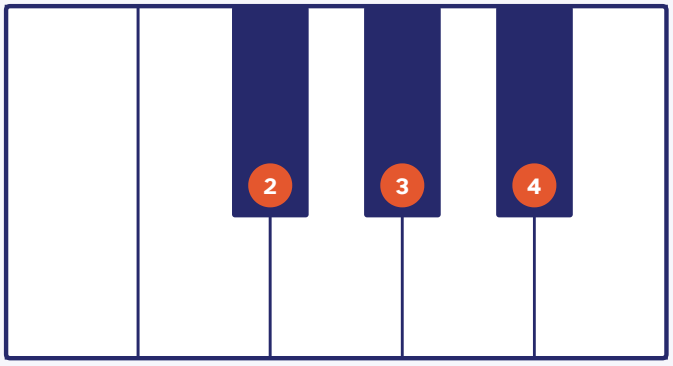
2 **Find its first key:** C or F (the red dots).

3 **Walk on** to each numbered key and name it.

1 is **B**, the last of F G A B · 2 is **E**, the last of C D E · 3 is **G**, one key after F. Find the group, find its first key, walk on: no counting from far away.

YOU KNOW THIS

Hot Cross Buns, on three black keys



Right hand, fingers **2 3 4** on the three black keys (thumb is 1, little finger 5). Play from the top: **4 3 2**, 4 3 2, then quickly, twice as fast, **2 2 2 2, 3 3 3 3**, and 4 3 2 to finish. A whole tune, and not one white key.

Try it. Find another group of three, higher up, and play it again there.

THINK OF IT The black keys are bumps you can feel in the dark. Close your eyes and slide your hand along: two bumps, and the key to their left is C; three bumps, and the key to their left is F.

TRAP

- × Counting every key from C: find the nearest group and start from its C or F.
- × Mixing up the families: C is left of the **two** black keys, F left of the **three**.

SEE ALSO

The staff and the clefs p. 27 · The staff and the keyboard p. 29

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 1–2 · Online: Keyboard Patterns · The Musical Alphabet

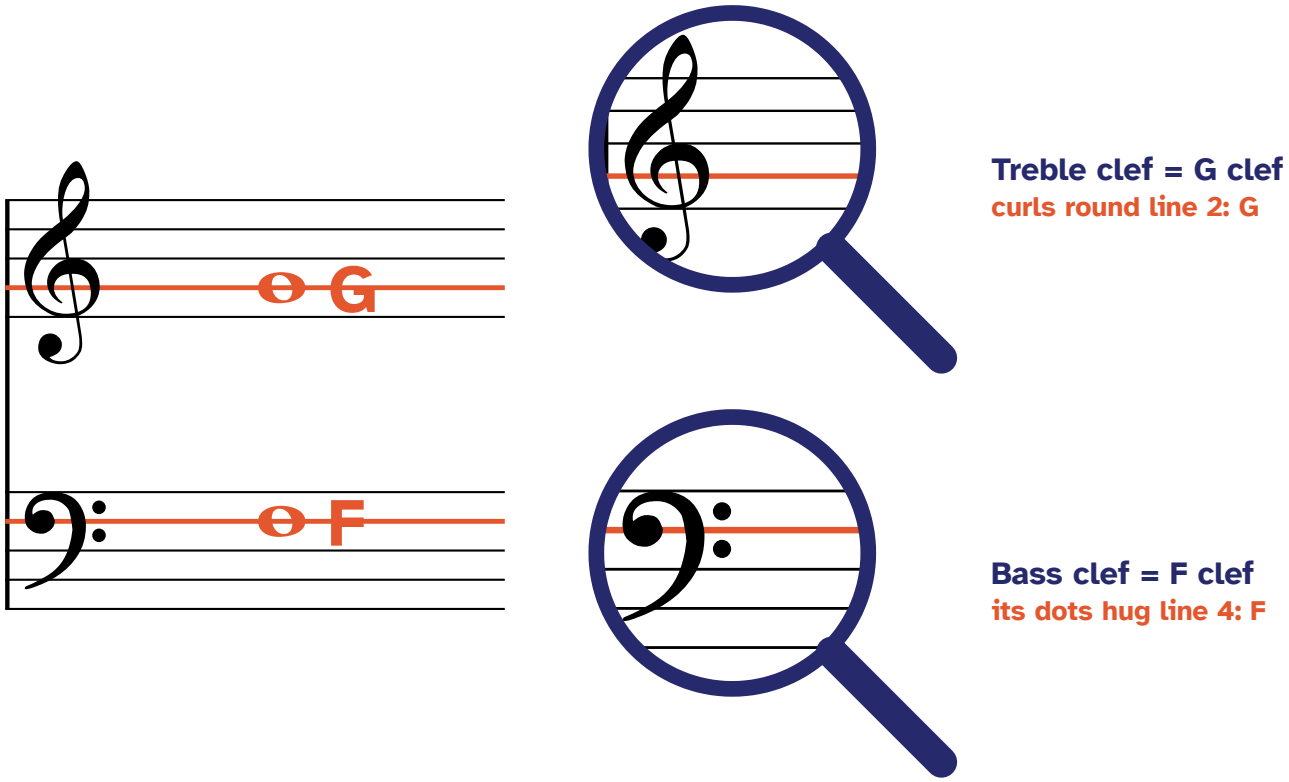
PART I · PITCH · 2

The staff and the clefs

Music is written on a **staff**: five lines and four spaces, counted from the **bottom**. Higher on the staff means higher on the keyboard. The **clef** at the start is the key to the code: it names one line, and every other note follows from it.

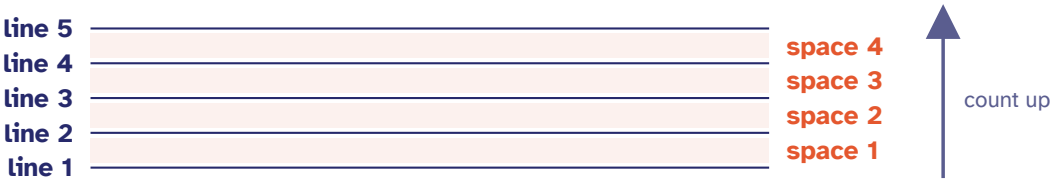
THE SECRET

The treble clef curls round G; the bass clef's two dots hug F.



The treble clef is the G clef: it curls round G · the bass clef is the F clef: its dots hug F

Five lines, four spaces

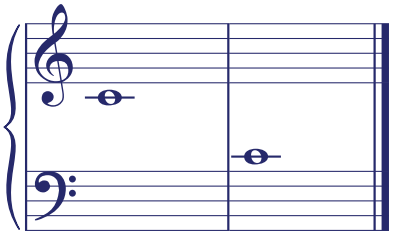


Always count from the **bottom**: line 1 is the lowest line, space 1 the lowest space.

PART I · PITCH · 2 · CONTINUED

The grand staff

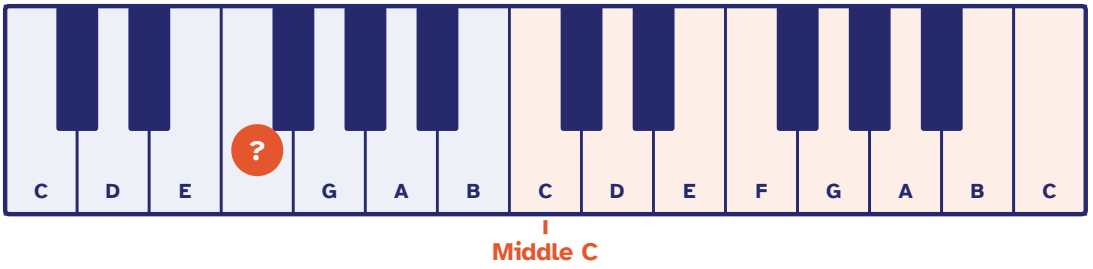
Two staves joined by a brace: the **treble** staff on top, usually for the right hand, and the **bass** staff below, usually for the left. **Middle C** sits between them on its own short line, in either staff.



Middle C in the treble staff (left) and in the bass staff (right): the same key.

EXAMPLE

Which staff is this key written on?
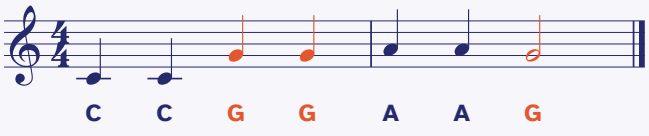


1. **Find Middle C.**
2. **Is the ? to its left or right?** Left is lower: the blue half.
3. **Low keys go on the bass staff**, high keys on the treble staff.

The **?** is below Middle C, so it is written on the **bass staff**, usually for the left hand.

YOU KNOW THIS

Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star



The treble clef curls round **line 2: G**, the very note Twinkle leaps up to. Read the round head, not the stem: the stem never changes the note.

Try it. Point to the G line, then play C C G G A A G.

THINK OF IT A clef is a pair of glasses: the same lines, read through a different pair.

TRAP

× Reading bass-clef notes as if they were treble: check the clef on every line.

SEE ALSO
The staff and the keyboard p. 29 · Reading the notes p. 32

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 3–4 · Online: The Staff & the Two Clefs

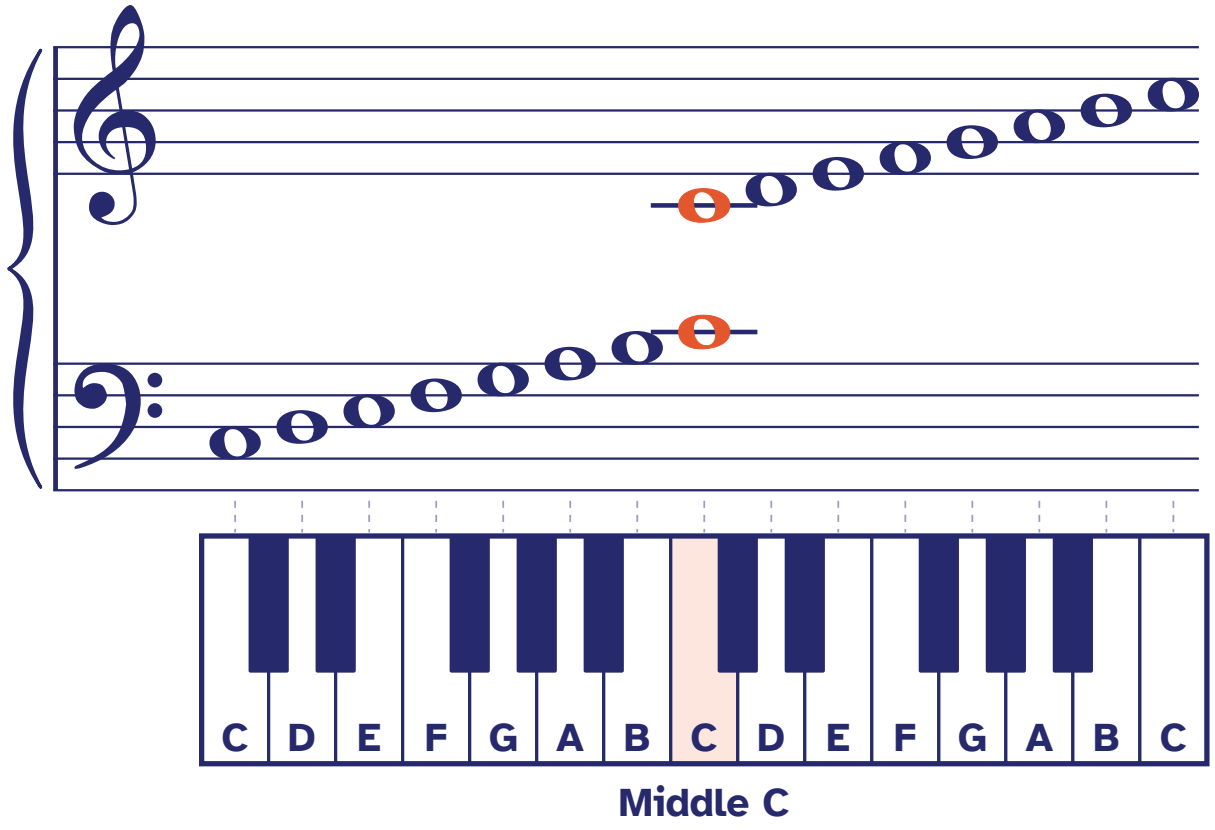
PART I · PITCH · 3

The staff and the keyboard

Each line and each space of the grand staff is one white key. Climb the staff and you climb the keyboard: here are two octaves, from Bass C to Treble C, with Middle C in red where the two staves meet.

THE SECRET

Every line and every space is one white key, in order.



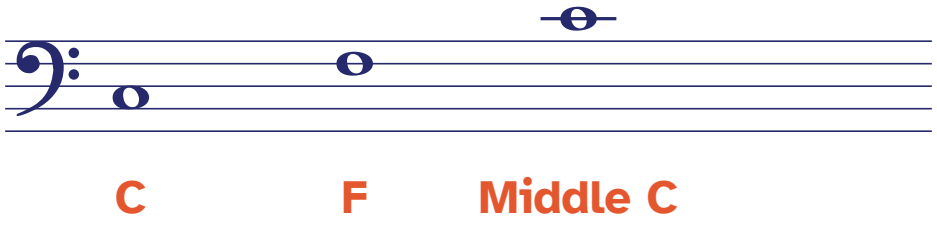
Between the two staves there is only one key: **Middle C**, written twice, below the treble staff or above the bass staff. No other key is missed out.

One step on the staff, line to space or space to line, is the very next **white** key (the black keys come in chapter 6, p. 39). Up the staff is to the **right** on the keyboard; down the staff is to the **left**. A note on a line and the note in the space just above it are next-door white keys, so no key is ever missed out.

PART I · PITCH · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

From the page to the key

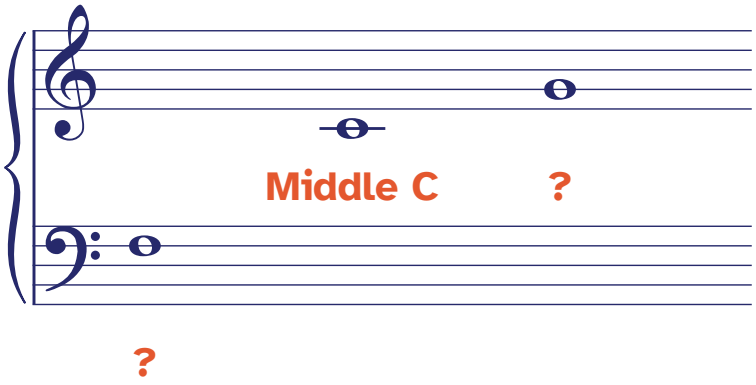


1. **Name the note:** line 4 of the bass staff, between the clef's dots, is F.
2. **On the piano,** find the three black keys just below Middle C.
3. **F is the first key** of that family: play it with the left hand.

The bass-clef F is the **F just below Middle C**: left of the three black keys under it.

EXAMPLE 2

Mirror notes either side of Middle C



1. **Treble G:** the three black keys just above Middle C; G is the second key, after F.
2. **Bass F:** the three black keys just below Middle C; F is the first key.
3. **Now count each from Middle C:** C D E F G up, C B A G F down. Which number?

Both are **note 5**: mirror images. Fold the grand staff at Middle C and treble G lands exactly on bass F; the staves meet line for line.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



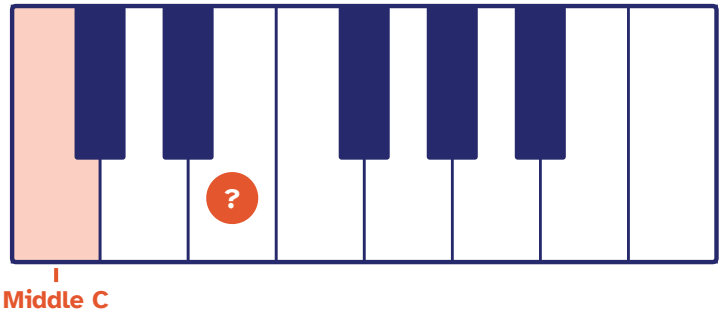
Play Middle C, then walk up.

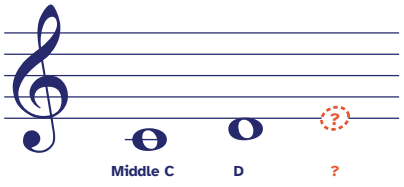
Say each white key as you play it, C D E F G A B C, and picture each one climbing the staff: line, space, line, space.

PART I · PITCH · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

From the key to the page



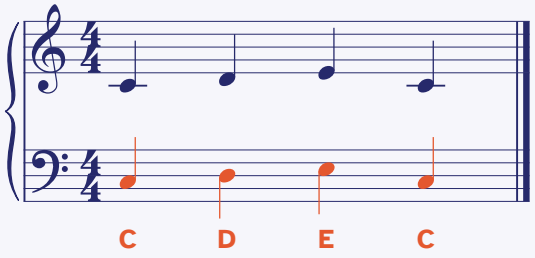


1. **Find the ? key:** count up from Middle C, C 1, D 2 …
2. **Do the same on the staff:** Middle C on its ledger line, D in the space under the staff …
3. **Where do you land?**

The **?** is **E**, note 3, and it sits on the **bottom line** of the treble staff.

YOU KNOW THIS

Frère Jacques, in both hands



The left hand plays the **same letters**, C D E C, one octave lower, written in the bass clef.

Try it. Play it right hand, then left hand, then both together.

THINK OF IT The staff is a ladder laid beside the keyboard: each rung, a line or a space, is the next white key.

TRAP

- × Skipping a key: every line and every space is used, one white key each.
- × Counting from 0: the note you start on is note 1.

SEE ALSO

The staff and the clefs p. 27 · Reading the notes p. 32

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 5–6 · Online: The Staff & the Two Clefs · Line and Space Names

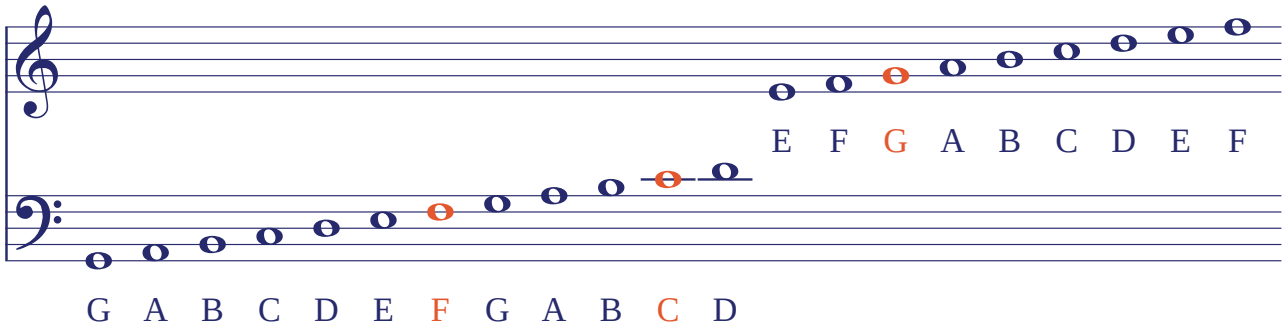
PART I · PITCH · 4

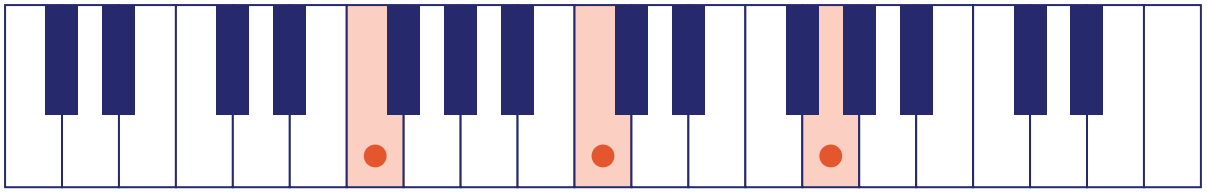
Reading the notes

Every line and space has one letter. You do not have to learn them all at once: start from a note you always know, then **step** or **skip** to the one you want.

THE SECRET

Start from a note you know (bass F, Middle C, treble G), then step or skip.

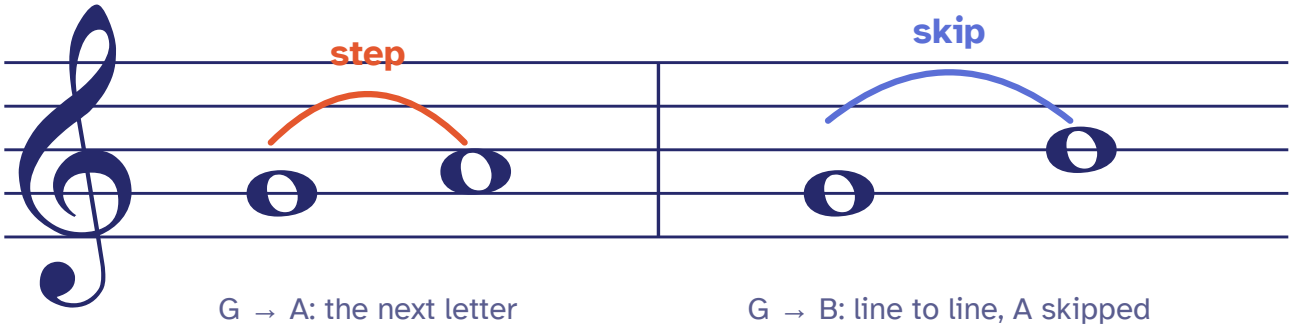




Middle C in the middle; treble G and bass F, the clef notes, either side. Every line and space is the next letter, with its own key underneath (the keyboard starts on G, so its first black keys belong to a group of three).

THE RULE

Step: to the very next line or space (one letter on). Skip: line to the next line, or space to the next space (two letters on).



G → A: the next letter

G → B: line to line, A skipped

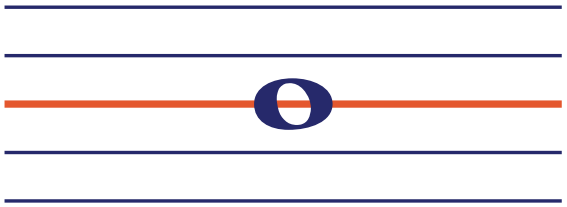
PART I · PITCH · 4 · CONTINUED

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Read the shape, not just the notes

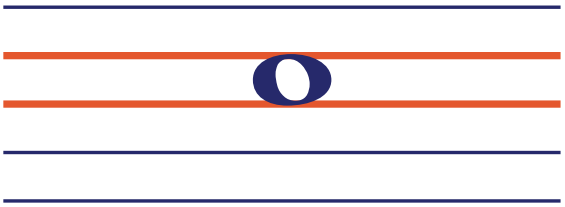
Good readers see the jumps before the letters. Notes that touch, line then space, are a **step**: the next letter. Notes with one line between them, line to line or space to space, are a **skip**: one letter missed out. Name the first note, then let the shape name the rest: up a step, up a skip, down a step.

Line note or space note?



line note

a line runs through its middle

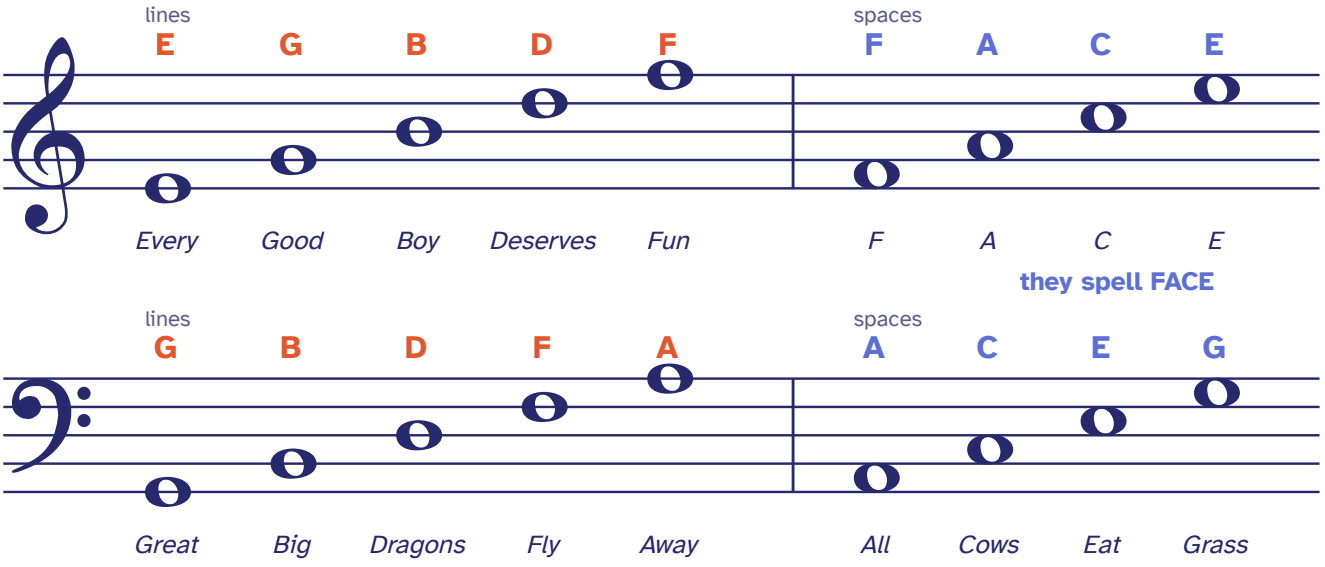


space note

sits between two lines, touching both

Count both from the bottom: line 1 is the bottom line, space 1 the bottom space.

Words to remember the lines and spaces



PART I · PITCH · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Read a line note with its sentence



1. **Treble lines:** *Every Good Boy Deserves Fun*. The red note on line 4 is the fourth word.
2. **Bass lines:** *Great Big Dragons Fly Away*. The red note on line 3 is the third word.
3. **Check each** from its clef note: treble G, bass F.

Treble line 4: **D** (Deserves). Bass line 3: **D** (Dragons). Same letter, different keys: the clef decides.

EXAMPLE 2

One line, two notes

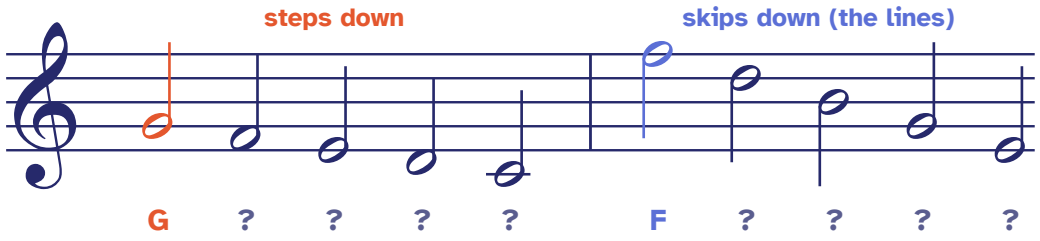


1. **Look at the red notes:** both sit on the bottom line.
2. **Now look at the clefs:** treble on the left, bass on the right.
3. **Use each clef's sentence:** the first word of the treble lines, *Every...*; the first word of the bass lines, *Great...*.

Treble bottom line: **E** (*Every*). Bass bottom line: **G** (*Great*). Same line, different note: always read the **clef** first.

EXAMPLE 3

Read it downwards



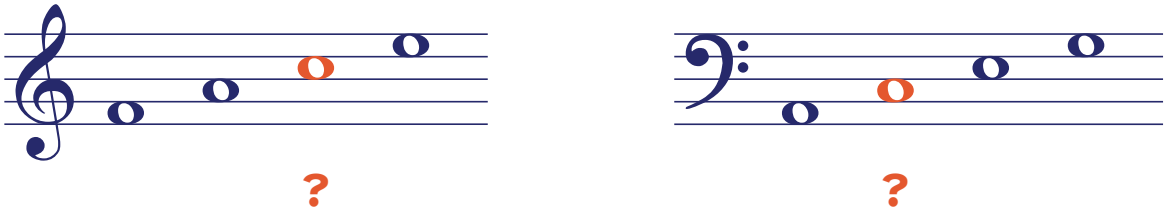
1. **Start on G**, the clef note: line 2.
2. **Each step down** is the letter before: say the alphabet backwards.
3. **Skips down** go back two letters. Start on F, the top line.

Steps: G **F E D C**, down to Middle C. Skips: F **D B G E**, the lines backwards.

PART I · PITCH · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 4

Find Treble C and Bass C
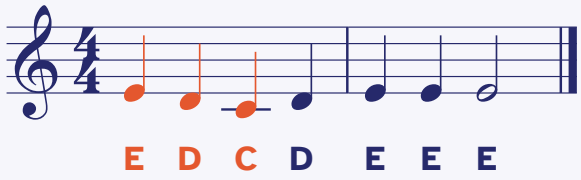


1. **Treble spaces** spell *FACE*: space 3 is the third letter.
2. **Bass spaces:** *All Cows Eat Grass*: space 2 is the second word.
3. **Play both:** one octave either side of Middle C.

Treble space 3: **C**, Treble C. Bass space 2: **C**, Bass C. Mirror images, an octave above and below Middle C.

YOU KNOW THIS

Mary Had a Little Lamb



E D C: **line, space, Middle C's own little line**, one step down each time. Read the shape and the tune walks down with it.

Try it. Read the notes aloud before you play them.

THINK OF IT The clef notes are lamp posts on a dark road: walk from the nearest one and you are never lost.

TRAP

- × Naming bass notes with treble names: in the bass, the bottom line is G, not E.
- × Mixing up step and skip: a step changes line to space; a skip stays on lines (or on spaces).
- × Mistaking a space note for a line note: a line runs through a line note; a space note sits between two lines.
- × Counting lines from the top: line 1 is always the bottom line.

SEE ALSO

The staff and the keyboard p. 29 · Ledger lines p. 36

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 7–8 · Online: Line and Space Names · Steps & Skips

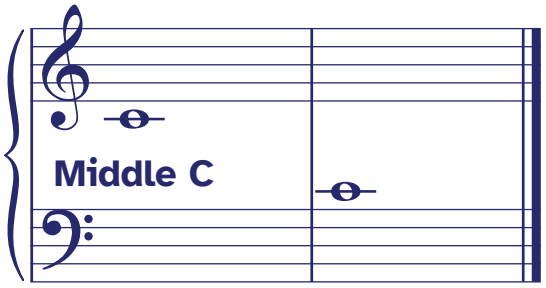
PART I · PITCH · 5

Ledger lines

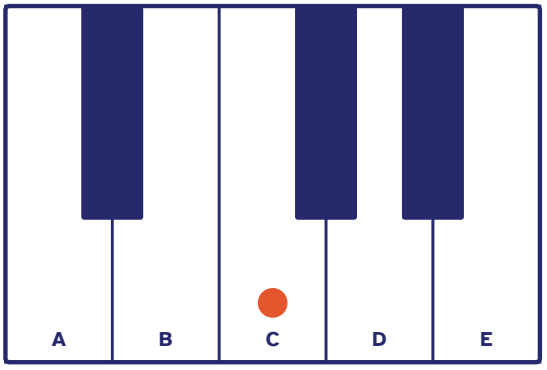
Some notes are too high or too low for the five lines of the staff, so the staff borrows a few short **ledger lines**, spaced just like its own.

THE SECRET

Step out from the nearest staff line: line, space, line. The first ledger line is the one nearest the staff.

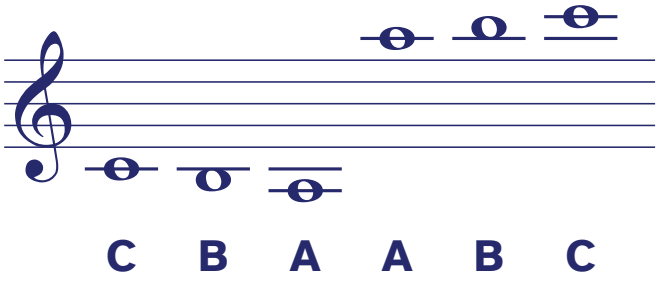


Middle C



Middle C sits on a ledger line of its own: below the treble staff, or above the bass staff. One key, two ways to write it.

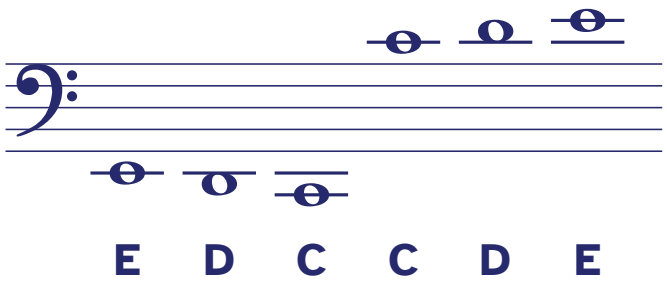
Below and above the staff



Treble: C, B, A below; A, B, C above.

Count ledger lines from the staff outwards: the first ledger line is the one nearest the staff. Step out line, space, line, and never skip one.

PART I · PITCH · 5 · CONTINUED



Bass: E, D, C below; C, D, E above.

EXAMPLE 1

Read a high note on ledger lines



1. **The top line** of the treble staff is F.
2. **Step up** one note at a time: G sits on top of the staff, A on the first ledger line.
3. **Keep stepping** to the red note: B above it, then the second ledger line.

Two ledger lines above the treble staff: **High C**, two octaves above Middle C.

EXAMPLE 2

Read a low note on ledger lines



1. **The bottom line** of the bass staff is G.
2. **Step down** one note at a time: F in the space below, E on the first ledger line.
3. **Keep stepping** to the red note: D below it, then the second ledger line.

Two ledger lines below the bass staff: **Low C**, two octaves below Middle C. Its mirror is High C, two ledger lines above the treble.

PART I · PITCH · 5 · CONTINUED

The four first ledger lines



Middle C
treble, below

Middle C
bass, above

A
treble, above
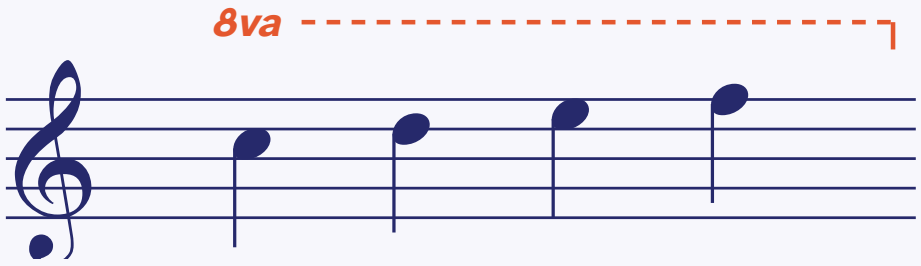
E
bass, below

Only Middle C belongs to both staves.

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Too many ledger lines? 8va

Very high notes need lots of ledger lines, and lots of ledger lines are hard to read. So a high passage is often written lower, with **8va** and a dotted line above it: play those notes **one octave higher** (eight notes up, from a C to the next C, p. 25) until the dotted line stops. **8vb** under the notes means an octave lower. (On its own, 8ve is just short for octave.)



play these
one octave higher
until the line stops

THINK OF IT Ledger lines are the staff's ladder carried on past its ends: the same rungs, just shorter. Climb them one rung at a time, from the staff outwards, and you can read any note however high or low.

TRAP

- × Reading ledger lines from the wrong end: step out from the staff.
- × Counting from the outside in: the first ledger line is the one nearest the staff.

SEE ALSO
Reading the notes p. 32 · Sharps, flats and naturals p. 39

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 9–10 · Online: Ledger Lines

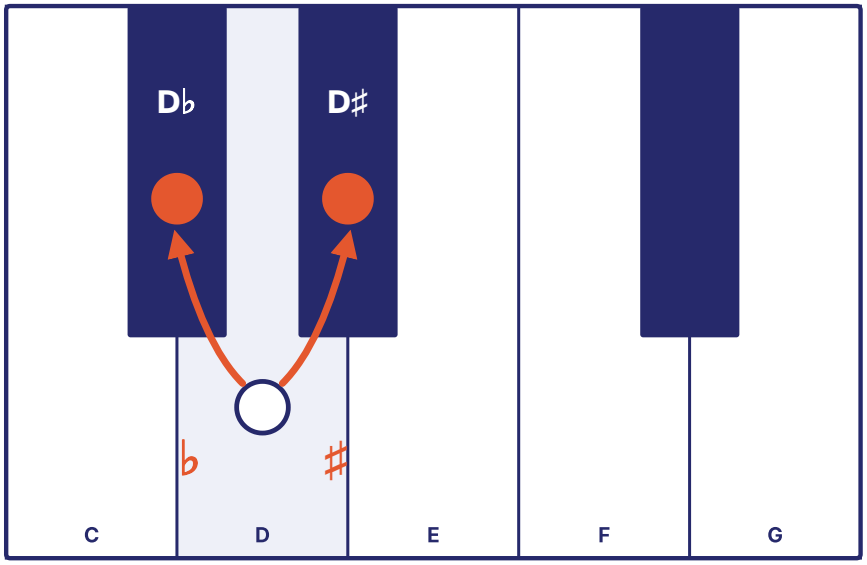
PART I · PITCH · 6

Sharps, flats and naturals

The black keys have no letters of their own. They borrow the names of their white neighbours, adding a sharp or a flat. These signs, and the natural that cancels them, are called **accidentals**.

THE SECRET

Sharp: the very next key to the right. Flat: the very next key to the left.

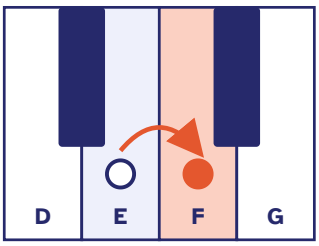


♯ one key right · ♭ one key left

SIGN	NAME	WHAT IT DOES	FIRST MET
♯	sharp	one key to the right (a semitone higher)	Beginner
♭	flat	one key to the left (a semitone lower)	Beginner
♮	natural	cancels a sharp or flat: back to the white key	Prelim

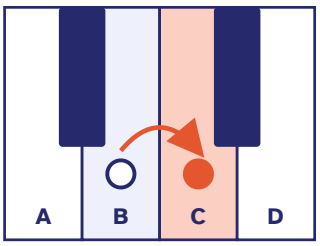
A **semitone** is the smallest step on the piano: from one key to the very next, black or white (American books call it a *half step*). More on p. 42. With no black key between (E–F, B–C), the next key is white: E♯ = F and B♯ = C; F♭ = E and C♭ = B. And every black key has two names: C♯ = D♭.

E♯ = F



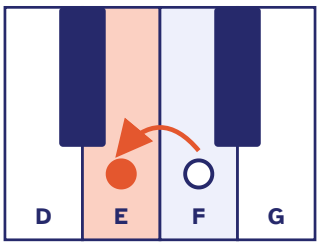
♯ right, no black key between

B♯ = C



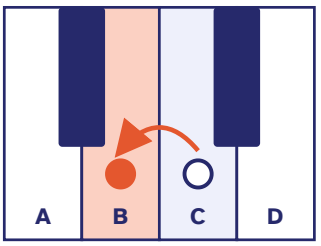
♯ right, no black key between

F♭ = E



♭ left, no black key between

C♭ = B

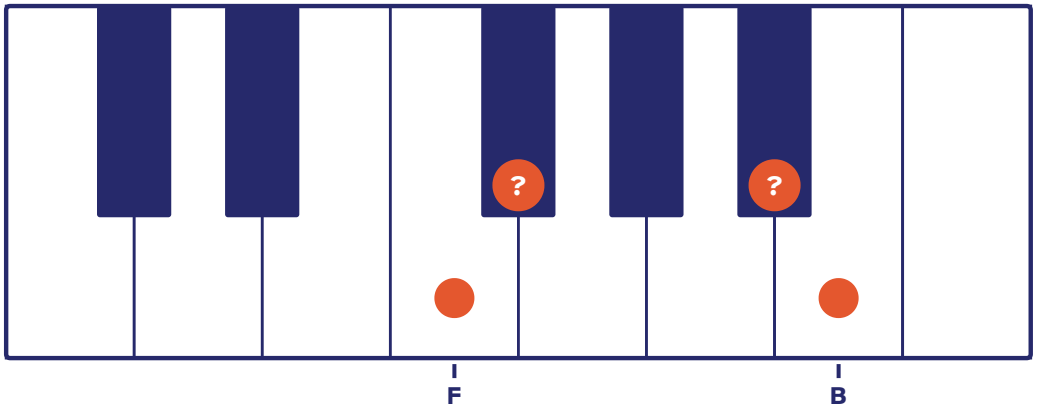


♭ left, no black key between

PART I · PITCH · 6 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Find F♯ and B♭



1. **Find F and B** (the red dots): F just left of the three black keys, B just right of them.
2. **Sharp means right:** F♯ is the very next key to the right of F.
3. **Flat means left:** B♭ is the very next key to the left of B. Black or white?

The left **?** is **F♯**, the first black key of the three; the right **?** is **B♭**, the highest one, on the right.
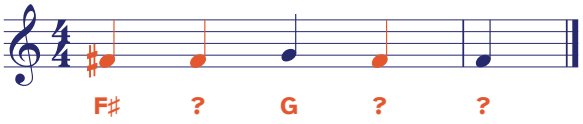
THE RULE

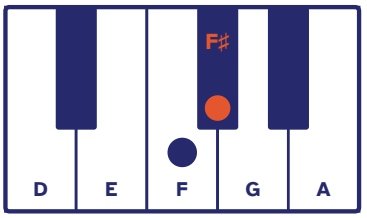
A sign belongs to one line or space. It changes only that line or space, in that octave, and only until the bar line. The same letter in another octave, and every other note, stays as it is.

A **bar** is the space between two **bar lines** (p. 50). A **key signature** at the start of every line is different: it lasts the whole piece (p. 99). And a natural cancels a sharp just as it cancels a flat.

EXAMPLE 2

How long does the sharp last?





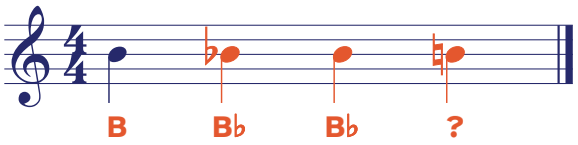
1. **The first note** has a sharp: F♯.
2. **Later in the same bar** there is no sign. Is it still sharp?
3. **After the bar line**: is it still sharp?

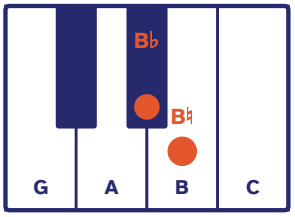
Still **F♯** until the bar line; after it, plain **F** again. A sign lasts **to the end of its bar**.

PART I · PITCH · 6 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

A natural cancels the flat
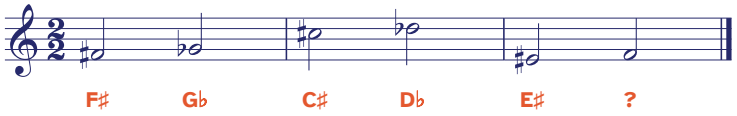




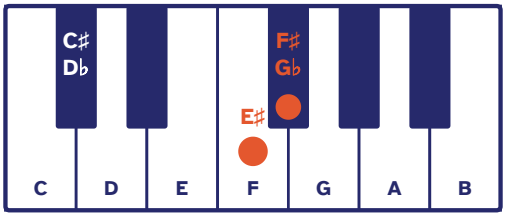
1. **B**: the white key.
2. **B♭**: one key left, and it stays flat for the rest of the bar.
3. **The last note** has a natural sign: what does it do?

The natural **cancels** the flat: back to the white key B, until the bar line.

EXAMPLE 4

One key, two names
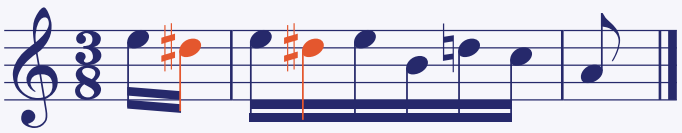




1. **The first bar:** F♯, then G♭. Find both on the keyboard.
2. **Are they different keys?**
3. **The last bar:** E♯. Which key is one right of E?

F♯ and G♭ are the **same black key**; E♯ is the white key **F**, so the **?** is plain F, the same key as E♯. Same sound, different names: **enharmonic**. The same trick with no black key between: **B♯** is the white key C, **F♭** is the white key E.

YOU KNOW THIS

Für Elise (Beethoven)



E, **D♯**, E, **D♯**: the next key down and back. The bar line wipes the sharp out, so it is written again; later the D needs a **natural**, or it would still be D♯.

Try it. Play E and D♯ back and forth: the black key just left of E.

THINK OF IT A sharp or flat is a sticky note on one line of the staff: it stays stuck until the bar line, then it falls off.

TRAP

× Carrying a sharp or flat past the bar line: after it, the note is plain again.

SEE ALSO

Keys and key signatures p. 99

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 11–12 · Online: Accidentals · Tones & Semitones

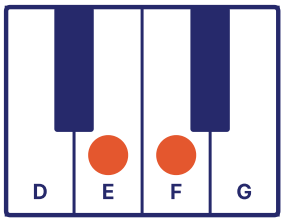
PART I · PITCH · 7

Counting intervals

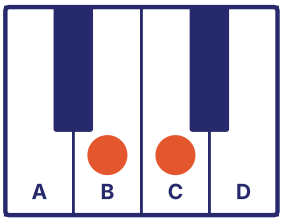
Music moves in distances: a tiny step, a bigger step, a leap. Any distance between two notes is an **interval**. The smallest is the **semitone**, and bigger ones each get a number.

THE SECRET

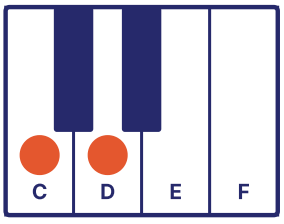
The very next key is a semitone; two make a tone. For an interval, count the notes, both ends included.



E–F
nothing between: a semitone



B–C
nothing between: a semitone



C–D
C♯ between: a tone

Best friends: nobody between

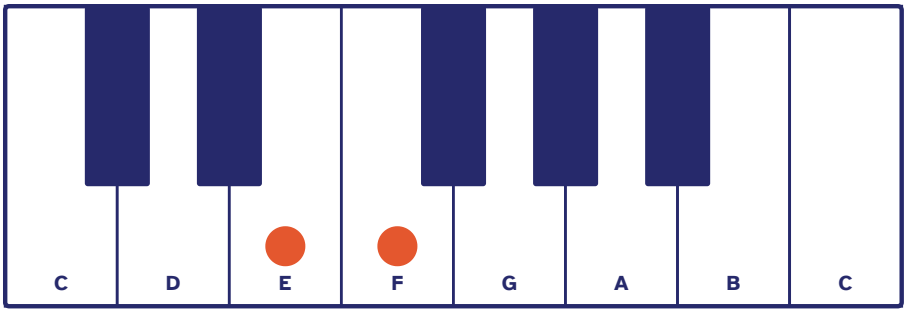
Think of your best friend sitting right next to you, with nobody in between: that is a **semitone**. On the white keys two pairs are already best friends, with **no black key between**: **E–F** and **B–C**. Everywhere else a black key sits between two white keys: one key between, a **tone**.

THE RULE

Semitone: the very next key, with nothing between: white to white (E–F, B–C), white to black, or black to white. Tone: exactly one key between.

EXAMPLE 1

Tone or semitone?

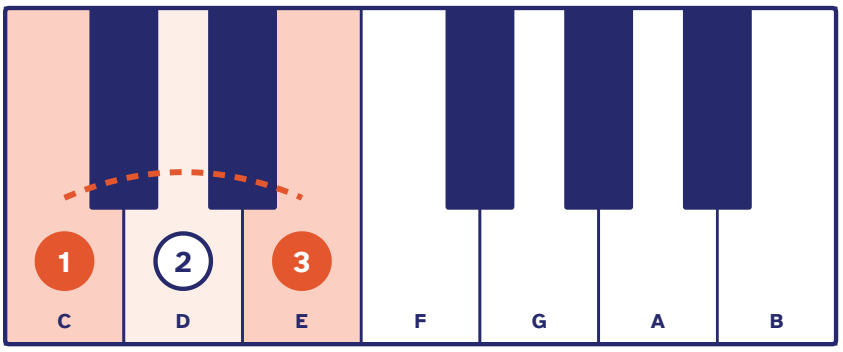


1. **Look between the red keys:** is there a black key?
2. **No black key** means they are next-door keys.
3. **Now try C and D**: is there a black key between?

E–F is a **semitone** (next door). C–D has C♯ between: a **tone**.

PART I · PITCH · 7 · CONTINUED

Intervals: count the notes

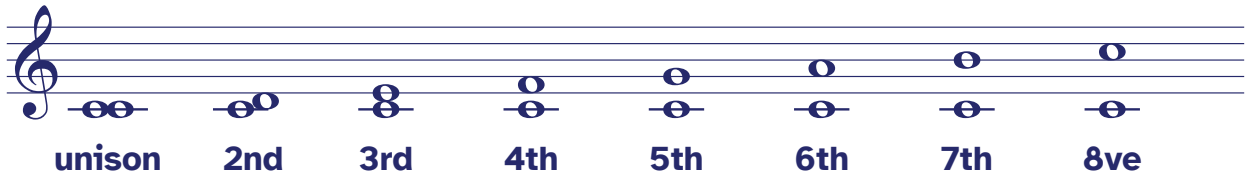


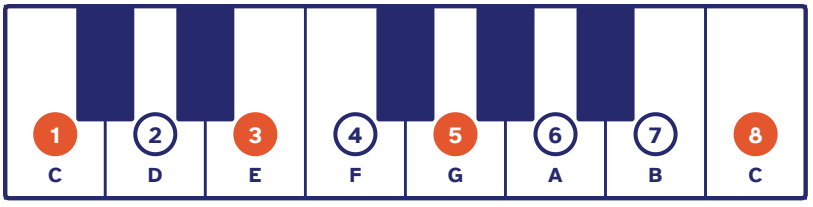
C to E: count the notes, 1 2 3: a 3rd

THE RULE

Count the letters for the number: start at 1 on the first note and count white keys, or lines and spaces, never the black keys. C to E is C D E: 3 notes, a 3rd. Sharps and flats never change the number.

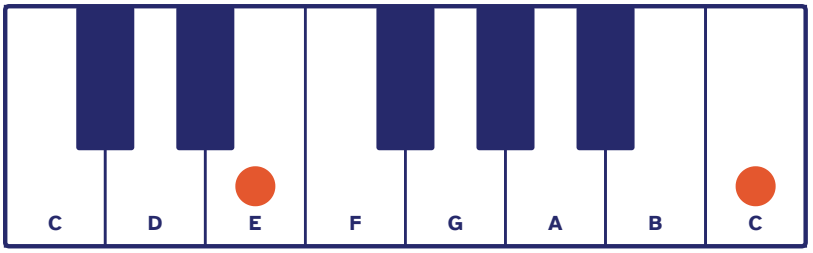
Interval numbers from C





EXAMPLE 2

Name an interval on the keyboard



1 **Find both red keys:** E, and the C above it.

2 **Count the notes** from E: E is 1 ...

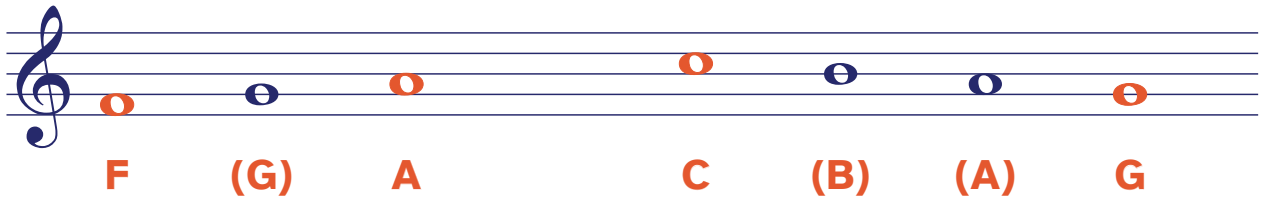
3 **Stop on the C.** What number is it?

E F G A B C is 6 notes: a **6th**.

PART I · PITCH · 7 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

How far apart are these notes?

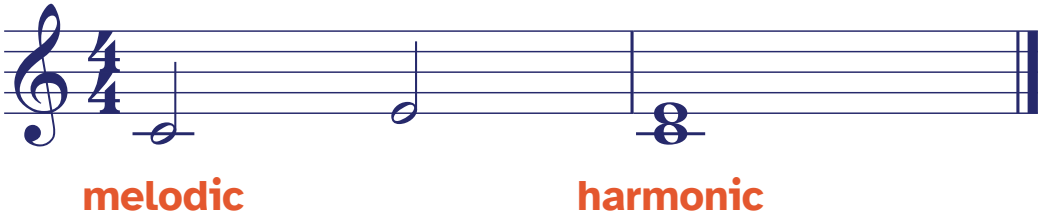


1. **Call the first note 1:** here F is 1.
2. **Count every letter** up to the second note.
3. **Going down works the same:** start at 1 on the top note and count down.

F G A is 3 notes: a **3rd**. C B A G is 4 notes: a **4th**.

EXAMPLE 4

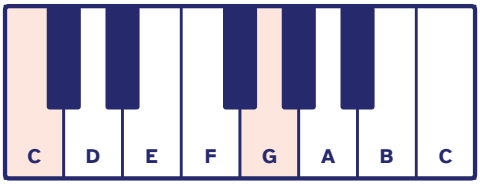
Melodic or harmonic?



1. **The first bar:** C, then E, one after the other.
2. **The second bar:** C and E at the same time.
3. **Count the notes** in each.

Both are a **3rd**: **melodic** when played one after the other, **harmonic** when played together.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Thumb on C, finger 5 on G.

Your hand is a ruler: thumb to little finger on white keys is a 5th. Play it, then thumb to finger 3: a 3rd.

TRAP

× Counting only the gaps: C to E is 3 notes, not 2 gaps. And a sharp or flat never changes the number: C to G♯ is still a 5th.

SEE ALSO
Major, minor and perfect p. 45 · Major scales p. 93

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 13–14 · Online: Intervals · Tones & Semitones

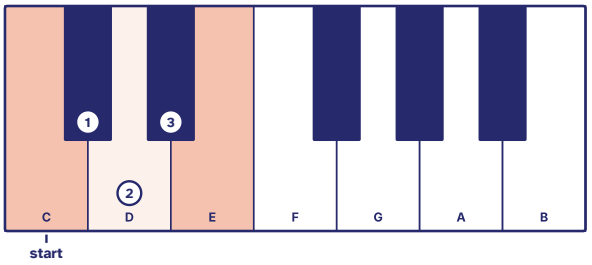
PART I · PITCH · 8

Major, minor and perfect

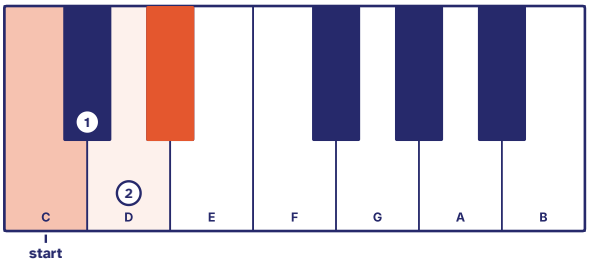
C to E and C to E♭ are both 3rds: three notes each. But they sound different, bright and dark. To tell them apart, **count the keys in between**, black and white: the keys you do not play.

THE SECRET

3 keys between: a major 3rd. 2 keys between: a minor 3rd.



C to **E**: 3 keys between. A **major** 3rd: bright.



C to **E♭**: 2 keys between, one fewer. A **minor** 3rd: dark.

One key fewer between: a major 3rd becomes minor

THE RULE

Count the notes for the number (a 3rd). Count the keys in between for the size (major or minor): black and white, not the two you play.

Why count the keys in between? Because the size is what you hear: one key more or less turns bright into dark, or makes a 5th sound hollow and strange.

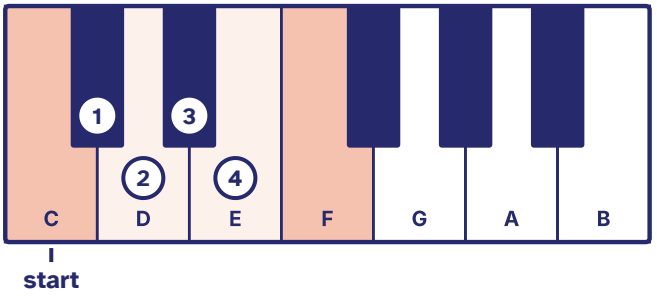
NUMBER	KEYS BETWEEN: MINOR	MAJOR OR PERFECT
3rd	2 (minor)	3 (major)
4th		4 (perfect)
5th		6 (perfect)
6th	7 (minor)	8 (major)
octave		11 (perfect)

3rds and 6ths come in two sizes: **major** and **minor**.

4ths, 5ths and octaves have one main size, called **perfect**. They are never major or minor.

PART I · PITCH · 8 · CONTINUED

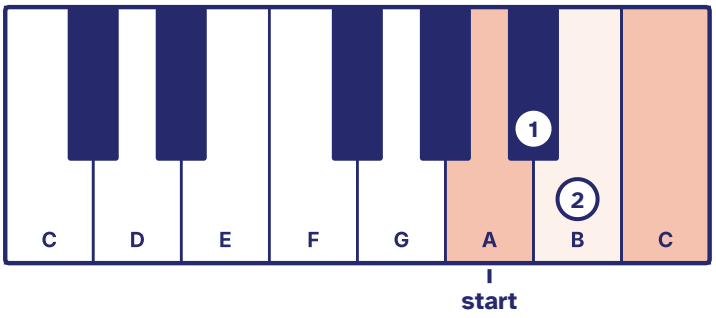
A perfect 4th



C to **F**: four notes, a 4th, with **4 keys between**: a **perfect 4th**.

EXAMPLE 1

Major or minor 3rd? A up to C

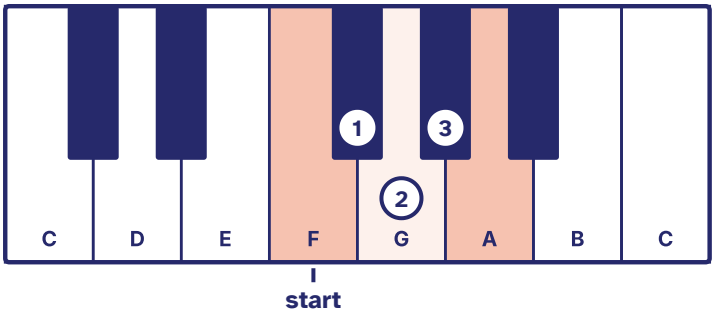


1. **Count the notes:** A B C, three letters, so it is a 3rd.
2. **Count the keys in between:** they are numbered.
3. **A major 3rd has 3 between.** How many here?

A to C has **2 keys between** (B♭ and B): one fewer than major, a **minor 3rd**. Dark, like C to E♭.

EXAMPLE 2

Name F up to A



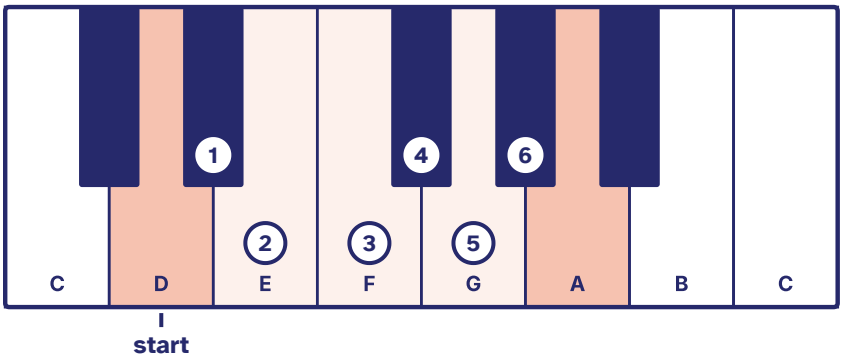
1. **Count the notes:** F G A is 3, so it is a 3rd.
2. **Count the keys in between:** they are numbered.
3. **3 between, or 2?**

F to A has 3 keys between: a **major 3rd**, the same size as C to E.

PART I · PITCH · 8 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

Name D up to A
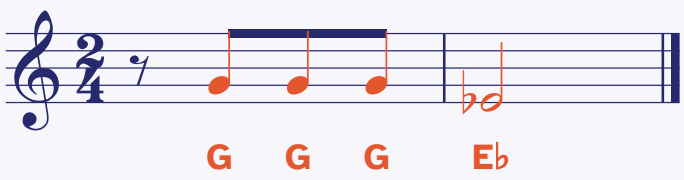


1. **The number:** D E F G A, five notes, a 5th.
2. **The size:** count the keys in between: the numbered keys.
3. **A 5th with 6 between** is its main size. What is that called?

D up to A is a **perfect 5th**: 6 keys between.

YOU KNOW THIS

Beethoven, Symphony No. 5



Da-da-da-DUM: G down to E♭ is three notes, a 3rd, with 3 keys between (F♯, F, E): a **major 3rd**. Counting down works the same way.

Try it. Count the keys between G and E♭ on the keyboard.

THINK OF IT A major and a minor 3rd are a smile and a frown: the same face, one small change at the corners.

TRAP

- × Counting white keys only: count every key between, black and white.
- × Calling a 4th or 5th “major”: they are perfect.
- × C–D♯ is a 2nd, C–E♭ a 3rd: the same keys, but the letters decide the number.

SEE ALSO
Counting intervals p. 42 · Chords and triads p. 110

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 15–16 · Online: Intervals (Major or minor 3rd)

PART I · PITCH · TIPS

When a note reads wrong

Most wrong notes come from a handful of slips. Name the slip first, then fix only that note: playing the whole line again rarely finds it.

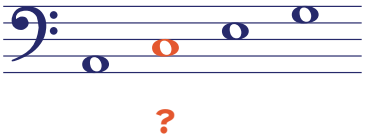
TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
The left hand reads like the right	**the clef**: bass lines are G B D F A, not E G B D F	p. 32
You land an octave too high or too low	**the Cs**: find Middle C first, then walk out to Bass C or Treble C	p. 25
Notes above or below the staff slow you down	**the ledger lines**: step on from the nearest staff line	p. 36
A sharp or flat vanishes, or stays too long	**the bar line**: a sign lasts only to the end of its bar	p. 40
You play the black key on the wrong side	**the direction**: sharp goes right, flat goes left	p. 39
Two notes sound too close or too far apart	**the interval**: count the notes, then the keys between	p. 45

EXAMPLE

Spot the slip



?

Sam played A. Wrong!

1. **Check the clef first:** this is the bass clef, not the treble.
2. **Use the bass sentence:** the spaces are *All Cows Eat Grass*.
3. **The red note is in space 2:** the second word.

The note is **C** (*Cows*): Bass C. Sam read the bass staff with treble names (treble space 2 is A): the most common slip of all.

HOW TO

Three checks before you read a new line

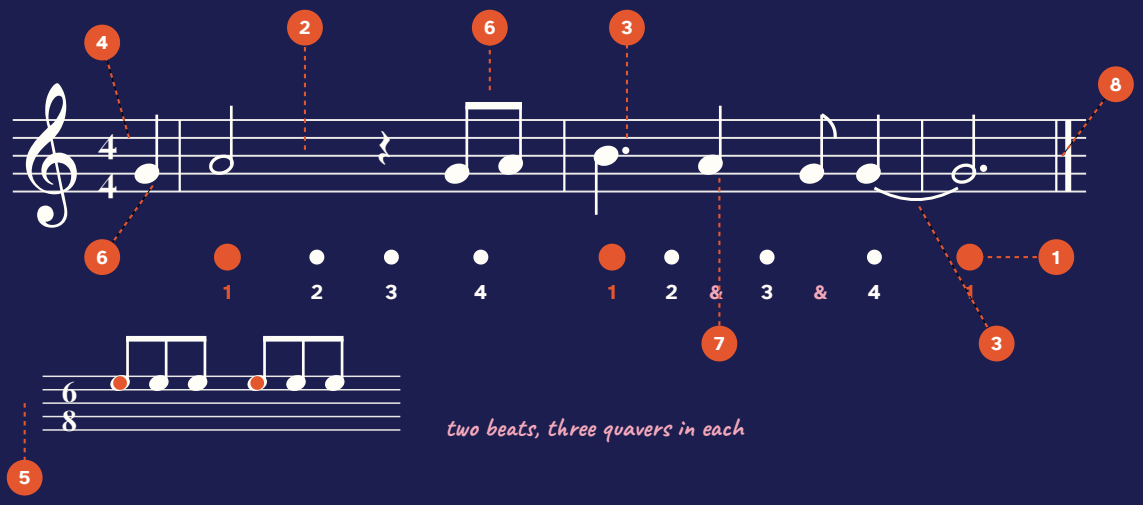
1. **The clefs:** which staff is treble, which is bass?
2. **The clef notes:** find treble G, bass F and Middle C, and read the other notes from them.
3. **The signs:** mark each sharp, flat or natural, and see where its bar ends.

THINK OF IT Like reading a map: find the big landmarks first, then the streets around them. A note far from every clef note is the one most often misread.

PART II · WHEN, AND FOR HOW LONG

Time

Music never stands still. Underneath runs a steady **pulse**, packed into **bars**, and every note and rest gets its fair share. Everything in this part is in these two bars.



1 **Pulse, tempo and the bar** p. 50
the steady beat underneath; beat 1 is strongest

2 **Notes and rests** p. 53
the shape says how long; rests are counted too

3 **How long is a note?** p. 56
a dot adds half; a tie glues two notes into one

4 **Time signatures** p. 59
four seats in every bar, a crotchet in each

5 **Compound and irregular time** p. 62
beats in threes; bars of five or seven

6 **Rhythm: groups and upbeats** p. 65
beams show the beats; starting before bar 1

7 **Rhythm: off the beat** p. 68
a note between the beats that holds on

8 **Repeats and road signs** p. 71
repeat signs, D.C., D.S., Fine and Coda

★ **Tips: when the rhythm slips** p. 74

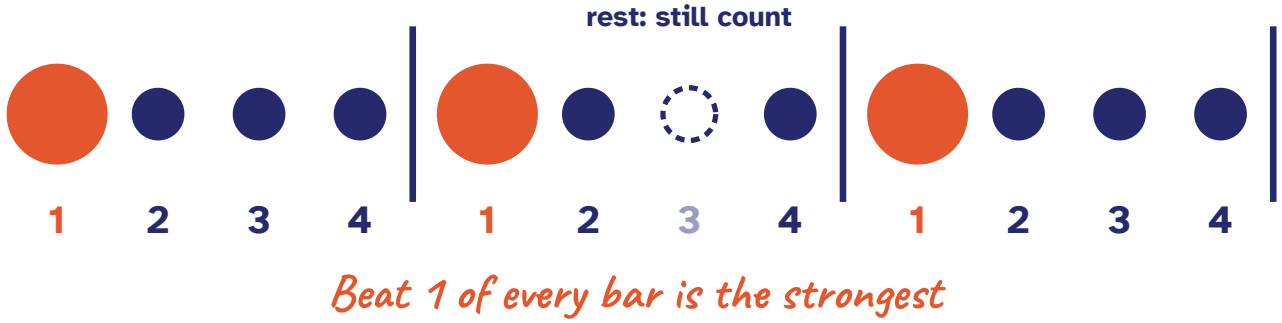
PART II · TIME · 1

Pulse, tempo and the bar

Put your hand on your heart: that steady beat is a **pulse**, and almost every piece has one. Its speed is the **tempo**. Beats travel in groups called **bars**, and beat 1 is the strongest.

THE SECRET

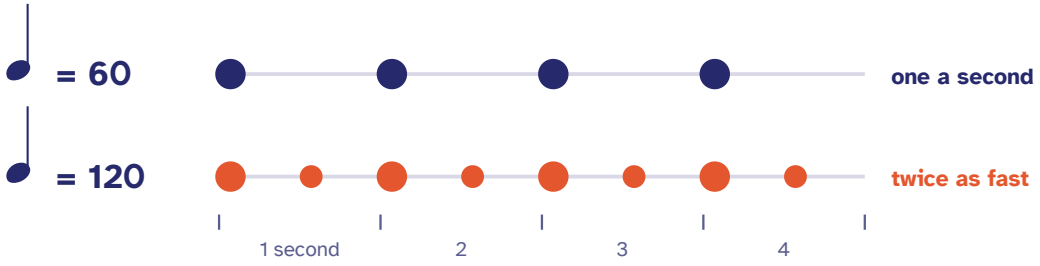
The beat never stops, not even in a rest. Feel it before you play.



Beat 1 of every bar is the strongest

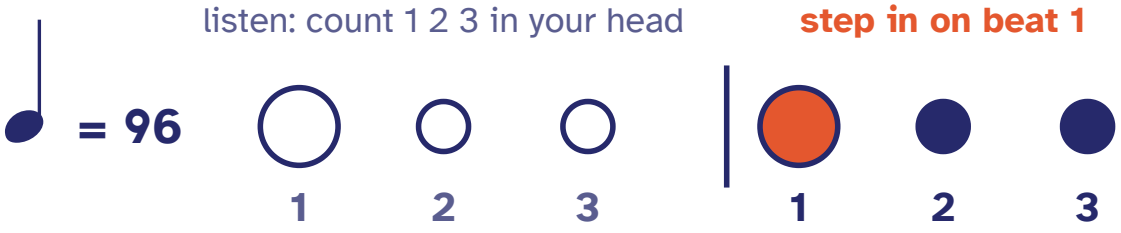
Tempo

Tempo is measured in beats per minute. A **metronome mark** at the top of the music shows it: ♩ **= 60** means 60 crotchet beats a minute, one beat a second. ♩ **= 120** is twice as fast. Speed words such as *Andante* and *Allegro* are on p. 82.



EXAMPLE 1

Feel the beat before you play

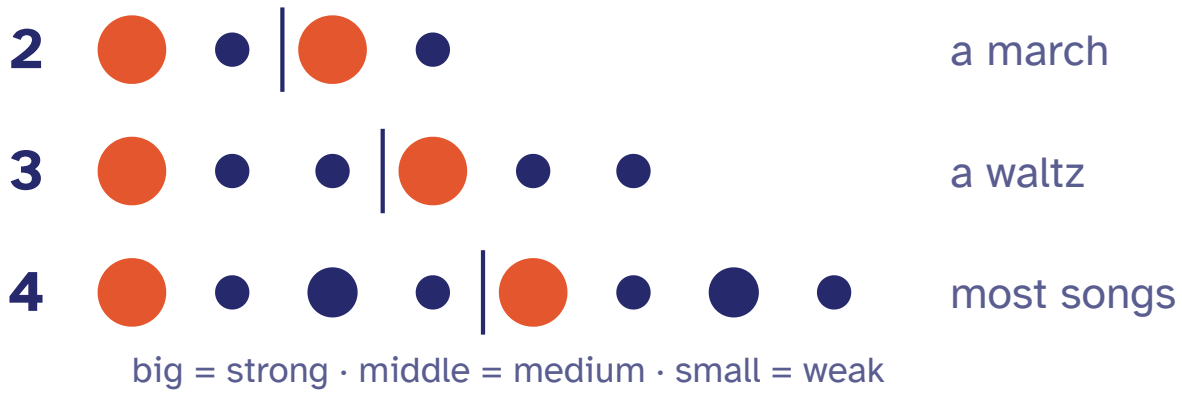


1. **Read the mark:** ♩ **= 96**, 96 crotchet beats a minute.
2. **Listen first:** set the metronome and let one full bar go by, counting "1 2 3" in your head.
3. **Step in** on the next beat 1, the way you step onto a moving escalator.

The first note lands **on the beat**, not a guess.

PART II · TIME · 1 · CONTINUED

Strong and weak beats



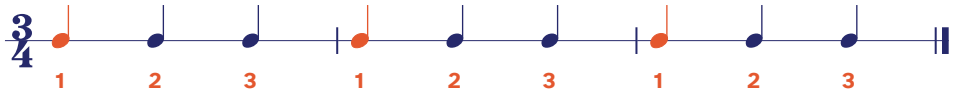
big = strong · middle = medium · small = weak

In tunes you know

TUNE	BEATS IN A BAR	PATTERN
Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star	4	**Strong** weak **medium** weak
Happy Birthday	3	**Strong** weak weak
The Blue Danube (a waltz)	3	**Strong** weak weak
Radetzky March	2	**Strong** weak

EXAMPLE 2

Is this a march or a waltz?



1. **Tap a steady beat** as you listen.
2. **Which beats feel heavier?** The red notes help.
3. **Count from one heavy beat to the next.** How many?

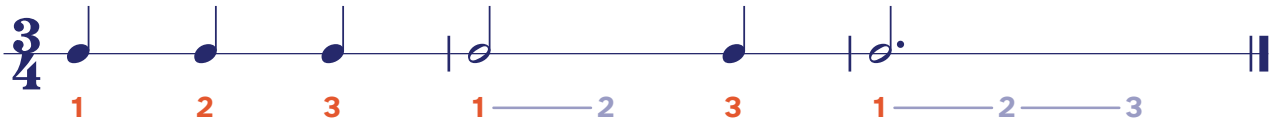
Heavy every three: 1 2 3, 1 2 3. A **waltz**. Every two would be a march.

Bars and bar lines

SIGN	NAME	MEANING
	bar line	divides the music into bars
	double bar line	marks the end of a section, or a change of time signature or tempo
	final bar line	marks the end of the piece
	repeat signs	play the passage between them again; if there is no start sign, go back to the beginning

PART II · TIME · 1 · CONTINUED

Counting



Three bars of 3/4 (the sign at the start: three beats in each bar, p. 59). Every beat is counted, even inside a long note: the red number is where you play, the grey numbers are the beats you hold.

Count aloud at one speed, a little louder on beat 1. With a metronome, start slower than you think and speed up only when the passage is steady.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Hand on your heart. Tap the beat.

Say “1 2 3 4” with your taps, 1 a little louder. Keep going for ten seconds without slowing down.
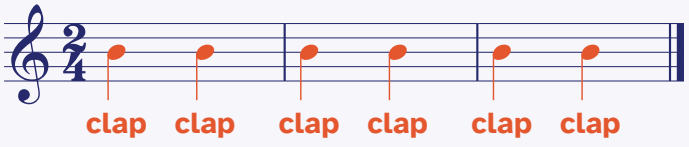
HOW TO

Find the beat of a new piece

1. **Read the time signature:** how many beats in each bar.
2. **Tap the beat** on your knee before you play, counting one bar aloud.
3. **Start slower** than the marked speed, and keep it steady to the end.

YOU KNOW THIS

Radetzky March (Johann Strauss I)



At the New Year concert the audience claps along on **every beat**. That steady clap is the pulse; the orchestra’s tune moves freely over it.

Try it. Put on any march and clap only the beat, not the tune.

THINK OF IT The beat is the stage and the notes are the actors: the stage is there before anyone walks on. Step in as you would onto an escalator: watch it move for a bar, then join in.

TRAP

- × Speeding up in easy bars and slowing in hard ones: the pulse never changes.
- × Counting only the notes you play: the beat goes on through long notes and rests.

SEE ALSO
Time signatures p. 59 · Speed words p. 82

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 1–2 · Online: Metronome
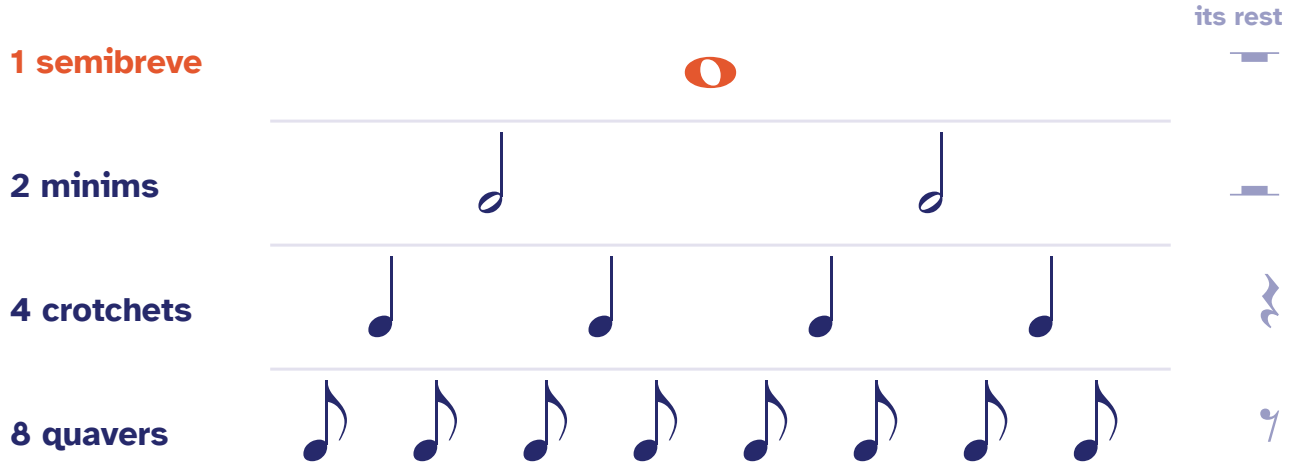
PART II · TIME · 2

Notes and rests

Music is made of sounds and silences. A **note** shows how long a sound lasts; a **rest** shows how long a silence lasts, and you count it just as carefully.

THE SECRET

Each note is half the one above it, and every note has a rest twin.

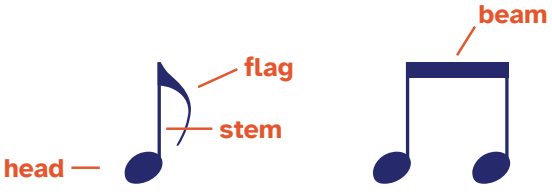


Each note splits into two of the next
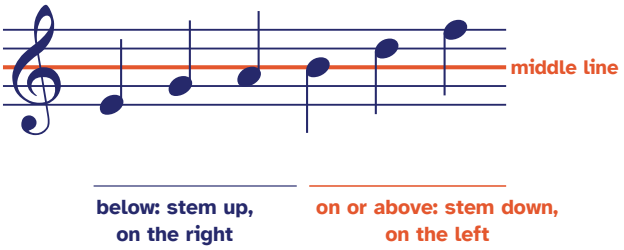
Counting quavers: say the beat's number, then "&" halfway to the next beat: "1 & 2 & 3 & 4 &".

Head, stem, flag

The **head** sits on a line or in a space. Every note but the semibreve has a **stem**. A **flag** halves the note; quavers side by side share a **beam** instead.



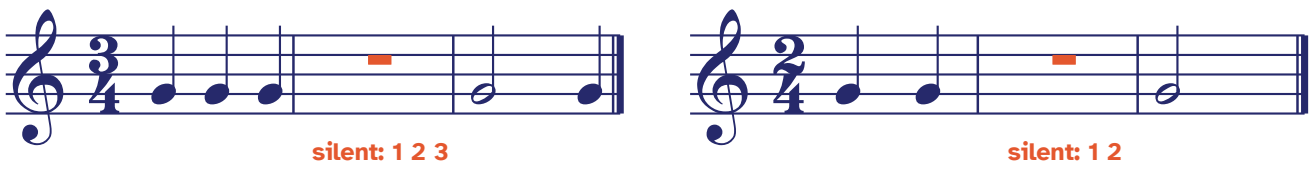
Which way does the stem go?



The stem never changes the note's length: it only keeps the page tidy.
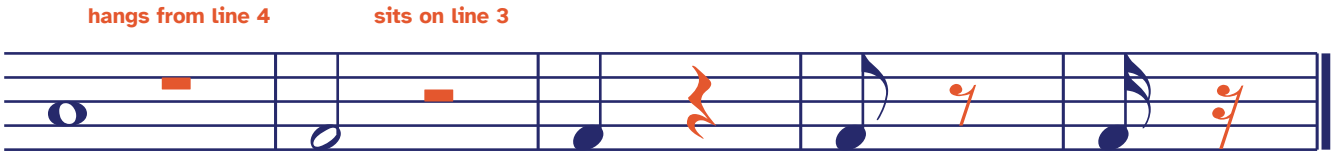
THE SEMIBREVE REST'S SPECIAL POWER

Most rests last a fixed number of beats. The **semibreve rest** can also mean **a whole bar of silence** in any time signature: 4 beats in 4/4, but 3 in 3/4 and 2 in 2/4. It is then centred in the bar. No other rest can do this.



PART II · TIME · 2 · CONTINUED

Every note has a twin rest



semibreve	**minim**	**crotchet**	**quaver**	**semiquaver**
note and rest: 4 beats	note and rest: 2 beats	note and rest: 1 beat	note and rest: ½ beat	note and rest: ¼ beat

Same length, no sound. The two big rests look alike: the **semibreve rest hangs** from line 4, heavy as a coat on a hook; the **minim rest sits** on line 3, like a hat.

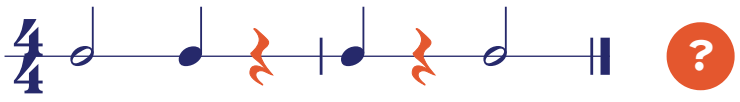
Why whole, half and quarter?

Think of each beat as a pizza. A bar of 4/4 is four pizzas. The note that fills a whole bar of 4/4 is the **whole note**; the others are a half, a quarter, an eighth and a sixteenth of it. Two quavers beamed together fill one pizza. A rest is the same share left empty: shaded with lines.

semibreve	whole note	4 pizzas · 4 beats	
semibreve rest	silence	4 beats, or a whole bar	
minim	half note	2 pizzas · 2 beats	
minim rest	silence	2 empty pizzas · 2 beats	
crotchet	quarter note	1 pizza · 1 beat	
crotchet rest	silence	1 empty pizza · 1 beat	
quaver	eighth note	half a pizza · ½ beat	
quaver rest	silence	half an empty pizza · ½ beat	
semiquaver	sixteenth note	a quarter of a pizza · ¼ beat	
semiquaver rest	silence	a quarter of an empty pizza · ¼ beat	

EXAMPLE 1

How long is each sound, and each silence?



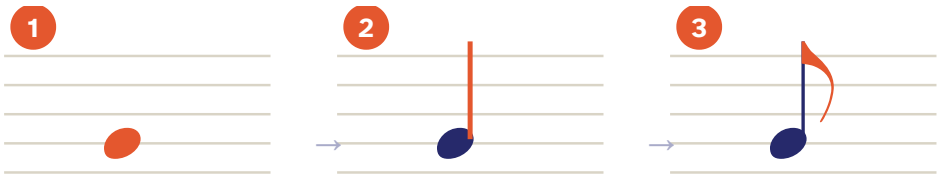
1. **Name each shape** in the bar.
2. **How many beats** does each one last?
3. **Add them up,** rests included. What is the total?

Minim 2, crotchet 1, crotchet rest 1: every bar adds up to **4 beats**, silences included.

PART II · TIME · 2 · CONTINUED

How to draw notes and rests

Draw them yourself: it is the quickest way to remember them.



an oval, tilted
filled or hollow

a stem, 3 spaces tall
up on the right

a flag, curling right
for a quaver



semibreve rest
a block hanging under line 4

minim rest
a block sitting on line 3

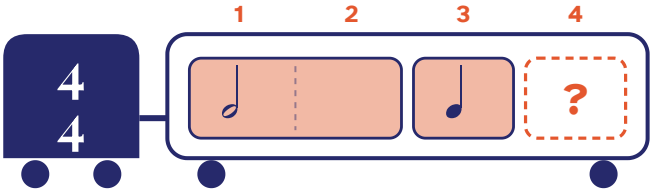
crotchet rest
draw a Z, then a little c

quaver rest
a 7 with a dot on top

semiquaver rest
a 7 with two dots

EXAMPLE 2

Fill a bar of 4/4: what goes in the last seat?
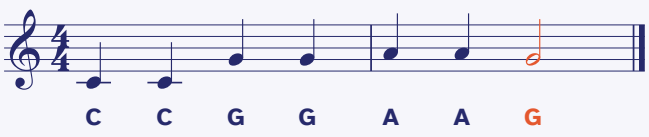


1. **How many seats** does the minim take?
2. **And the crotchet?**
3. **How many seats are left** for a silence, and which rest fills one seat?

2 + 1 = 3, one seat left: a **crotchet rest**. The bar is full.

YOU KNOW THIS

Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star



Six **crotchets**, then a **minim** at the end of the line: one beat, one beat … and two beats to breathe.

SEE ALSO
Pulse, tempo and the bar p. 50 · How long is a note? p. 56

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 3–4 · Online: Library › Notes

PART II · TIME · 3

How long is a note?

Sometimes a note needs a length no single shape gives, like three beats, or a sound that carries across the bar line. Two little signs stretch it.

THE SECRET
A dot adds half. A tie glues two notes into one.

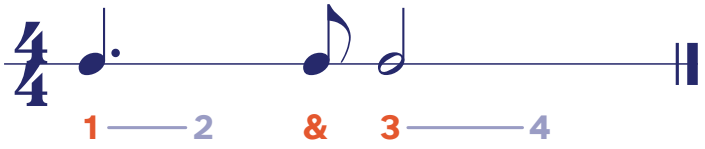


2 beats **2 + 1 = 3 beats**

The dot adds half

The dot

A dot adds **half the note's value**: a dotted minim lasts 2 + 1 = 3 beats; a dotted crotchet 1 + ½ = 1½.



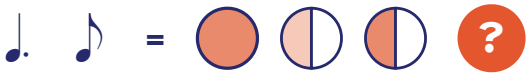
The dot, in pizzas

The dot is a helper that adds **half of whatever its note is worth**. Dark slices: the note. Lighter: what the dot adds.

dotted minim		2 + **1** (half of 2) = **3 beats**
dotted crotchet		1 + **½** (half of 1) = **1½ beats**
dotted quaver		½ + **¼** (half of ½) = **¾ beat**

EXAMPLE 1

How many beats: a dotted crotchet and a quaver?
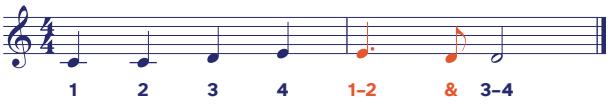


1. **The dotted crotchet:** 1 beat plus half of 1.
2. **The quaver:** half a beat.
3. **Add them.** Where does the quaver fall?

1½ + ½ = **2 beats**. The quaver lands on the "&" of beat 2: "1 (&) 2 **&**".

PART II · TIME · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

A dotted crotchet you already know: Ode to Joy



1. **Bars 3–4 of Beethoven's Ode to Joy.** Sing it: "C C D E, E — D D".
2. **The red E is a dotted crotchet:** 1 + ½ = 1½ beats, held through "1 & 2".
3. **The quaver D** falls on the "&" of beat 2; the last D takes beats 3 and 4.

Long–short, then long: the dot is why the tune **leans** before it lands.

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

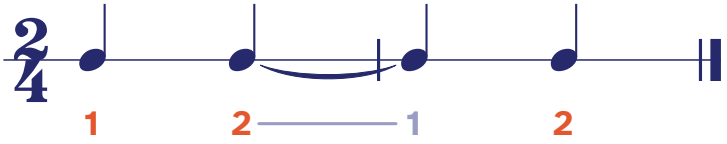
The double dot

A second dot adds half of the first dot. Rare before the higher Levels.



The tie

A curve joining two notes **of the same pitch** makes one longer sound: play the first, hold through the second, and never play it again. Ties can cross a bar line, where a dot cannot.



EXAMPLE 3

Dot or tie: which is longer?



1. **The dotted minim:** a dot adds half. How many beats?
2. **The tied notes:** add the two notes together.
3. **Compare** the two totals.

Both last **3 beats**: the same length. A tie can also cross a bar line, which a dot cannot.

PART II · TIME · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 4

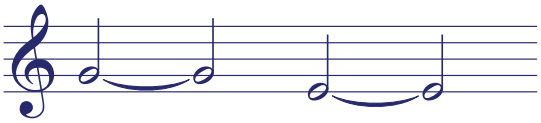
Which is longer: a dotted minim or a minim tied to a quaver?



1. **Dotted minim:** add half of 2. How many pizzas?
2. **Minim tied to a quaver:** add the two.
3. **Compare** the totals.

3 against 2½: the **dotted minim** is longer, by half a beat.

Tie or slur?



Tie: the same pitch. Play once and hold: G for 4 beats, then E for 4.



Slur: different pitches. Play every note, smoothly joined (legato).

GAME

How many beats?



1 2 3

With a crotchet as one beat: how long does each one last?

Answer: 1 three (2 + 1) · 2 one and a half (1 + ½) · 3 three (2 tied to 1).

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Clap once, hold for three.

Say “1 2 3” as you hold: a dotted minim. Then a dotted crotchet and quaver: “1 (& 2) &”.

TRAP

- × Putting the dot on the wrong note: a dot adds half of **its own** note.
- × Tying two different pitches: that curve is a slur, not a tie.
- × Two kinds of dot: one **after** the head adds length; one **above or below** it means staccato.

SEE ALSO
Time signatures p. 59 · Rhythm: groups and upbeats p. 65

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 5–6 · Online: Library

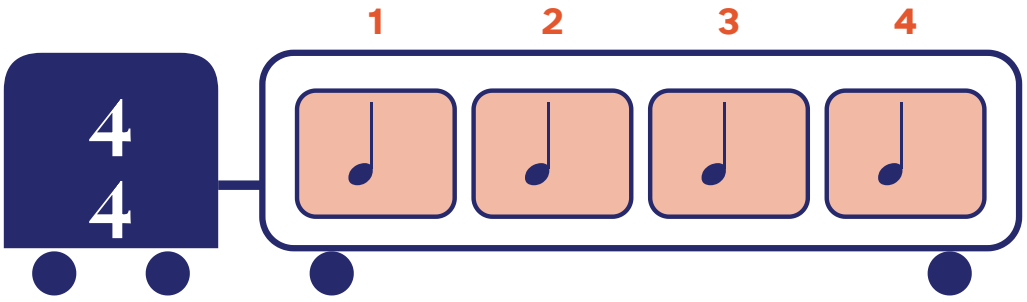
PART II · TIME · 4

Time signatures

Two numbers, like a train ticket: the **top number** says how many seats (counts) each bar has; the **bottom number** says which note fills one seat.

THE SECRET

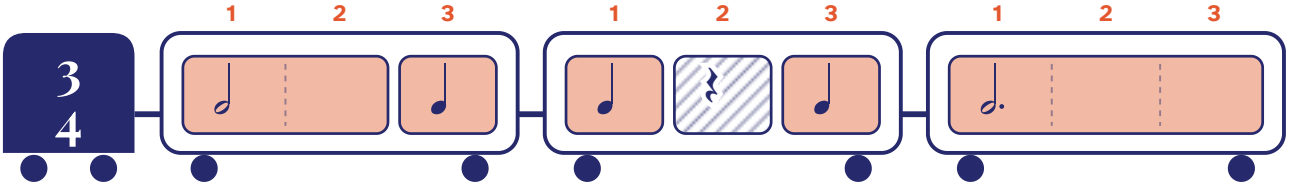
Top number: how many beats. Bottom number (in simple time): which note gets one beat.



Top: how many seats · bottom: which note sits in one

Think of a train

In 3/4 every carriage (bar) has exactly **3 seats**; each seat is one crotchet beat. Notes book seats: a minim takes 2, a crotchet 1. A rest books a seat and leaves it **empty** (shaded). Every seat in every carriage must be booked.



minim + crotchet · crotchet, crotchet rest, crotchet · dotted minim: 3 seats each

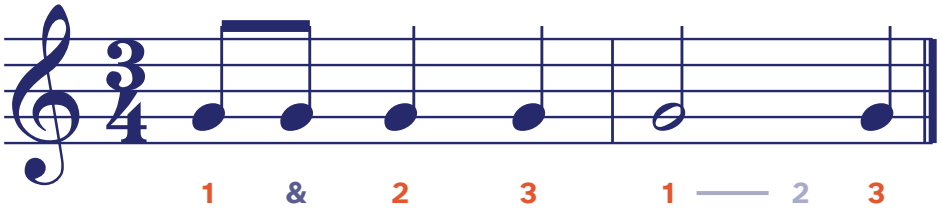
The bottom number

BOTTOM	NOTE	ONE COUNT IS A	FIRST MET
2	𝅗𝅥	minim	Grade 3
4	♩	crotchet	Beginner
8	♪	quaver	Grade 1
16	𝅘𝅥𝅯	semiquaver	*Extra*

PART II · TIME · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

What does 3/4 mean?



1. **The top number:** how many counts in each bar?
2. **The bottom number:** 4 stands for a crotchet. Which note gets one count?
3. **Check a bar:** does it add up?

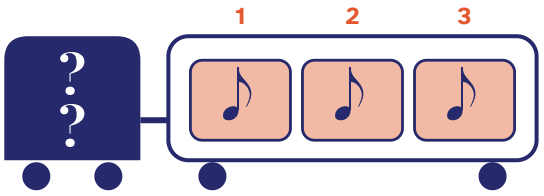
3/4: **three crotchet beats** in every bar (two quavers + crotchet + crotchet = 3).

Simple time: each beat divides in two

TIME SIGNATURE	EACH BAR HOLDS	FIRST MET
2/4	2 crotchets	Beginner
3/4	3 crotchets	Beginner
4/4 C	4 crotchets (the C sign: common time)	Beginner
2/2 ¢	2 minims (the cut C: cut common time)	Grade 3
3/2	3 minims	Grade 3
4/2	4 minims	*Extra*
3/8	3 quavers	Grade 3

EXAMPLE 2

Which ticket?



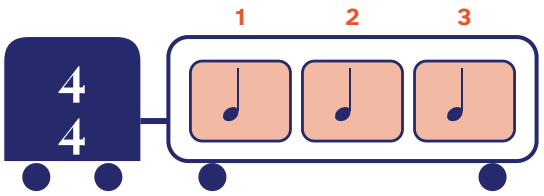
1. **Count the seats:** how many in the carriage? That is the top number.
2. **Which note** sits in one seat?
3. **Its number:** a quaver is 8. Write the ticket.

Three seats, a quaver in each: **3/8**.

PART II · TIME · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3
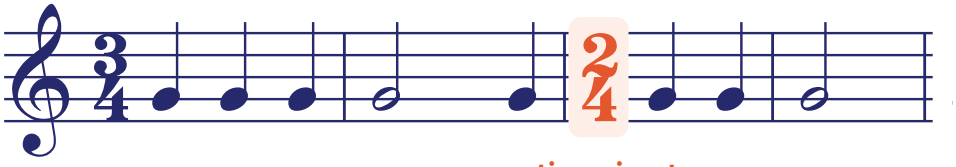
Where does the rest go?



1. **How many seats** in 4/4?
2. **The three crotchets** fill which seats?
3. **Which seat is empty,** and what goes there?

Seat 4 is empty: a **crotchet rest**. Count it: 1 2 3 (4).

Changing time signature
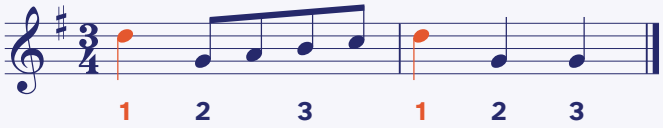


new time signature

2 beats a bar from here on

A new time signature can appear right after a bar line; it holds until the next one. It is written only once, not on every line.

YOU KNOW THIS

Minuet (from the Notebook for Anna Magdalena Bach)



Every bar holds **three crotchet beats**: 1 2 3, 1 2 3, the step of the dance. That is 3/4.

Try it. Count 1 2 3 aloud while someone plays it.

TRAP

- × Reading the bottom number as a count: it names the note that gets one beat.
- × Mixing up 3/4 and 6/8: both hold six quavers, grouped differently (p. 62).

SEE ALSO
Pulse, tempo and the bar p. 50 · Compound time p. 62

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 7–8 · Online: Library › Time signatures

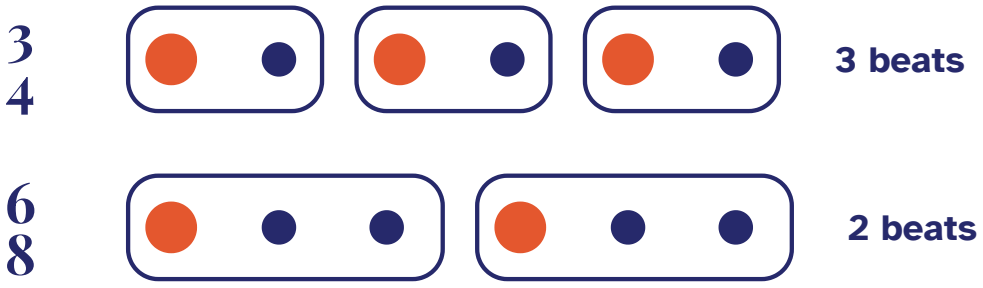
PART II · TIME · 5

Compound and irregular time

Compound time is a skipping rope: each dotted beat splits into **three**. Irregular time keeps you guessing, with **five or seven** counts in uneven groups. (9/4, 12/4 and /16 signatures are rare.)

THE SECRET

Dotted beats split in three: 6/8 is two big beats.



Same six quavers, new groups

SIMPLE OR COMPOUND?

In **simple time** each beat divides into **two**. In **compound time** each beat is a dotted note and divides into **three**.



Simple: one beat splits in 2 **Compound: one beat splits in 3**

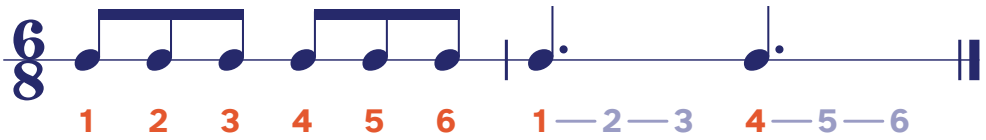
Quick test: a top number of 6, 9 or 12 means compound. Divide it by 3 to find the beats: 6/8 has 2, 9/8 has 3, 12/8 has 4.

Compound time

TIME SIGNATURE	EACH BAR HOLDS	FIRST MET
6/8	2 dotted crotchets	Grade 1
9/8	3 dotted crotchets	Grade 3
12/8	4 dotted crotchets	Grade 3
6/4	2 dotted minims	Grade 4

PART II · TIME · 5 · CONTINUED

Counting 6/8



Slowly, count all six quavers. At speed, feel two beats, on 1 and 4: “1 & a, 2 & a”.

HOW TO

Feel compound time

1. **Say “pine-ap-ple”** on every beat and step only on “pine”.
2. **Clap the three syllables** while you step.

EXAMPLE 1

How many beats in 9/8?



1. **The top number, 9:** does it divide by 3?
2. **How many groups of three** fit in 9?
3. **What is each beat**, in quavers?

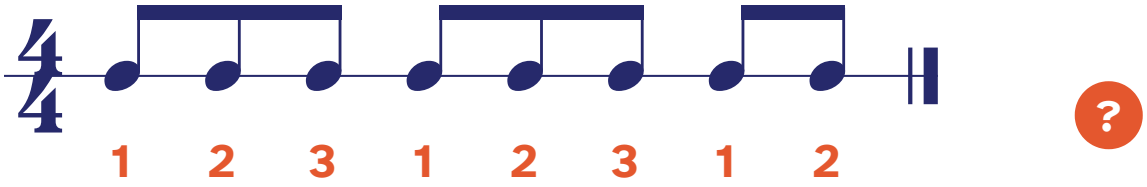
9 ÷ 3 = **three beats**, each a dotted crotchet: “1 2 3, 4 5 6, 7 8 9”.

Uneven groups in 4/4

Many dances keep 4/4 but group the eight quavers unevenly.

EXAMPLE 2

Is this still 4/4?



1. **Count eight quavers** in the bar.
2. **Group them 3 + 3 + 2:** where do the accents fall?
3. **Keep your foot on the beat.** How many foot taps?

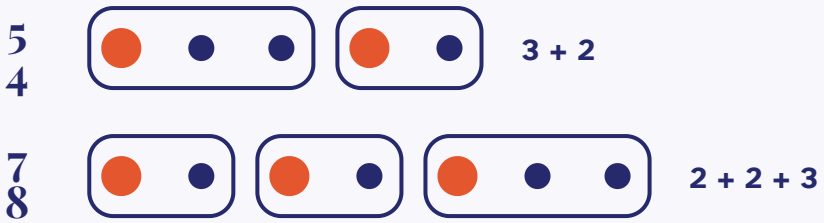
Accents on 1, 4 and 7, but four foot taps: the bar is still **4/4**, only the accents are uneven.

PART II · TIME · 5 · CONTINUED

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Irregular time
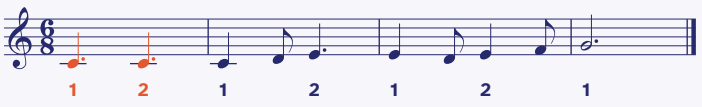
Five or seven counts, grouped unevenly. Met from Grade 5.



TIME SIGNATURE	EACH BAR HOLDS	FIRST MET
5/4	5 crotchets: 3 + 2 or 2 + 3	Grade 5
7/4	7 crotchets: 4 + 3 or 3 + 4	*Extra*
5/8	5 quavers: 3 + 2 or 2 + 3	*Extra*
7/8	7 quavers: 2 + 2 + 3 or 3 + 2 + 2	*Extra*

YOU KNOW THIS

Row, Row, Row Your Boat



Two big beats in every bar, each a **dotted crotchet**: “Row, row”. Each big beat is worth three quavers: “row your” is long-short, a crotchet and a quaver, filling one big beat. That is 6/8.

Try it. Sway twice per bar while you sing it.

TRAP

- × Reading 6/8 as six crotchet beats: the 8 means quavers.
- × Beaming 6/8 quavers in twos: in compound time they go in threes.
- × Counting 5/4 as four beats and one left over: feel it as 3 + 2 (or 2 + 3), one long group and one short.

SEE ALSO
Time signatures p. 59 · Rhythm: groups and upbeats p. 65

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 9–10 · Online: Rhythm clock

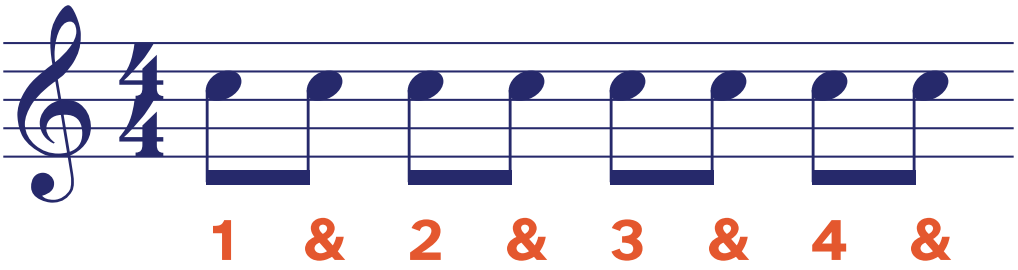
PART II · TIME · 6

Rhythm: groups and upbeats

Say your own name: long and short sounds, that's **rhythm**. The pulse marches steadily on; the rhythm dances around it. How the notes are grouped on the page shows where the beats fall.

THE SECRET

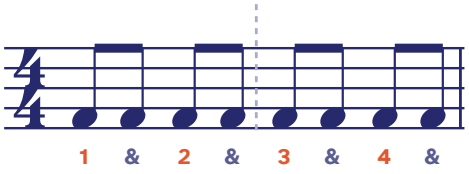
Beams group notes into beats; an upbeat borrows from the last bar.



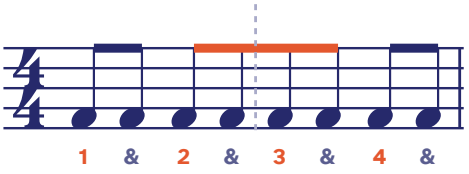
One beam, one beat

Grouping with beams

Beams join the notes of **one beat**, so the beats stay visible. In 4/4 a beam may cover beats 1–2 or 3–4, but never cross the middle of the bar (except in a deliberate grouping such as 3 + 3 + 2). In compound time, quavers are beamed in threes.



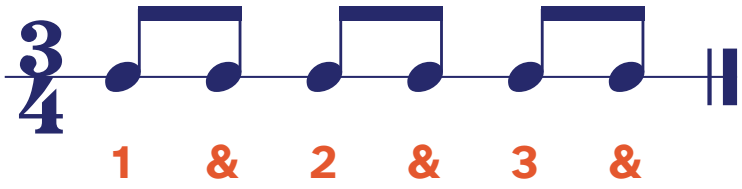
✓ beams show the beats



× a beam across the middle

EXAMPLE 1

Why are six quavers beamed in twos in 3/4?



?

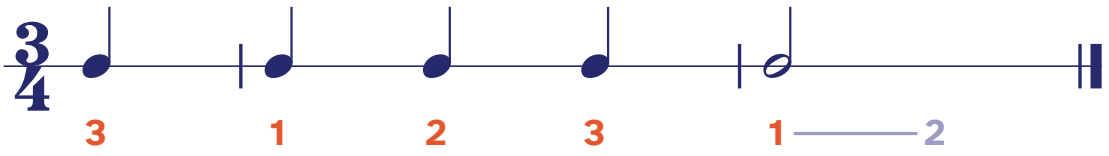
1. **How many beats** does 3/4 have, and what kind?
2. **How many quavers** fit in one beat?
3. **So how many** go under each beam?

Three crotchet beats, two quavers each: **2 + 2 + 2**. Beamed 3 + 3 they would look like 6/8.

PART II · TIME · 6 · CONTINUED

The upbeat (anacrusis)
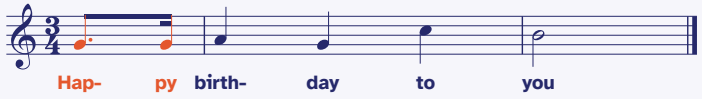
A piece can begin **before** the first full bar, with one or more notes called an upbeat or anacrusis. The last bar is then short by the same amount, so the two together make one full bar. Count the missing beats in silence before you start.



Count “1 2” silently, then play on 3. The upbeat (1 beat) and the last bar (2 beats) make one full bar.

YOU KNOW THIS

Happy Birthday

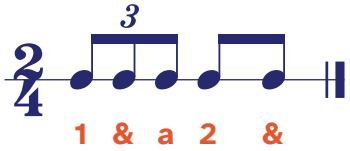


“Hap-py” comes **before** the first strong beat: an upbeat. The strong beat lands on “birth”.

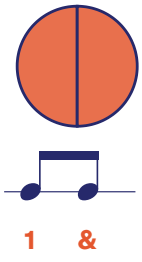
Try it. Sing it and clap only on “birth”, “day” and “you”: you feel where bar 1 starts.

THINK OF IT An upbeat is the breath before you speak: “and-ONE”. You lift on the upbeat so the strong beat can land.

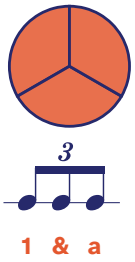
Triplets



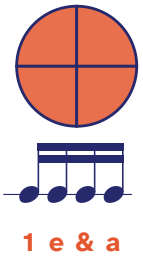
Triplet: three exactly equal notes in the time of two. First met: Grade 2.



Two quavers: one beat cut in 2



A **triplet**: one beat cut in 3

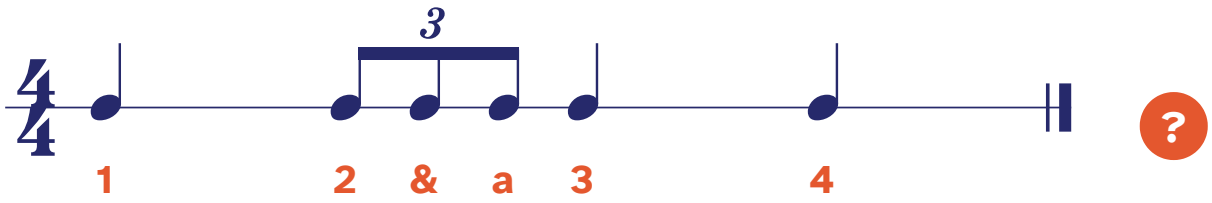


Four semiquavers: one beat cut in 4

PART II · TIME · 6 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Where is the triplet, and how do you count it?



1. **Count the bar:** four crotchet beats.
2. **Find the little 3.** Which beat do the three quavers share?
3. **Say it:** "2 & a" on that beat.

Beat 2: "1, **2 & a**, 3, 4" (some say "trip-o-let"). Three notes squeeze into one beat; the beat never moves.

EXAMPLE 3

Count a bar of mixed values
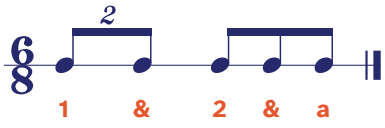


1. **Find the beats:** four crotchet beats, one per number.
2. **Beat by beat:** how many notes share each beat?
3. **Say it:** "&" for 2 notes, "e & a" for 4, "& a" for a triplet.

"1, 2 &, 3 e & a, 4 & a": crotchet, two quavers, four semiquavers, a triplet. **One beat each.**

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Duplet



Two notes in the time of three, in compound time: the triplet turned inside out.

SEE ALSO

Notes and rests p. 53 · Rhythm: off the beat p. 68

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 11–12 · Online: Rhythm clock

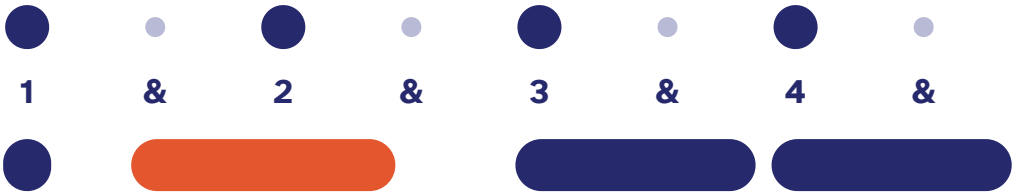
PART II · TIME · 7

Rhythm: off the beat

Now the fun part: rhythm that teases the beat. It only works if the beat underneath stays rock-steady.

THE SECRET

Keep the beat rock-steady and let the rhythm tease it.



starts on “&”, held over beat 2

A note between the beats

Swing Prelim

Common from the first pieces: jazz, blues and many easy modern pieces are marked *swing*. Pairs of quavers are written evenly but played **long–short**, like the first and last notes of a triplet.



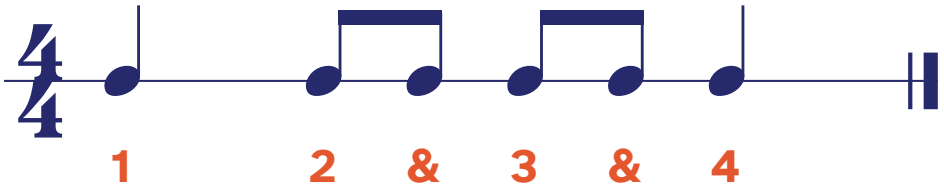
Written



Played

EXAMPLE 1

Which notes swing?



?

1. **Find the quaver pairs.** On which beats?
2. **Play each pair long–short:** “doo-ba”.
3. **What about the crotchets?**

Only the **pairs** (beats 2 and 3) swing; the crotchets and the beat underneath stay even.

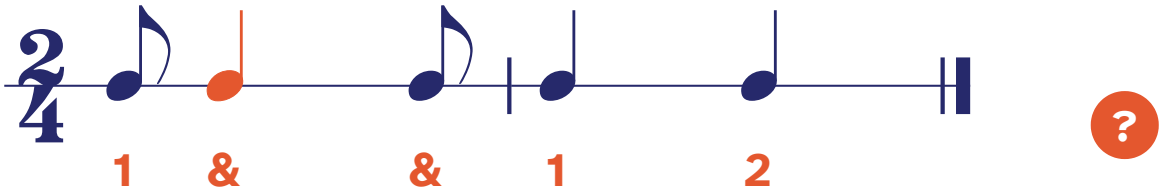
PART II · TIME · 7 · CONTINUED

Syncopation Grade 4

A note starts on the “&”, between the beats, and is held through the next beat. Feel that beat even though nothing is played on it.

EXAMPLE 2

Where does the long note start?
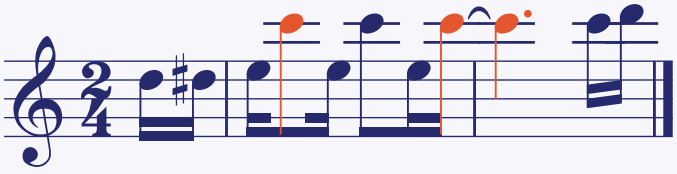


1. **Tap the beats:** 1, 2.
2. **Find the red crotchet.** Does it start on a beat, or on the “&”?
3. **Hold it:** through which beat?

It starts on the “&” and holds through beat 2: the long note starts **off the beat**. That is syncopation.

YOU KNOW THIS

The Entertainer (Scott Joplin)



The high **C** keeps landing just after the beat, not on it: syncopation, the bounce of ragtime.

Try it. Tap the beat with your foot and hum the tune: hear the C slip between the taps.

THINK OF IT Syncopation is a skip in your walk: a step that lands between the beats.

HOW TO

Feel off-beat rhythm

1. **Tap a steady beat** with your foot.
2. **Clap only between the taps**, on the “&”.
3. **If the foot starts to follow the hands,** slow down.

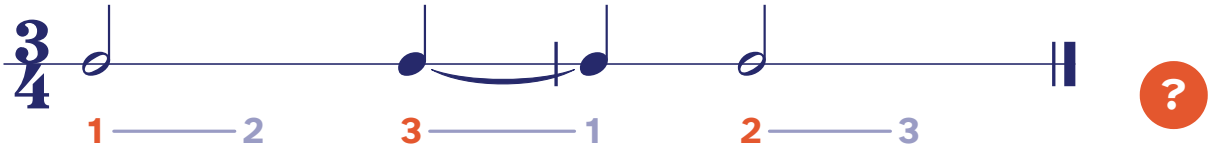
PART II · TIME · 7 · CONTINUED

Hemiola Grade 4

Two bars of 3/4 felt as three bars of two: three minims across the bar line. Common at the ends of phrases in Baroque dances.

EXAMPLE 3

Two bars of 3, or one big bar?



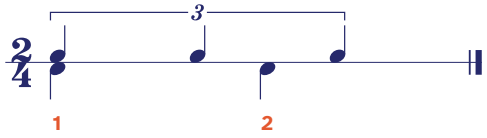
1. **Count as written:** "1 2 3, 1 2 3".
2. **Look at the notes:** how many beats does each minim last?
3. **Feel each minim** as one big beat. How many big beats?

Three minims of two beats: the six beats are felt as **three big ones**. That is a hemiola.

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Polyrhythm and rubato

Polyrhythm (Grade 7): two rhythms at once.



Three against two: a triplet above, two crotchets below, starting together.

Rubato: time is stretched and then given back, for expression: the music leans into a phrase and catches up after it. The pulse always returns. Marked *rubato*, or simply part of the style in much music from the 1800s.



TRAP

- × Rushing the short notes after a long one: keep counting inside the long note.
- × Swinging the crotchets: only the quaver pairs swing.

SEE ALSO

Rhythm: groups and upbeats p. 65 · Speed words p. 82

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 13–14 · Online: Rhythm clock

PART II · TIME · 8

Repeats and road signs

Music often says “play that again”. Instead of writing the same bars twice, it uses **repeat signs** and **road signs**. Read them like a map: they tell you which bar comes next.

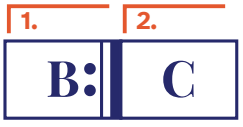
THE SECRET

Follow the map: jump back at the sign, stop at Fine, or jump to the Coda.



You play: A → B → A → B → C

Two dots facing back mean: go back and play it again

SIGN	NAME	WHAT YOU DO
	**repeat signs**	play the bars between them twice (with only the end sign: go back to the start)
	**1st and 2nd time bars**	first time play the 1. bar; after the repeat skip it and play the 2. bar
D.C.	**da capo**	“from the head”: go back to the very beginning
	**D.S.** (dal segno)	“from the sign”: go back to the segno
Fine	**fine**	“the end”: after a D.C. or D.S., stop here
	**coda**	“tail”: at “To Coda”, jump to the coda sign and play the ending

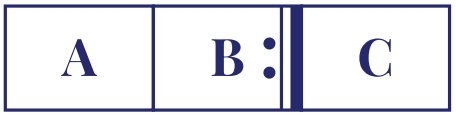
THE RULE

Follow the map in order. At a jump (D.C., D.S.) go back; then the first time you meet Fine, stop; or at To Coda, jump to the coda.

PART II · TIME · 8 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

In what order do you play these bars?



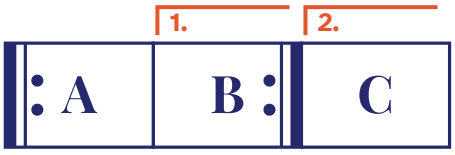
You play: ? ? ? ? ?

1. **Play A and B.**
2. **B ends with a repeat sign** facing back. There is no start sign: where do you go back to?
3. **Play it again,** then carry on.

Back to the very start: **A B A B C**.

EXAMPLE 2

First and second time



You play: ? ? ? ?

1. **First time through:** play A, then the bar marked 1.
2. **The repeat sign** sends you back to A.
3. **Second time:** which bar do you skip, and which do you play?

A B, A C: **A B A C**. The 1. bar is skipped the second time.

GAME

How many bars do you play?

1	2	3
|: A B :|	A |: B C :| D	A B (Fine) C D.C.

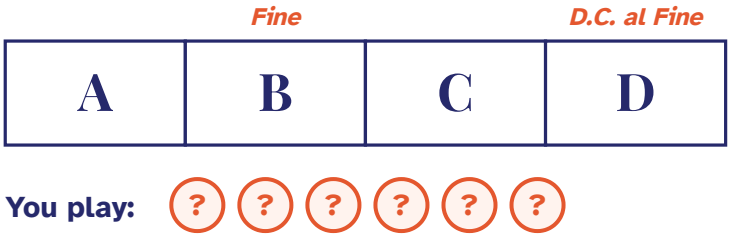
Each letter is one bar. Follow the signs and count every bar you play.

Answer: 1 four (A B A B) · 2 six (A B C B C D) · 3 five (A B C A B).

PART II · TIME · 8 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

D.C. al Fine

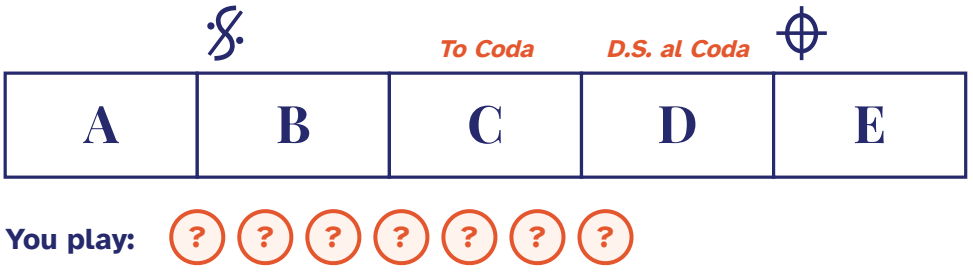


1. **Play straight through** to D.
2. **D.C.** means go back: to where?
3. **al Fine:** where do you stop the second time?

A B C D, then from the head to Fine: **A B C D A B**.

EXAMPLE 4

D.S. al Coda



1. **Play through** to D. (Ignore "To Coda" the first time.)
2. **D.S.** sends you back to the sign: which bar has it?
3. **Play on to "To Coda",** then jump. Where?

A B C D, back to the sign, B C, jump to the coda: **A B C D B C E**.

TRAP

- × Taking the repeat again after a D.C.: on the way back, skip the repeats (unless the music says otherwise).
- × Jumping at "To Coda" the first time through: it only works after the D.S. or D.C.

SEE ALSO
Pulse, tempo and the bar p. 50 · Time signatures p. 59

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 15–16 · Online: Library › Signs

PART II · TIME · TIPS

When the rhythm slips

A rhythm that slips is nearly always a beat that was not counted. Find which beat, count it out loud, and the rest of the bar usually falls into place.

TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
It speeds up or slows down	**the pulse**: count one bar aloud before you start	p. 50
A rest gets skipped	**the rest**: it is counted just like a note	p. 53
Long notes come out short	**the hold**: count every beat of a minim, dot or tie	p. 56
The bar feels too long or too short	**the time signature**: how many counts, which note is one	p. 59
An off-beat note lands on the beat	**the "&"**: keep the beat in your foot and count it	p. 68

Four ways to steady a rhythm

1. **Count out loud**
   Say the counts while you play, not in your head: a slip you can hear is a slip you can fix.

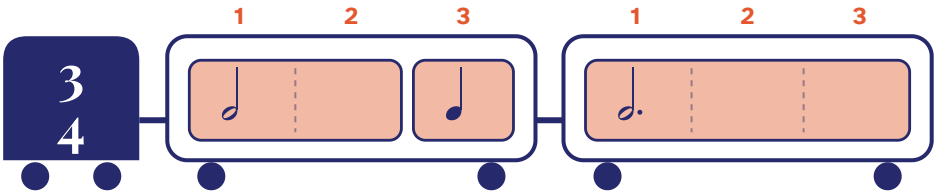
2. **Tap, then play**
   Tap the rhythm on the lid and say the counts; play only when the tapping is steady.

3. **Walk the beat**
   Step the pulse while you clap the rhythm, so the beat lives in your feet.

4. **Split the beat**
   For dots and quavers, count "1 & 2 &": the extra "&" shows exactly where each note goes.

EXAMPLE

Count the long notes



1. **Say 1 2 3** once through before you play, to feel the beat.
2. **The minim books seats 1 and 2:** keep saying "2" while it sounds.
3. **The dotted minim books all three:** let go on the next "1", not before.

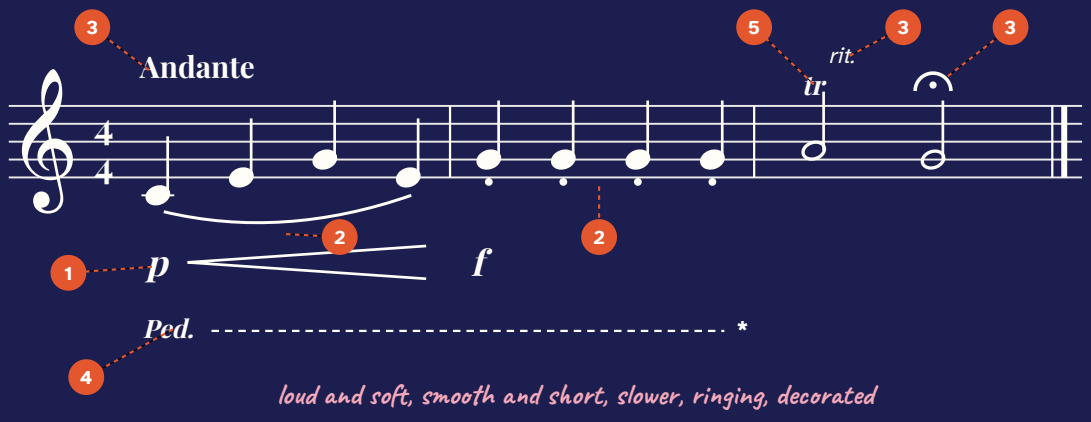
Long notes are where counting slips: **say every seat** they book.

THINK OF IT Like a dance partner: the beat leads, the rhythm follows.

PART III · HOW IT SHOULD SOUND

Expression

The notes say **what** to play; expression says **how**: loud or soft, smooth or short, faster or slower, ringing or dry. Everything in this part is in these three bars.



1 **Loud and soft** p. 76
p, f and the steps between; hairpins grow and fade

2 **Touch: smooth, short, strong** p. 79
slurs, staccato dots, tenuto lines and accents

3 **Speed words** p. 82
Andante, Allegro; rit. slows down, a fermata waits

4 **The pedals** p. 85
Ped. down, * up: the right pedal keeps notes ringing

5 **Ornaments** p. 88
trills, mordents, turns and grace notes

★ **Tips: when your playing sounds flat** p. 91

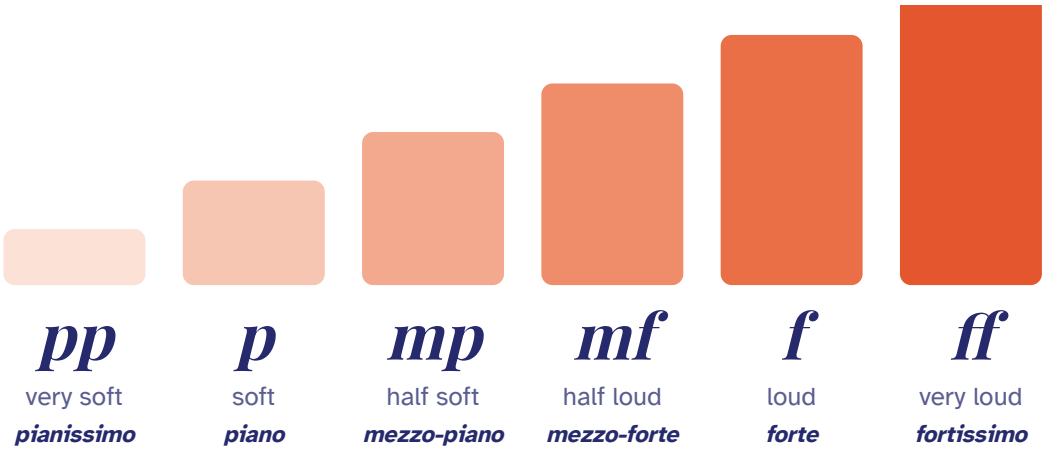
PART III · EXPRESSION · 1

Loud and soft

A voice can whisper, chat or shout. Music does the same, and small Italian words tell you which: the **dynamics**. They sit under the notes, shortened to one or two letters.

THE SECRET

Six steps, from a whisper to a shout: pp p mp mf f ff. m means half.



Six steps from a whisper to a shout

THE RULE

A sign lasts until the next one: *p* stays soft until a new sign arrives.

EXAMPLE 1
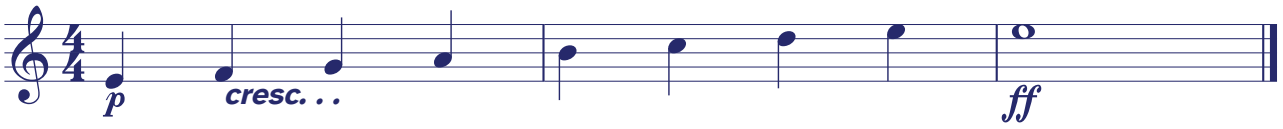
Which is louder: mp or mf?

mp ***mf*** ?

1. **m means half.** Half of what?
2. **p is soft, f is loud.**
3. **So which half** is louder?

mf, half loud, is louder than **mp**, half soft. Both sit in the middle of the ladder.

Growing and fading



In words: *cresc.* and dots, then *ff*. A hairpin that opens does the same; one that closes fades.

PART III · EXPRESSION · 1 · CONTINUED
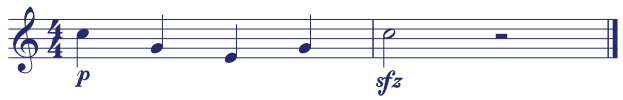
SIGN	NAME	WHAT YOU DO
	**crescendo** (*cresc.*)	getting louder, little by little
	**diminuendo** (*dim.*, *decresc.*)	getting softer, little by little
sfz* / *sf	**sforzando**	one note made suddenly strong
fp	**forte-piano**	loud, then soft at once
subito p	**subito**	"suddenly": *subito p*, suddenly soft



height = loudness · left to right = time

EXAMPLE 2

One strong note, or loud then soft?



A



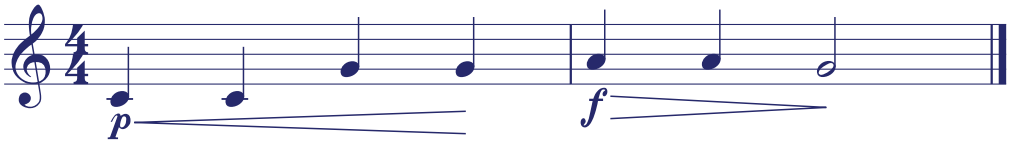
B

1. **Find the sign** under each tune.
2. **sfz**: one note made suddenly strong; the music goes on as before.
3. **fp**: loud for an instant, then soft at once.

A is **sfz**: one strong note, then back to the music around it. B is **fp**: strike loud, and the next moment soft.

EXAMPLE 3

What happens across the hairpins?
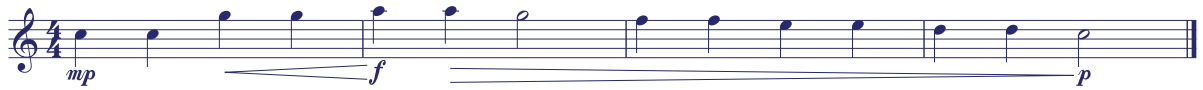


?

1. **Find the start:** which sign?
2. **The first hairpin opens** to which sign?
3. **The second hairpin closes.** What happens?

Start *p*, grow through bar 1 into *f*, then **fade** through bar 2.

PART III · EXPRESSION · 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 4

Where is the loudest note?



?

1. **Start:** *mp*.
2. **Follow the hairpin** to its sign.
3. **Then the long hairpin closes** to which sign?

The **first A in bar 2**, at *f*. From the next note the tune fades all the way to *p*.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

pp* → *ff

One note, six ways.

Play Middle C *pp*, then *p*, *mp*, *mf*, *f*, *ff*: six different steps, using the weight of your arm. Then come back down.
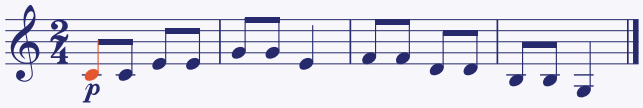
HOW TO

Practise a crescendo

1. **Play five notes up**, C to G, all *p*.
2. **Now grow** one step on each note: *p* to *f*.
3. **Come back down** the same notes, fading to *p*, without slowing down.

YOU KNOW THIS

Haydn's "Surprise" Symphony



The tune tiptoes along softly, *p*, then comes again even softer. Just as everyone relaxes, the whole orchestra crashes in with one **ff** chord: the surprise that gave the symphony its name.

Try it. Hum it very softly, then clap once, as loud as you can.

THINK OF IT Dynamics are a volume knob with six clicks. Turn it with the weight of your arm, not by hitting harder.

TRAP

- × Playing everything *mf*: each sign is a different step.
- × Speeding up in a crescendo: louder is not faster.

SEE ALSO
Touch p. 79 · Pulse, tempo and the bar p. 50

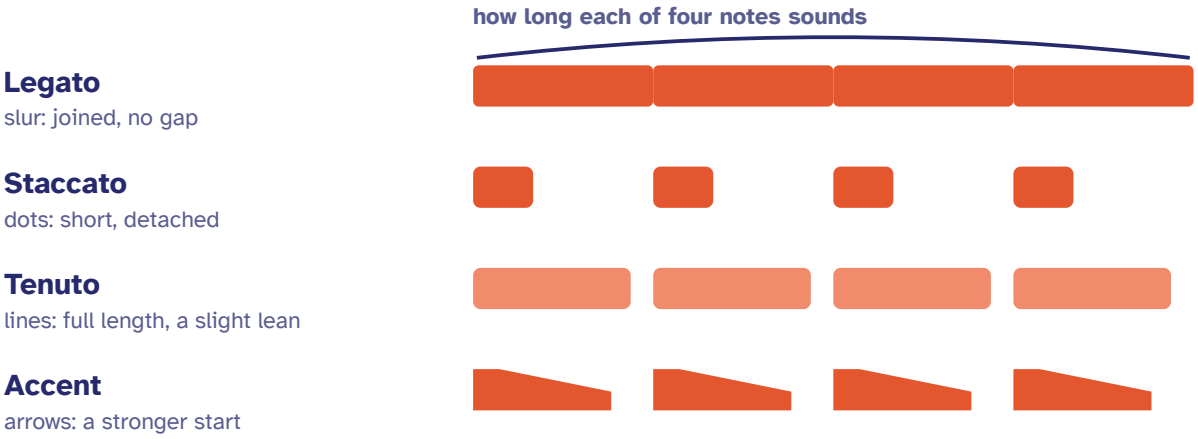
PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 1–2 · Online: Library › Dynamics

PART III · EXPRESSION · 2
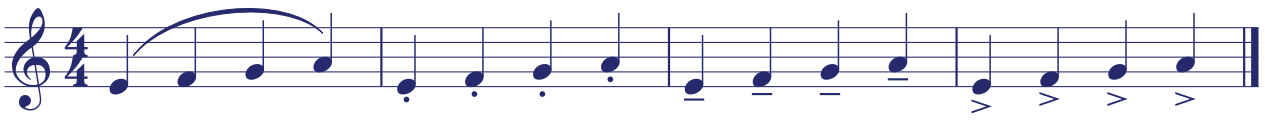
Touch: smooth, short, strong

The same four notes can sound smooth or bouncy, gentle or strong. Small marks above or below the notes tell your fingers how to touch the keys: this is **articulation**.

THE SECRET
Curve: join. Dot: short.
Line: hold. Arrow: strong.



Same notes, four touches
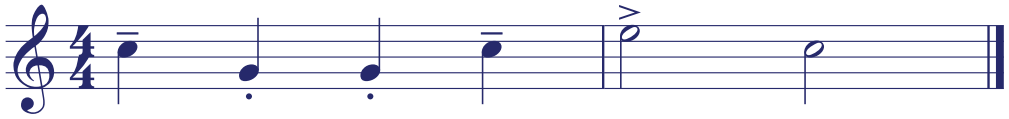


The same four notes: slurred, staccato, tenuto, accented.

MARK	NAME	HOW TO PLAY
⌒	**slur** (*legato*)	join the notes smoothly, no gap
●	**staccato**	short and detached: let go early
—	**tenuto**	hold the full length, leaning a little
>	**accent**	a stronger start to the note
▼	**staccatissimo**	very short *Extra*
^	**marcato**	very strong, marked *Extra*

PART III · EXPRESSION · 2 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Line, dot or arrow?
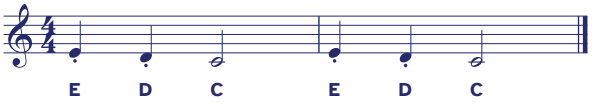


1. **The first two Cs have lines:** how long?
2. **The Gs have dots.**
3. **The E in bar 2** has an arrow.

The first two Cs held their **full length**, the Gs short, the E strong, and the last C plain, held for its two beats.

Slurs and phrases



Slurred: join E D C, then a tiny lift.
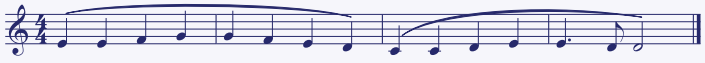


Staccato: every E and D let go early.

A curve over **different** notes is a slur: join them, then lift at its end, like a breath. A long slur over a whole line of tune is a **phrase mark**: one musical sentence. (A curve joining the **same** note twice is a tie, p. 56.)

YOU KNOW THIS

Ode to Joy (Beethoven)



Two long slurs: two musical sentences. Lift your hand **only** at the end of each one, like a singer taking a breath.

Try it. Sing it and breathe only where the slurs end.

EXAMPLE 2

Which notes are short?
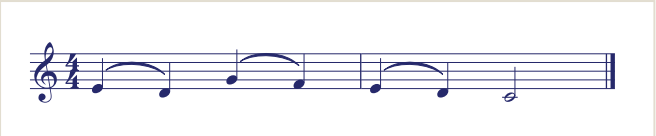


1. **Bar 1:** what does the curve ask?
2. **Bar 2:** find the dots.
3. **The last G** has a different mark: which?

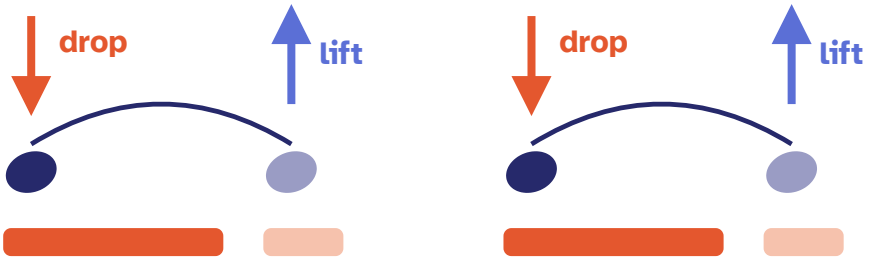
Bar 1 is joined; the **two dotted Gs are short**; the third G is accented, stronger but full length.

PART III · EXPRESSION · 2 · CONTINUED

Two-note slurs



A slur over just two notes is a little sigh: **drop** into the first note, then **lift** off the second, lighter and a little shorter. Drop, lift.



first note full and weighted · second lighter and shorter

Mood words

Some words describe the mood, not the speed.

WORD	MEANING	WORD	MEANING
dolce	sweetly	*leggiero*	lightly
cantabile	in a singing style	*espressivo*	with feeling
legato	smoothly	*grazioso*	gracefully
maestoso	majestically	*con moto*	with movement

HOW TO

Practise touch

1. **Play one bar** of a piece three ways: all legato, all staccato, then as written.
2. **Listen:** can someone else hear which way was which?

THINK OF IT Legato is walking: one foot leaves the ground as the other lands. Staccato is hopping on hot sand.

TRAP

- × Making staccato loud: short is not the same as strong.
- × Lifting in the middle of a slur: keep every note joined until the curve ends.

SEE ALSO
Loud and soft p. 76 · Tie or slur? p. 58

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 3–4 · Online: Library › Articulation

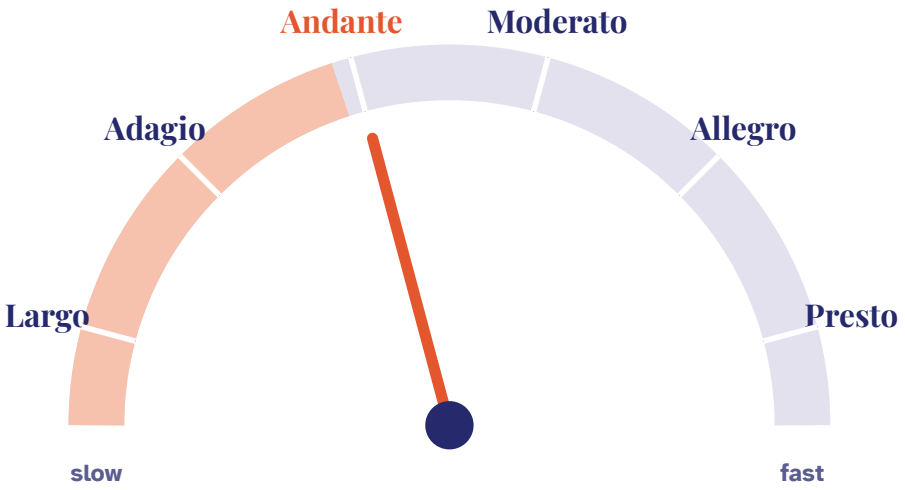
PART III · EXPRESSION · 3

Speed words

How fast is the beat? A word at the top of the music tells you, usually in Italian, and often a number too. Other words inside the music ask you to slow down, speed up, or wait.

THE SECRET

The word at the top sets the speed; rit. brakes gently, a tempo drives off again.



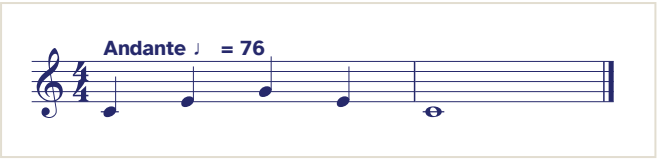
Andante: the speed of walking

WORD	MEANING	ABOUT (BEATS A MINUTE)
Largo	very slow and broad	40–60
Lento	slow	45–60
Adagio	slow, at ease	60–76
Andante	at a walking pace	76–108
Moderato	at a moderate speed	108–120
Allegretto	fairly fast, a little slower than Allegro	112–120
Allegro	fast and lively	120–156
Vivace	lively and brisk	156–176
Presto	very fast	168–200

The numbers are a rough guide: the music and the room decide the rest.

PART III · EXPRESSION · 3 · CONTINUED

The metronome mark



♩ = 76 means 76 crotchet beats in one minute. Set a metronome to 76: each click is one beat. The word tells you the character; the number pins down the speed.

EXAMPLE 1

How fast is ♩ = 60?

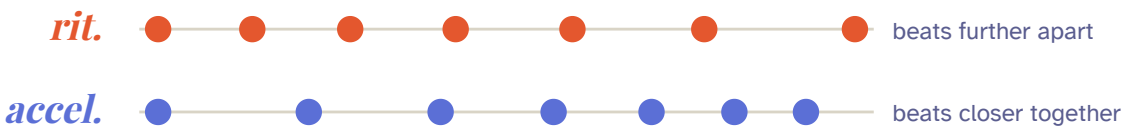


1. **60 beats** in one minute.
2. **How many seconds** are there in a minute?
3. **So one beat** lasts how long?

One beat every **second**: tick, tick, like a clock.
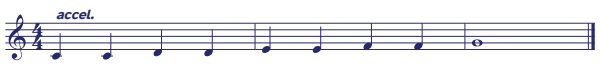
Changing speed

WORD OR SIGN	WHAT YOU DO
rit. (ritardando), *rall.* (rallentando)	gradually slower
accel. (accelerando)	gradually faster
a tempo	back to the speed before
𝄐 fermata (pause)	hold longer than written, then go on
poco a poco	little by little
molto · *poco* · *più* · *meno*	very · a little · more · less (*più mosso*: faster; *meno mosso*: slower)
rubato	time borrowed and paid back (p. 69) *Extra*





rit.: slow down into the end, then wait on the fermata.
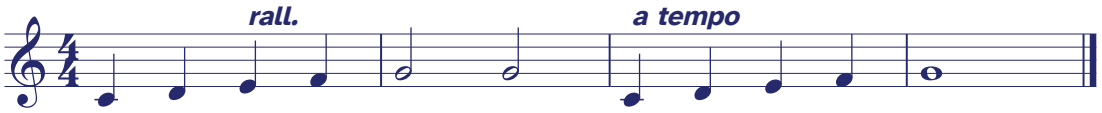


accel.: speed up, little by little, to the end.

PART III · EXPRESSION · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Where does it slow down, and where does it come back?

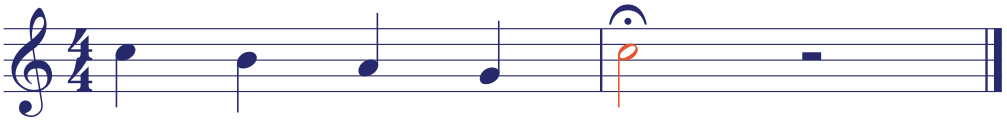


1. **Find rall.** Which notes does it slow?
2. **Find a tempo.**
3. **What speed** does a tempo mean?

Bar 1 slows into the two Gs; at **a tempo** (bar 3) the first speed comes straight back.

EXAMPLE 3

How long do you hold the fermata?
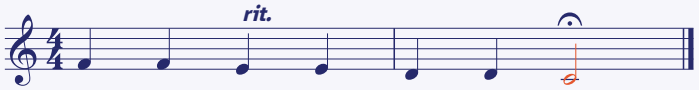


1. **The minim** is worth how many beats?
2. **The fermata** asks for more. How much?
3. **Then what?**

Longer than 2 beats: hold until it **feels finished**, often half as long again or more, then go on.

YOU KNOW THIS

Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star



Players often slow down into the last “are”: a **rit.**, then a fermata on the final C. The ending feels like coming home.

Try it. Sing the last line twice: once in time, once with a rit.

THINK OF IT A rit. is a car braking gently at the lights; a tempo is driving off again at the same speed as before.

TRAP

- × Taking Andante as slow: it is a walking pace.
- × Slowing down all at once at rit.: slow little by little.
- × Forgetting a tempo: after a rit., the first speed comes back exactly.

SEE ALSO

Pulse, tempo and the bar p. 50 · Rubato p. 70

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 5–6 · Online: Metronome

PART III · EXPRESSION · 4

The pedals

Most pianos have three pedals. The right one, the **sustain pedal**, lifts every damper off the strings, so notes keep ringing after your fingers let go. The left one makes the sound softer.

THE SECRET

Play first, then change the pedal: up and straight down again.



soft pedal
una corda
softer, gentler

middle pedal
sostenuto
holds only some notes

sustain pedal
damper pedal
notes keep ringing

Right pedal: the notes keep ringing

What the sustain pedal does



pedal up: dampers on the strings

pedal down: dampers lifted

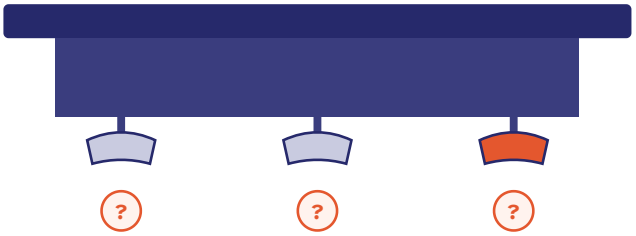
Each string has a felt damper resting on it. Let go of a key and its damper stops the string. The sustain pedal lifts every damper at once, so the strings ring on.

PEDAL	NAME AND SIGN	WHAT IT DOES
left	soft pedal: *una corda*, written *u.c.*	a softer, gentler sound; lift it at *t.c.* (*tre corde*)
middle	*sostenuto* *Extra*	holds only the notes already down (on many uprights: a practice mute)
right	sustain (damper) pedal: *Ped.*	every note keeps ringing until you lift it

PART III · EXPRESSION · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Which pedal?



1 **Ped.**: which foot pedal? 2 **u.c.**: which one? 3 **t.c.**: what do you do?

Ped. is the **right** pedal; *u.c.* the **left** one; *t.c.* means let the left pedal up.

Writing the sustain pedal
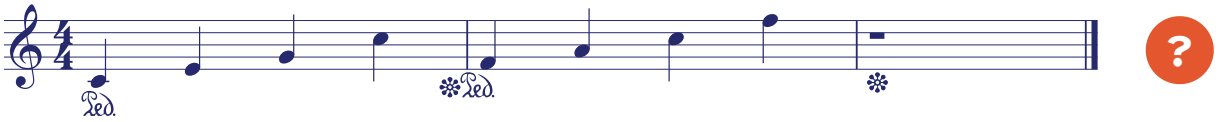
Down at **Ped.**, up at the star, or a line with hooks; six ways are on p. 87.

THE RULE

Heel on the floor, press with the ball of your foot. Play first, then pedal: new notes, then up and straight down again.

EXAMPLE 2

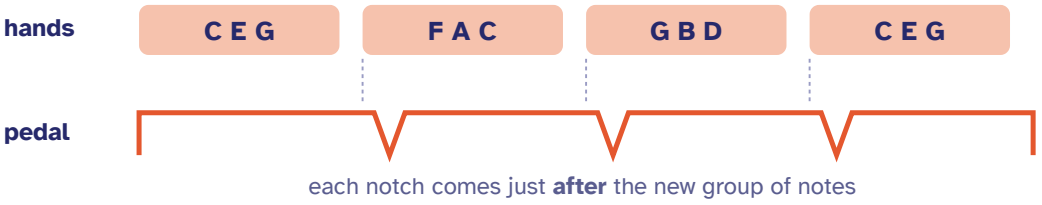
Where does the pedal go down, and where does it come up?



1 **Find Ped.** under the first C. 2 **Find the next sign:** a star with Ped. 3 **Find the last star.**

Down on the first C, **changed** at the first F (up and down again), and up at the end: each bar rings as one sound.

Changing the pedal



each notch comes just **after** the new group of notes

A chord is three or more notes played together. Play each new chord first, then change the pedal straight away.

PART III · EXPRESSION · 4 · CONTINUED

Six ways to write the pedal

HOW IT LOOKS	ITS NAME	WHAT YOUR FOOT DOES
Ped. ---------- *	**Ped.** ... *	down at Ped., up at the star
Ped. * *Ped.* * *Ped.*	* **Ped.** under each chord	every new Ped. is a change: up, and straight down
	a line with two hooks	down where it starts, up where it ends
	a line with notches	each notch is a change: up and down again
con Ped. · senza Ped.	*con Ped. · senza Ped.*	with the pedal (you choose the changes) · without the pedal
Ped. simile	*Ped. simile*	go on pedalling the same way

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Half pedal and the middle pedal

Half pedal: lift the pedal only part of the way, to clear some of the sound but not all. **Sostenuto** (the middle pedal on grand pianos): press it while notes are held, and only those notes keep ringing.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

Ped.

Hear the ringing.

Play C, E and G together, press the right pedal and take your hands off: the chord keeps sounding. Lift the pedal: silence. That is the dampers coming back down.

HOW TO

Practise the pedal change

1. **Without playing**, say “play, up-down” and move your foot on “up-down”.
2. **Play C-E-G, then F-A-C, then G-B-D**, slowly. Change just after each one.
3. **Listen** for a clean change with no gap of silence.

THINK OF IT The sustain pedal holds a door open: every note that walks in stays until the door shuts.

TRAP

- ✕ Lifting the pedal before the new notes: a gap of silence. Play first, then change.
- ✕ Keeping the pedal down through a new chord: muddy.

SEE ALSO
Touch p. 79 · Chords p. 110

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 7–8 · Online: Library › Pedal

PART III · EXPRESSION · 5

Ornaments

Ornaments are decorations: a small sign that stands for a quick burst of notes around the main note. They borrow the notes **next door**, one letter name up or down: on D, the note above is E and the note below is C.

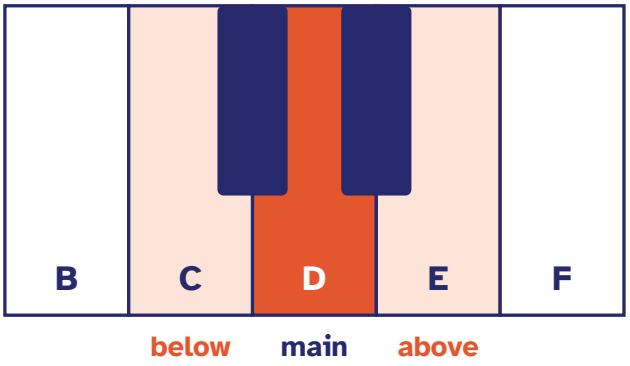
THE SECRET

An ornament is a necklace on the note: it borrows the next-door notes, and the main note still lands on time.
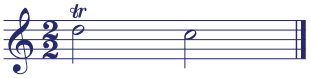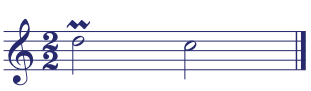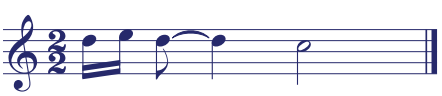


A small sign, a burst of notes

Next-door notes



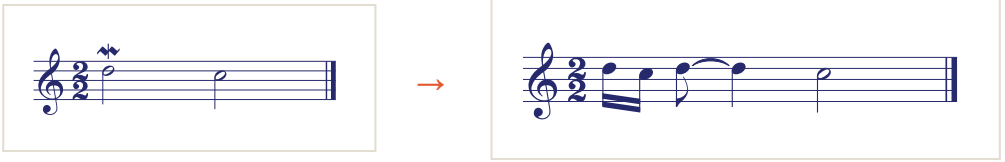
Plain letters on white keys: no sharps or flats unless the music adds one.

Written and played

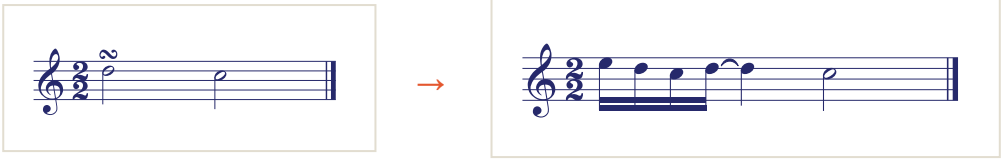
	WRITTEN		PLAYED
trill the note and the one above, back and forth		→	
upper mordent note, above, note: one flick		→	

PART III · EXPRESSION · 5 · CONTINUED

lower mordent
note, below, note

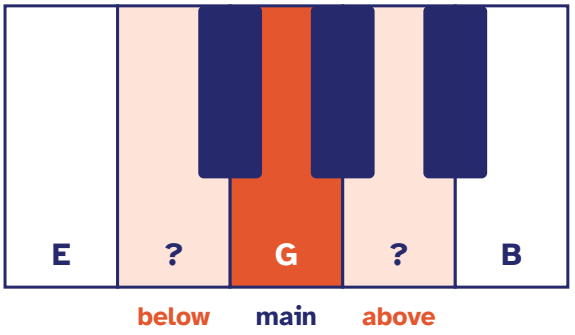


turn
above, note, below, note



EXAMPLE 1

A lower mordent on G

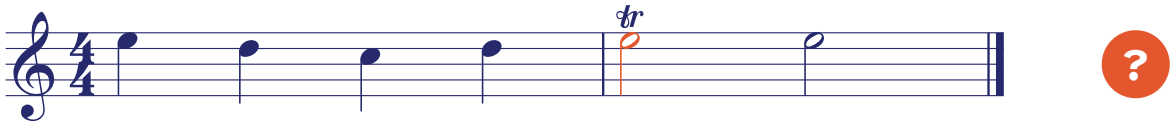


1. **The main note** is G.
2. **A lower mordent** borrows the note next door: above or below?
3. **Play it:** main, next door, main.

The note below G is **F**: **G F G**, one quick flick, then on. (A trill on G would use A, the note above.)

EXAMPLE 2

How do you play this trill?



1. **Which note** has the tr?
2. **Its next-door note above** is...?
3. **Go back and forth** for how long?

On the E: **E F E F...** quickly for its two beats, then the last E on time.

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Where does a trill start?

In music from the 1700s (Bach, Handel), a trill usually starts on the note **above**: F E F E on an E. In later music it starts on the main note. Your teacher or the edition will tell you.

PART III · EXPRESSION · 5 · CONTINUED

Tiny notes before the main note

A tiny note just before the main note borrows a moment from it. **With a slash** it is an **acciaccatura**: crushed in, as fast as you can. **Without a slash** it is an **appoggiatura**: it leans, taking about half the main note's time.

EXAMPLE 3

Crushed, or leaning?



1. **Look for the slash** through the tiny note.
2. **With a slash:** how fast?
3. **Without:** how much time does it take?

Slash (acciaccatura): **crushed in**, almost at once. No slash (appoggiatura): **D for a crotchet**, then C.
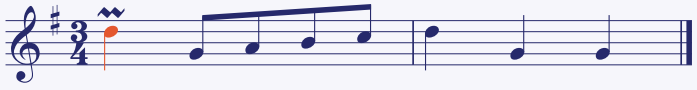
HOW TO

Practise an ornament

1. **Play the main notes** alone first, in time; then **add the ornament slowly**, as written-out notes.
2. **Speed it up** bit by bit, keeping the main note on the beat.

YOU KNOW THIS

Minuet in G (Notebook for Anna Magdalena Bach)



Here the first D is decorated with a **mordent**: D, E, D, one quick flick, then the music walks on in time. The flick borrows from the D; the beat does not move.

Try it. Play the first bar with the mordent, then without it: hear the sparkle it adds.

THINK OF IT Ornaments are like accessories: a necklace or a hair clip makes you look lovely, but you get dressed first. Learn the plain notes in time, then add the ornament.

TRAP

× Starting a trill, mordent or turn before the beat: it begins on the beat. (Only the crushed acciaccatura slips in just before.)

SEE ALSO
The keyboard p. 22 · Sharps, flats and naturals p. 39

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 9–10 · Online: Library › Ornaments

PART III · EXPRESSION · TIPS

When your playing sounds flat

Every note can be right and the music still sound flat. The fix is almost always one sign you read but did not play. Find what you notice, then check that one thing.

TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
Everything is the same loudness	**the dynamics:** is every sign a different step?	p. 76
The tune sounds choppy	**the slurs:** join every note inside the curve	p. 79
Short notes sound heavy	**staccato** is short, not loud	p. 79
The end feels rushed	**rit. and fermata:** slow little by little, then wait	p. 82
The sound is muddy	**the pedal:** change on each new chord	p. 85
The ornament trips the beat	**the main note** lands on time; practise it slowly	p. 88

Four ways to bring music to life

1. **Sing it first**
   Sing the phrase: your voice shapes it naturally. Then copy your voice on the keys.
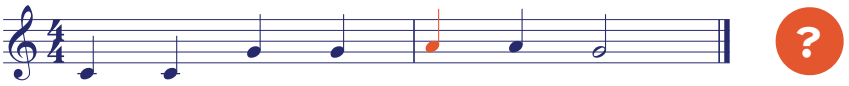
2. **Exaggerate**
   Play the dynamics twice as big as you think. It always sounds smaller to the listener.

3. **Record yourself**
   Listen back with the music: did each sign really happen?

4. **Shape every phrase**
   Grow towards the most important note, then let the phrase fall away.

EXAMPLE

Give this phrase a shape



?

1. **Sing it:** where does it want to go?
2. **Which note** feels like the top of the hill?
3. **Where** would you start soft and end soft?

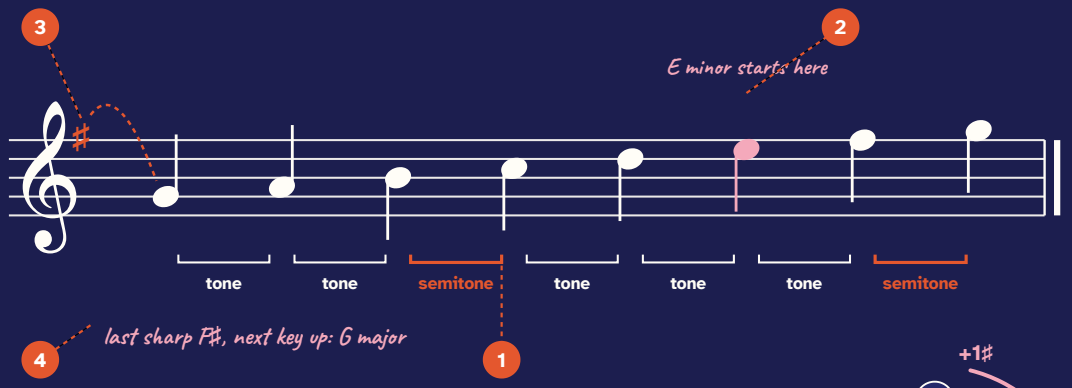
Start soft, grow to the first A, then fade: **a phrase is a hill**, up and down.

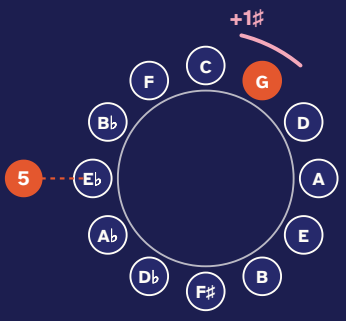
THINK OF IT Expression is the difference between reading a story aloud and telling it.

PART IV · NOTES IN FAMILIES

Scales and keys

Notes travel in families. Build the scales that whole pieces are made from, then learn to read the key a piece lives in: its signature, its home note, its place on the circle. All of it is in one scale.





1 **Major scales** p. 93
T T S T T T S: the two short steps

2 **Minor scales** p. 96
the major with 3, 6 and 7 one key lower

3 **Keys and key signatures** p. 99
the sharps at the start apply all the way

4 **Finding the key** p. 102
last sharp, next key up; second-last flat

5 **The circle of fifths** p. 105
go right: one more sharp each step

★ **Tips: when a note sounds wrong** p. 108

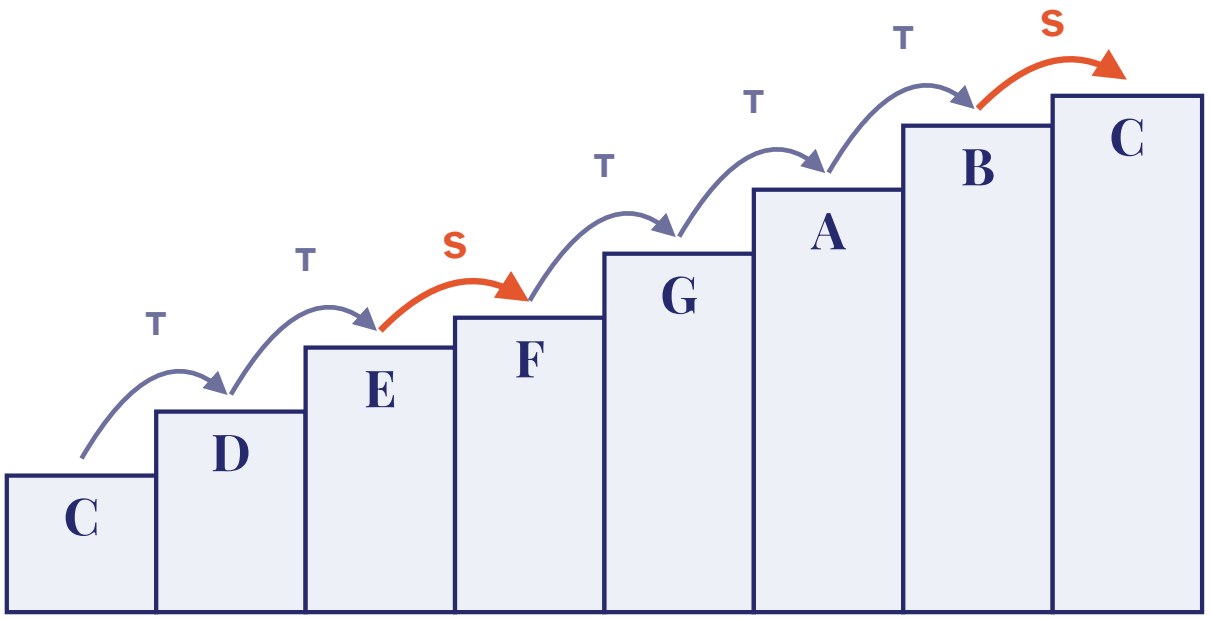
PART IV · SCALES AND KEYS · 1

Major scales

A **scale** climbs from a home note, the **key note**, to the next note with the same name, using every letter once. A **major** scale always takes the same steps, whatever note it starts on.

THE SECRET

Every major scale: tone, tone, semitone, tone, tone, tone, semitone.



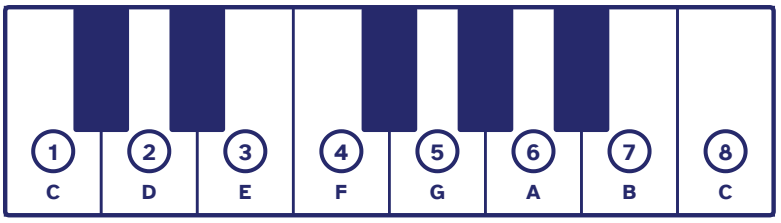
Tone, tone, semitone, tone, tone, tone, semitone

THE RULE

T = tone = one key between. S = semitone = no key between: the very next key, best friends.
Every major scale: T T S T T T S.

EXAMPLE 1

Where are the short steps?



?

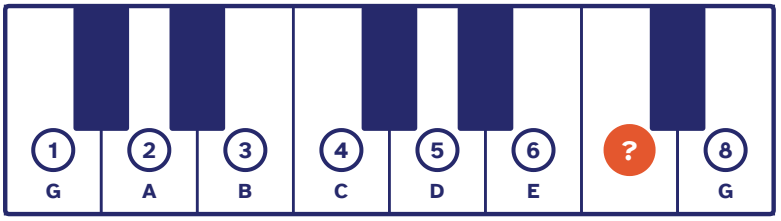
1. **Play C up to C** on the white keys, numbering the notes 1 to 8.
2. **Between each pair,** look for a black key. A key between means a tone.
3. **Which pairs have no black key** between them?

Only **3–4** (E–F) and **7–8** (B–C): nothing between. Those are the two short steps of every major scale.

PART IV · SCALES AND KEYS · 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Build G major

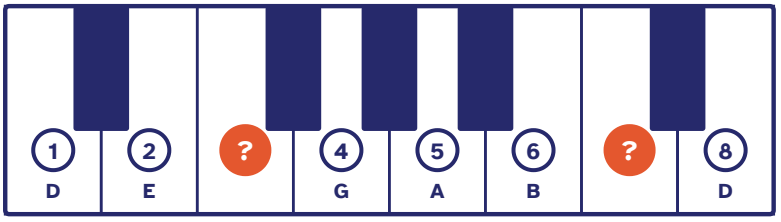


1. **Write the letters** G to G: G A B C D E F G.
2. **Check the top:** 6 to 7 must be T (one key between), 7 to 8 must be S (none between). E to F has nothing between.
3. **Move the ? one key right.** What is it called now?

The **?** becomes **F♯**. G major: G A B C D E F♯ G, one sharp.

EXAMPLE 3

Build D major

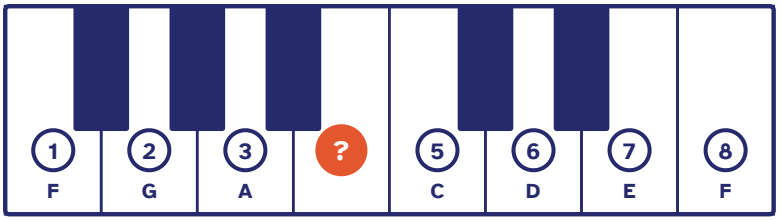


1. **Write the letters** D to D.
2. **Check each step** against T T S T T T S: is there a key between?
3. **Two steps are too short.** Move each ? one key right.

D major: D E **F♯** G A B **C♯** D, two sharps.

EXAMPLE 4

Build F major



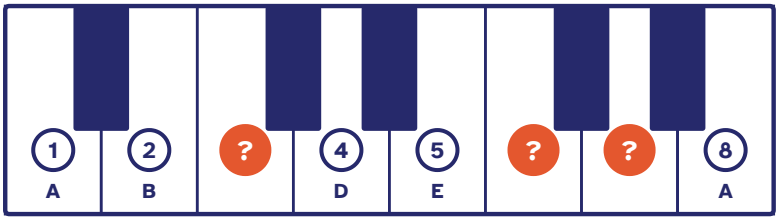
1. **Write the letters** F to F: F G A B C D E F.
2. **Check 3 to 4:** it must be S, nothing between. A to B has a key between: too big.
3. **Move the ? one key left.** What is it called now?

The **?** becomes **B♭**. F major: F G A B♭ C D E F, one flat.

PART IV · SCALES AND KEYS · 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 5

Build A major



1 **Write the letters** A to A.

2 **Check each step:** two are too short and the top one is too big.

3 **Move each ? one key right.**

A major: A B **C♯** D E **F♯** **G♯** A, three sharps.

GAME

Spot the wrong note

1 G A B C D E F G

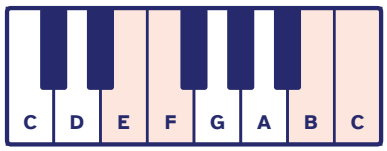
2 D E F♯ G A B C D

3 F G A B C D E F

Each of these major scales has one note that breaks T T S T T T S. Which one, and what should it be?

Answer: 1 F should be F♯ · 2 C should be C♯ · 3 B should be B♭.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS
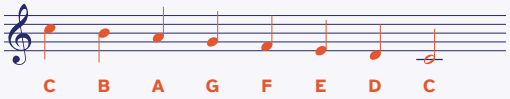


One finger, C to C.

Play the white keys from C up to C and say “tone, tone, semitone, tone, tone, tone, semitone”. Feel the two short steps.

YOU KNOW THIS

Joy to the World



The first line is the **C major scale**, top to bottom: C B A G F E D C.

Try it. Play C major down from the top C and sing “Joy to the world” over it.

TRAP

- × Using the same letter twice: every letter appears once (F♯ in G major, never G♭).
- × Forgetting the short step at the top: 7 to 8 never has a key between.

SEE ALSO

Minor scales p. 96 · Keys and key signatures p. 99

PRACTISE IT

Workbook p. 1 · Online: Library › Scales

PART IV · SCALES AND KEYS · 2

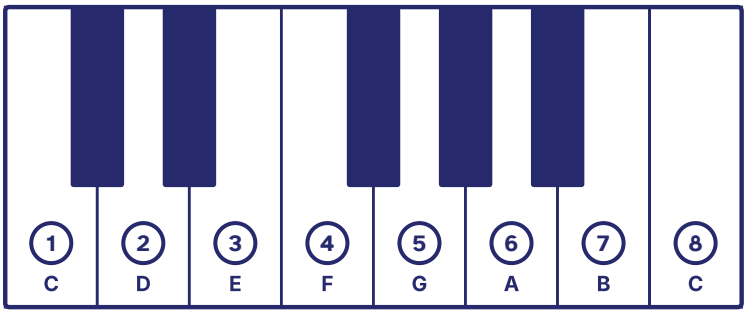
Minor scales

Play C major, then C minor: same home note, but the mood turns darker and more serious. Minor scales come in three versions, and all of them start from the major scale you already know.

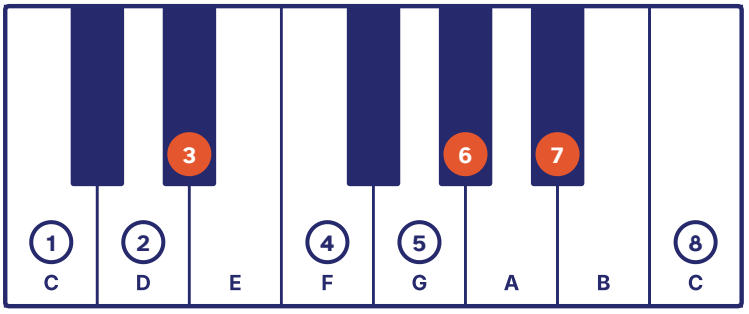
THE SECRET

Minor = the major on the same note with 3, 6 and 7 one key lower.

C major



C minor: 3, 6 and 7 move one key left
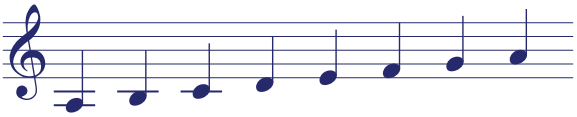


The same home note · three notes one key lower

THE RULE
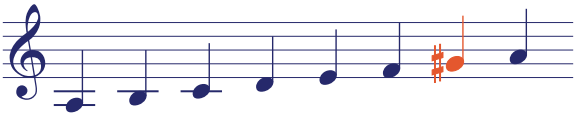
Natural minor = the major with 3, 6 and 7 lowered one key. Harmonic minor = the natural minor with 7 raised again. Melodic minor = going up, 6 and 7 raised; coming down, the natural minor.

A minor in three forms
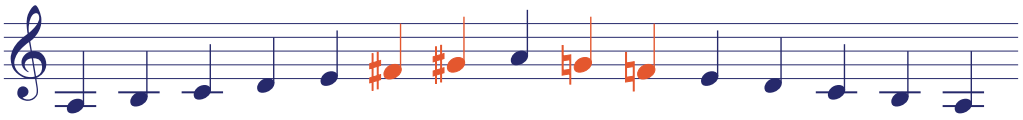


Natural: A major (F♯ C♯ G♯) with 3, 6 and 7 lowered: C, F and G. All white keys.

PART IV · SCALES AND KEYS · 2 · CONTINUED



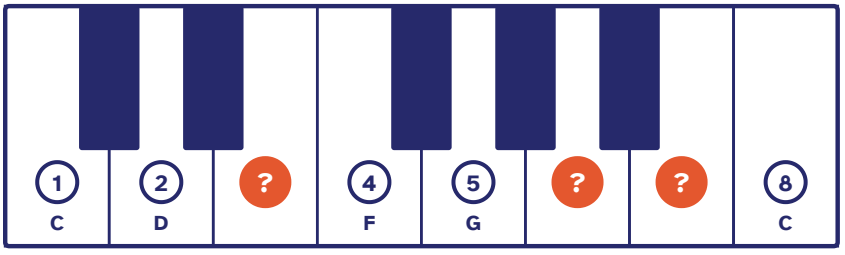
Harmonic: the 7th raised again, one key up: **G♯**.



Melodic: going up, 6 and 7 raised (**F♯ G♯**); coming down, back to **G F**.

EXAMPLE 1

Build C natural minor
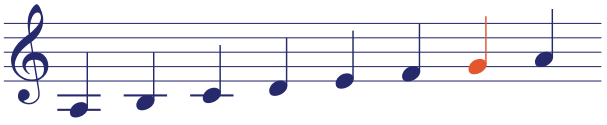


1. **Start from C major:** C D E F G A B C.
2. **The ? keys are 3, 6 and 7.** Move each one key left.
3. **Name the keys you land on.**

C natural minor: C D **E♭** F G **A♭** **B♭** C.

EXAMPLE 2

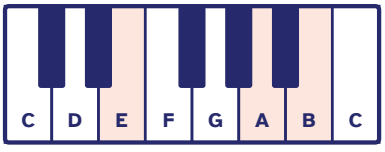
Build A harmonic minor



1. **Start from A natural minor:** A B C D E F G A, all white.
2. **Take note 7** (the ?) and raise it one key.
3. **Name it.**

Note 7 becomes **G♯**: A harmonic minor is A B C D E F G♯ A.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



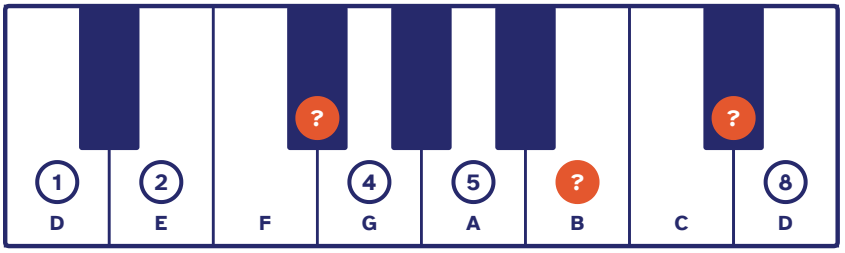
Major, then minor.

Play C major, then play it again with E, A and B one key lower. Same home, new colour: bright, then dark.

PART IV · SCALES AND KEYS · 2 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

Build D natural minor



1 **This is D major.** The ? keys are notes 3, 6 and 7.

2 **Move 3, 6 and 7** one key left each.

3 **Name the new keys.**

D natural minor: D E **F** G A **B♭** **C** D.

GAME

Which minor?

1

nothing raised

2

the 7th raised

3
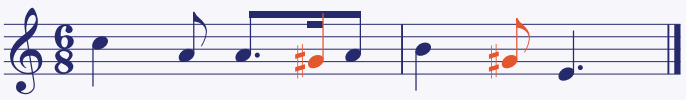
6th and 7th raised going up, lowered coming down

Three forms of the minor scale. Name each one.

Answer: 1 natural · 2 harmonic · 3 melodic.

YOU KNOW THIS

Greensleeves



A minor, with a **G♯**: the raised 7th of the harmonic minor, leaning hard up to A.

Try it. Play it once with G♯, once with G: hear the pull disappear.

TRAP

- × Lowering the wrong notes: only 3, 6 and 7 move.
- × Playing the melodic minor's raised notes on the way down.

SEE ALSO
Major scales p. 93 · Keys and key signatures p. 99

PRACTISE IT
Workbook p. 2 · Online: Library › Scales

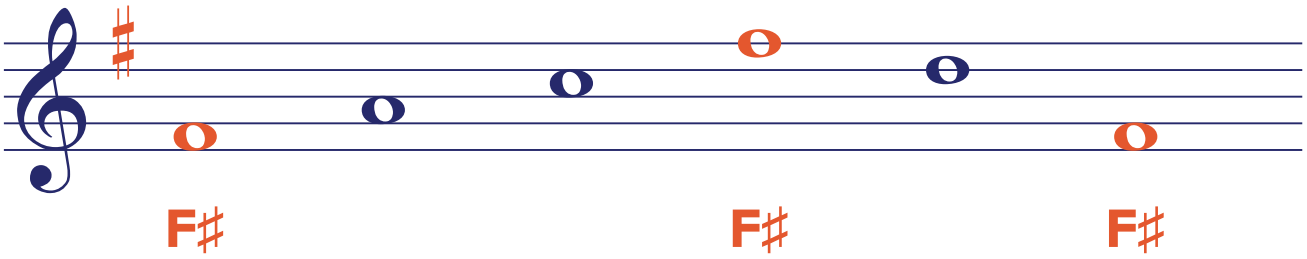
PART IV · SCALES AND KEYS · 3

Keys and key signatures

Why write F♯ fifty times? The **key signature** at the start of each line says it once, for the whole piece. Its sharps or flats always line up in the same order.

THE SECRET

The key signature says once, at the start, which notes are always sharp or flat.



One sharp at the start: every F plays F♯



Sharps always come in this order: F C G D A E B.



Flats: B E A D G C F, the sharps backwards.

To remember the order: **F**ather **C**harles **G**oes **D**own **A**nd **E**nds **B**attle; backwards for the flats: **B**attle **E**nds **A**nd **D**own **G**oes **C**harles' **F**ather.

KEY YOU BUILT	KEY SIGNATURE
C major	none
G major	1♯: F♯
D major	2♯: F♯ C♯
F major	1♭: B♭

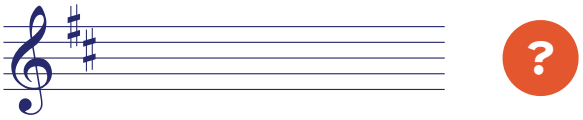
One signature, two keys

Every key signature also belongs to a **minor** key: the **relative minor**. To find it, go **down a minor 3rd**: 2 keys between, then land. C major and A minor share every note: all white keys.

PART IV · SCALES AND KEYS · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Which notes are sharp?

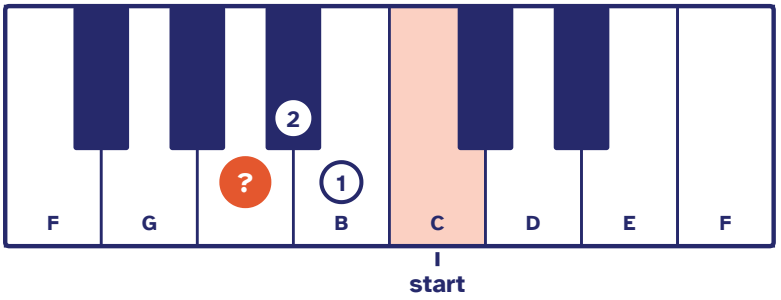


1. **Count the sharps.**
2. **Name them in order:** the first sharp is always F, then ...
3. **Which keys turn black** for the whole piece?

Two sharps, **F♯ and C♯**: every F and every C in the piece, high or low.

EXAMPLE 2

Find the relative minor of C major

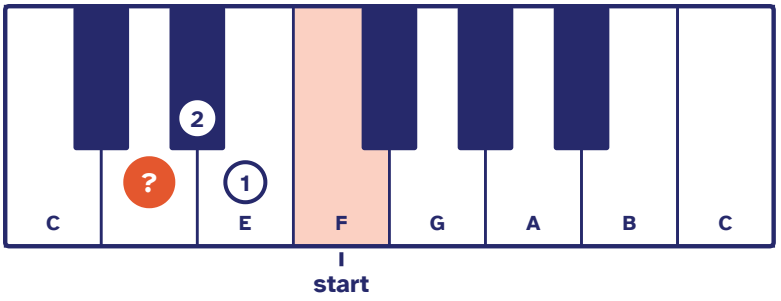


1. **Start on C**, the key note.
2. **Count 2 keys between, going down:** B is 1, B♭ is 2 ...
3. **The next key is the ?.**

You land on **A**: the relative minor of C major is **A minor**.

EXAMPLE 3

Find the relative minor of F major



1. **Start on F.**
2. **Count 2 keys between, going down:** E is 1, E♭ is 2 ...
3. **The next key is the ?.**

The **?** is **D**: D minor, which shares F major's one flat, B♭.

PART IV · SCALES AND KEYS · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 4

Which notes are flat?



1. **Count the flats.**
2. **Name them in order:** the first flat is always B, then …
3. **Which keys turn black?**

Three flats, **B♭ E♭ A♭**: every B, E and A in the piece.

GAME

Which comes next?

1 sharps: F C G …

2 flats: B E …

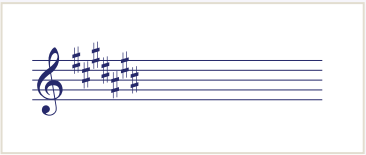
3 the 1st flat

4 the 2nd sharp

Use the orders of sharps and flats.

Answer: 1 D · 2 A · 3 B♭ · 4 C♯.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS
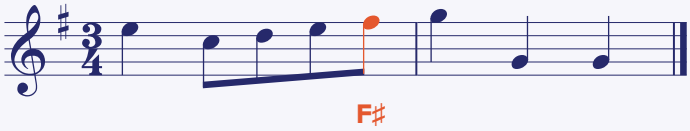


Say the sharps in order.

"Father Charles Goes Down And Ends Battle": F C G D A E B. Then backwards for the flats: B E A D G C F.

YOU KNOW THIS

Minuet in G



One sharp in the key signature: every F is **F♯**, like the one just before the top G. One sharp, and the piece ends on G: **G major**.

Try it. Find every F in the piece and play it as F♯.

THINK OF IT A dress code on a party invitation: written once at the top, it applies to every guest all night. Only an accidental, a word to one guest, overrules it, and only until the bar line.

TRAP

- × Writing a key signature in the wrong order: sharps always F C G D A E B.
- × Reading it once and forgetting it: glance at the key signature at the start of every line.

SEE ALSO

Major scales p. 93 · Finding the key p. 102 · The circle of fifths p. 105

PRACTISE IT

Workbook p. 3 · Online: Library › Keys

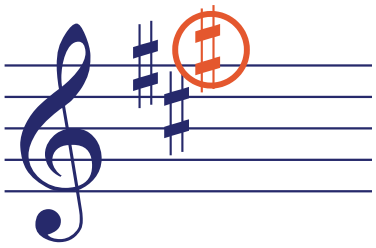
PART IV · SCALES AND KEYS · 4

Finding the key

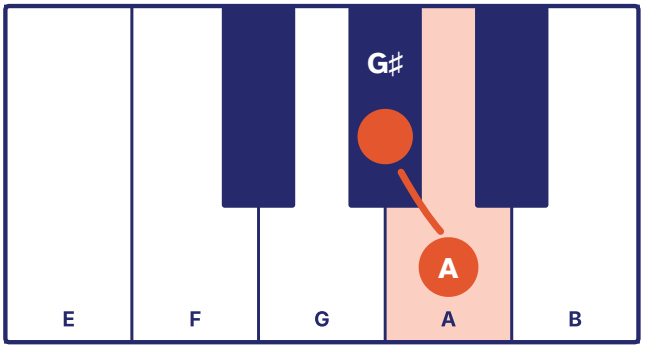
A key signature names two keys, a major and its relative minor. Two quick rules find the major; a minor 3rd down finds the minor; then the music itself tells you which of the two it is.

THE SECRET

Last sharp, then the next key up. Second-last flat: that is the key.



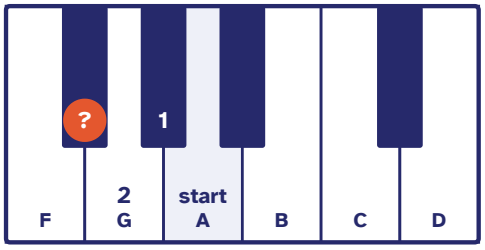
last sharp: G♯



Sharps: the last sharp, then the very next key up. Three sharps: A major



Flats: the second-last flat is the key.
B♭ E♭ A♭: the second-last is E♭, so **E♭ major**. One flat alone is F major.



Major to minor: down a minor 3rd.
From A: 2 keys between, G♯ and G, then land on **F♯**. Three sharps is A major **or** F♯ minor.

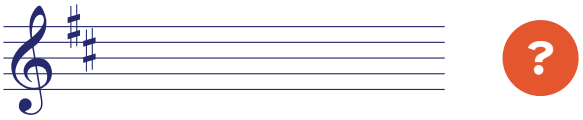
Minor keys and their clue notes

MINOR KEY	SIGNATURE	CLUE NOTE (THE RAISED 7TH)
A minor	none	G♯
E minor	1♯	D♯
D minor	1♭	C♯
B minor	2♯	A♯
G minor	2♭	F♯

PART IV · SCALES AND KEYS · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Name the major key: sharps



1. **Find the last sharp,** the one furthest right.
2. **Name it** (F first, then C ...).
3. **Go to the very next key up.** That is the key.

The last sharp is C♯; the next key up is D: **D major**.

EXAMPLE 2

Name the major key: flats
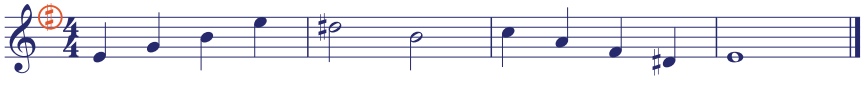


1. **Find the second-last flat.**
2. **Name it** (B first, then E ...).
3. **That flat names the key.**

B♭ E♭: the second-last is B♭: **B♭ major**.

EXAMPLE 3

Major or minor?



1. **The key signature:** one sharp. Which major, and which minor a minor 3rd below it?
2. **Look for a sharp that is not in the signature.** A minor key raises its 7th: whose 7th is it?
3. **Look at the last note.**

One sharp, D♯ clues, ending on E: **E minor**, not G major.

GAME

Name the major key

1	2	3	4
2 sharps	4 sharps	1 flat	3 flats

Sharps: the last sharp, the very next key up. Flats: the second-last flat (one flat alone is F).

Answer: 1 D · 2 E · 3 F · 4 E♭.

PART IV · SCALES AND KEYS · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 4

Find a minor key from its clue



1. **Two flats:** B♭ major, or the minor a minor 3rd below it.
2. **Count 2 keys between going down** from B♭: A, A♭ … and land. Which minor key is it, and what is its 7th note?
3. **Raise that 7th**: if the piece is full of it, the key is minor.

Two flats with F♯ clues: **G minor** (its 7th, F, raised to F♯).

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Three sharps, stop, step up.

Say “F C G”, stop: the last one is G♯. The next key up is A. Three sharps is A major. Try it with two and four.
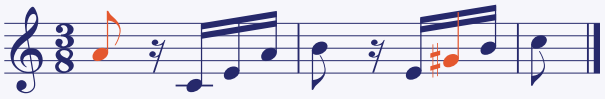
HOW TO

Find the key of a new piece

1. **The key signature:** name the major key, and its relative minor a minor 3rd below.
2. **The clue notes:** look for the minor key’s raised 7th.
3. **The last bass note:** pieces nearly always end on the key note.

YOU KNOW THIS

Für Elise (Beethoven)



No key signature, a G♯ as the clue, and the music keeps coming home to A: **A minor**.

Try it. Play A, then G♯ A: hear the G♯ lean into home.

THINK OF IT Detective work: the key signature narrows it to two suspects; the clue note and the last note name the culprit.

SEE ALSO
Keys and key signatures p. 99 · The circle of fifths p. 105

PRACTISE IT
Workbook p. 4 · Online: Library › Keys

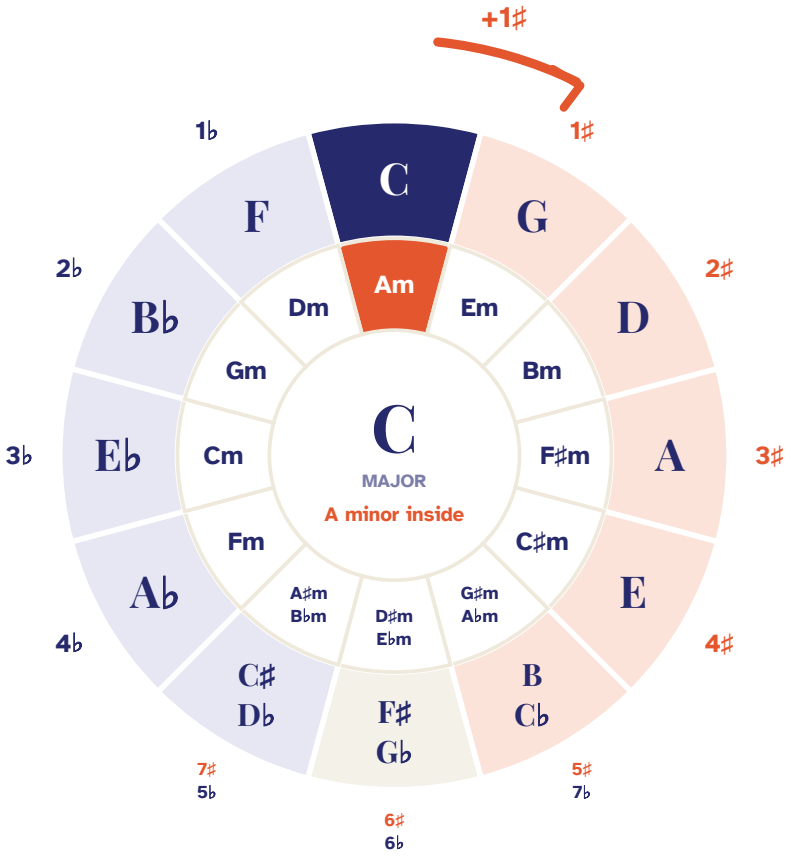
PART IV · SCALES AND KEYS · 5

The circle of fifths

Twelve major keys sit around one clock face, with C at twelve o'clock. Learn to read this clock and you can name any key signature in seconds.

THE SECRET

Go right: one more sharp. Go left: one more flat.



Right: one more sharp · left: one more flat

How to read the clock

Outer ring: the major keys. **Inner ring:** their relative minors. **Outside the circle:** how many sharps or flats.

Neighbours are close

Keys side by side share all but one note, so music moves between them easily: from C major to G major or F major, or to the relative minor.

THE RULE

Each step right is a 5th up: count the notes, C D E F G, and G is the next key round. That is why it is called the circle of fifths.

PART IV · SCALES AND KEYS · 5 · CONTINUED

The first steps round the circle

STEPS	RIGHT (SHARPS)	LEFT (FLATS)
1	G major: F♯	F major: B♭
2	D major: F♯ C♯	B♭ major: B♭ E♭
3	A major: F♯ C♯ G♯	E♭ major: B♭ E♭ A♭

EXAMPLE 1

How many sharps in A major?



1. **Start at C**, at the top: no sharps.
2. **Go right** one step at a time: G, D …
3. **Count the steps** to A.

Three steps right: A major has **three sharps**, F♯ C♯ G♯.

EXAMPLE 2

How many flats in E♭ major?

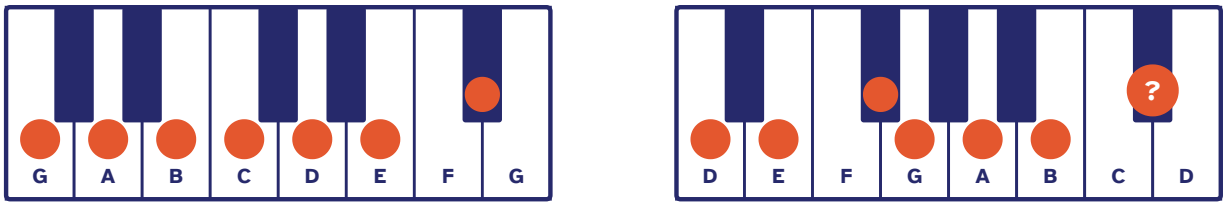


1. **Start at C** again.
2. **Go left:** F, B♭ …
3. **Count the steps** to E♭.

Three steps left: E♭ major has **three flats**, B♭ E♭ A♭.

EXAMPLE 3

Why do G and D sound so close?



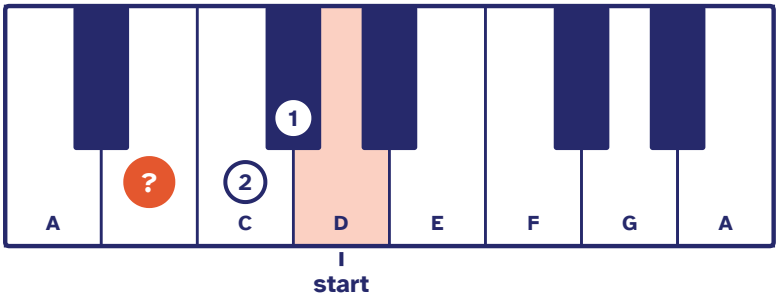
1. **G major** (left) and **D major** (right) are neighbours on the clock.
2. **Compare their notes:** which letters are the same?
3. **Which one letter changes?**

Six notes are the same; only C becomes **C♯**. One step round the circle changes just one note.

PART IV · SCALES AND KEYS · 5 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 4

Find the minor inside D



1. **Start on D**, on the outer ring.
2. **Count 2 keys between, going down:** C♯ is 1, C is 2 …
3. **The next key is the ?.** It sits on the inner ring, just inside D.

The **?** is **B**: B minor, D major's relative minor. Both have two sharps.

GAME

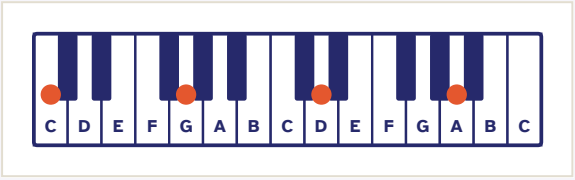
Neighbours on the clock

1	2	3	4
right of D	left of C	opposite C	inside G

Right adds a sharp. Inside each major sits its relative minor.

Answer: 1 A · 2 F · 3 F♯ / G♭ · 4 E minor.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Walk the circle: C G D A.

Play each key note with one finger, a 5th up each time. You just walked three steps right round the circle.

HOW TO

Learn the circle by heart

1. **Right, out loud:** C G D A E B F♯.
2. **Left:** C F B♭ E♭ A♭ D♭ G♭.
3. **Check yourself:** the number of steps from C is the number of sharps or flats.

TRAP

- × Going the wrong way round: right adds sharps, left adds flats.
- × Forgetting the relative minors on the inner ring.

SEE ALSO

Keys and key signatures p. 99 · Finding the key p. 102 · Chords in a key p. 116

PRACTISE IT

Workbook p. 5 · Online: Library › Related keys

PART IV · SCALES AND KEYS · TIPS

When a note sounds wrong

You read the note right, yet it sounds sour. The slip is usually in the key, not the note. Name the slip first, then fix only that note.
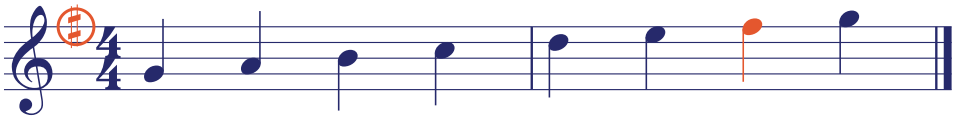
TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
A note sounds sour, though you read it right	**the key signature**: is this note sharp or flat all the way through?	p. 99
A key with many sharps or flats feels lost	**the circle**: go right for a sharp, left for a flat	p. 105
A minor tune sounds wrong near the end	**the raised 7th**: harmonic and melodic minor raise it	p. 96
A scale sounds wrong in the middle	**the short steps** (nothing between): 3–4 and 7–8 in every major scale	p. 93
A sharp is missing from the key signature	**the order of sharps**: F C G D A E B	p. 99
You are not sure which major key it is	**the last sharp**: the key is the very next key up	p. 102

EXAMPLE

Find the slip



1. **Read the key signature:** one sharp, on the top line, F (ringed).
2. **The red note is an F**, so the sharp belongs to it too: every F, high or low.
3. **No natural cancels it**, so this F is F♯, here and all through the piece.

Play **F♯**, the black key. Plain F is the most common slip in G major.

HOW TO

Three checks before you play

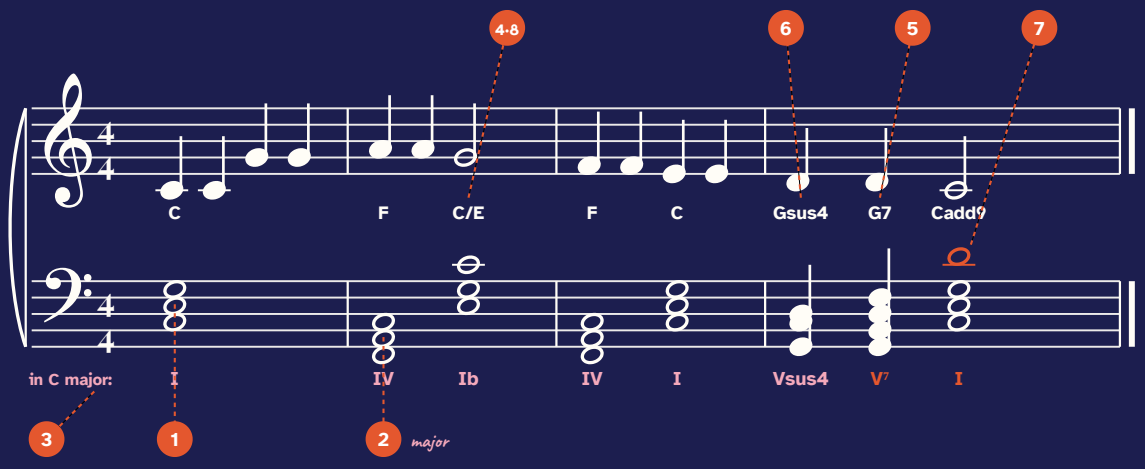
1. **The key signature:** say its sharps or flats aloud.
2. **The key:** name it from the last sharp or the second-last flat, then check the last note.
3. **The scale:** play it once, so your fingers know which black keys belong.

THINK OF IT Like proofreading: a spelling mistake jumps out once you know which words you usually get wrong. Keep a short list of your own slips, and check those first.

PART V · BUILD THEM

Chords

Press three notes at once and you have a chord. Stack them, name them, turn them upside down, add layers on top. Every chapter of this part is in these four bars of Twinkle.



1 **Chords and triads** p. 110
three notes stacked like a layer cake

2 **Four kinds of triad** p. 113
major 3 + 2, minor 2 + 3

3 **Chords in a key** p. 116
Roman numerals: I, IV and V do most of the work

4 **Inversions** p. 119
the same notes, a different one at the bottom

5 **Seventh chords** p. 122
one more layer on top: G7

6 **Colour chords** p. 125
sus and add: a note moved or added

7 **The tower: 9, 11, 13** p. 128
keep skipping a letter

8 **Slash chords** p. 131
C/E: the chord, then the bass note

★ **Tips: when a chord sounds wrong** p. 134

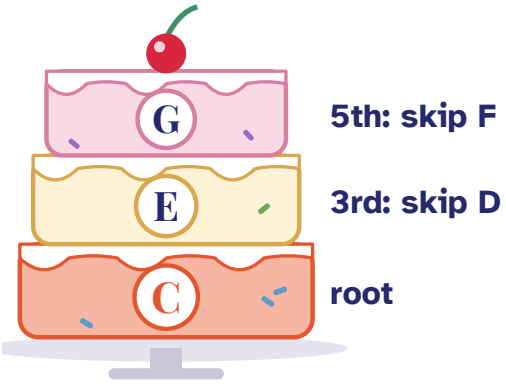
PART V · CHORDS · 1

Chords and triads

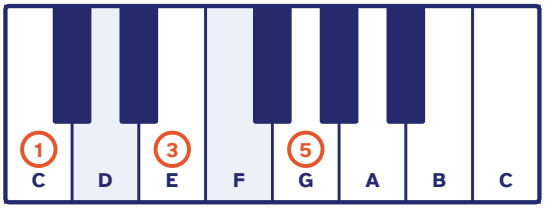
Press three or more notes at once and you have a **chord**. The favourite of all is the **triad**: three notes stacked like a layer cake.

THE SECRET

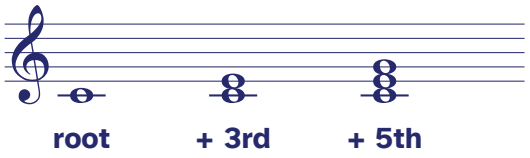
Play one, skip one, play one: the cake rule.



1. Pick a note: the **root**, the big layer at the bottom. It holds the chord up and gives it its name.
2. Skip one letter, take the next: **E**, the **3rd**.
3. Skip again: **G**, the **5th**. C E G is the triad of C.



On the keys: play one, skip one (shaded), play one, skip one, play one.



The cake on the staff: three lines in a row (or three spaces).

On the staff, each layer sits on the **next line up** (or the next space up): the root, a **3rd** above it, a **5th** above the root.

First met: Prelim (the tonic triad of C, G and F major).

All lines or all spaces

A stacked triad sits on **three lines in a row** or in **three spaces in a row**, in a neat stack. If one note breaks the pattern, it is not a stacked triad.



Lines, spaces, lines, spaces: every one a triad.

PART V · CHORDS · 1 · CONTINUED

Solid and broken

Played together, a chord is **solid** (or blocked). Played one note at a time, it is **broken**. Spread up and down the keyboard, a broken chord becomes an **arpeggio**. Left-hand accompaniments, the arpeggios in technical work and the chord names over a song are all triads.

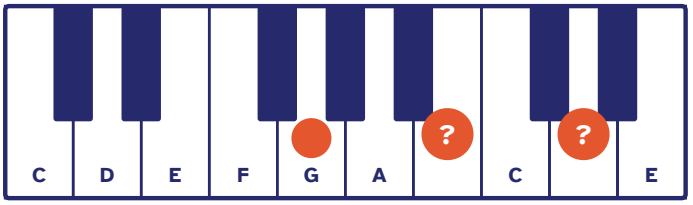
First met: Prelim; arpeggios from Grade 1.



The same three notes, solid then broken.

EXAMPLE 1

Build a triad on G

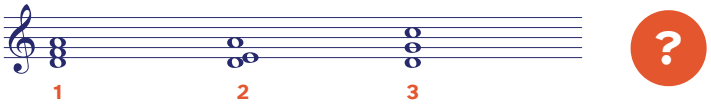


1. **Start on G** (the red dot): the root, the bottom layer.
2. **Skip one white key,** take the next: the first ?.
3. **Skip again,** take the next: the second ?.

G **B D**: the triad of **G**. Same shape as C E G, just moved up.

EXAMPLE 2

Which one is a triad?

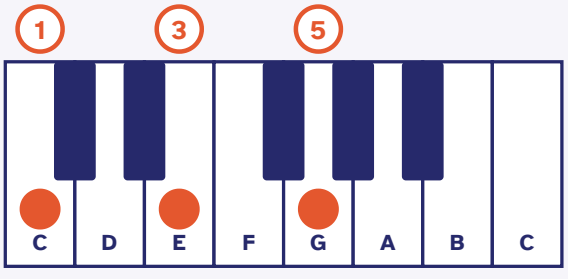


?

1. **Look at each chord:** are the three notes all on lines, or all in spaces?
2. **Count the notes** from each note to the next one up: is every gap a 3rd?
3. **Only one chord** passes both tests. Which?

Chord 1 (D F A, three spaces in a row). Chord 2 has a 2nd (D–E); chord 3 is stacked in 4ths.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Thumb on C. Fingers 1, 3, 5 down together.

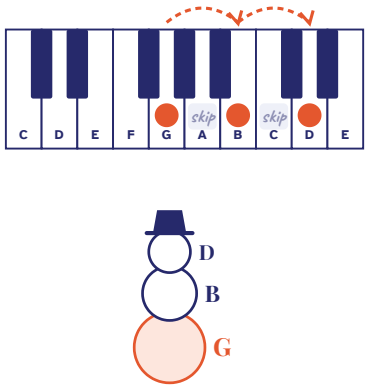
That is the C chord. Slide your hand to any white key and do it again: the cake shape always works.

PART V · CHORDS · 1 · CONTINUED

GAME

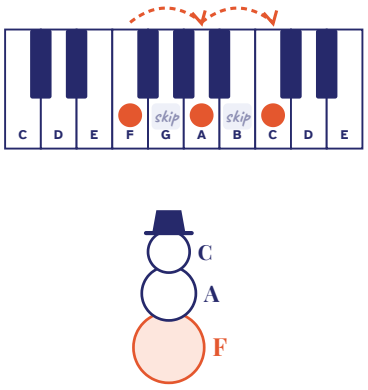
Build one yourself

G



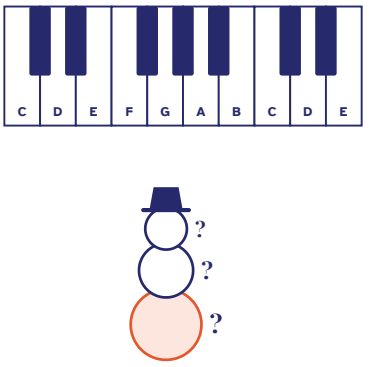
Start on G: **G B D**.

F



Start on F: **F A C**.
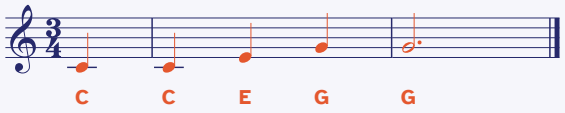
?



Your turn: start on **A**. Which three keys?

Build the cake on A: play one, skip one, play one, skip one, play one.

Answer: A C E: the triad on A.

YOU KNOW THIS

The Blue Danube (Johann Strauss II), here in C



The most famous waltz tune simply climbs the **C triad**: **C, C E G, G**. Root, 3rd, 5th, then it holds the top: that is why it sounds so open.

Try it. Play C E G one at a time, then hum the waltz over it.

THINK OF IT Solid: three friends shout “Hello!” together. Broken: each says it in turn.

TRAP

- × Stacking 2nds or 4ths: a triad skips exactly one letter each time.
- × Naming a chord from its top note: the root names it (at the bottom when the notes are stacked in 3rds).

SEE ALSO
Counting intervals p. 42 · Major scales p. 93

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 1–2 · Online: Library › Chords

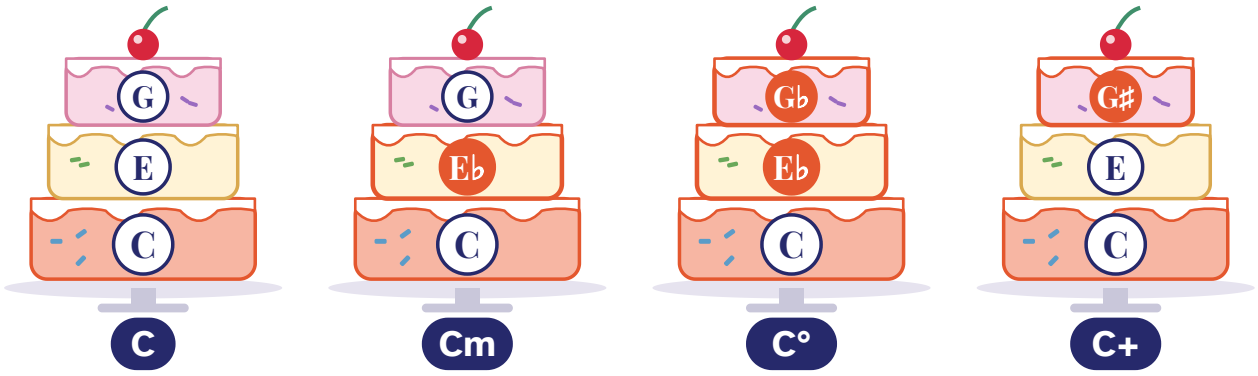
PART V · CHORDS · 2

Four kinds of triad

Every triad is two 3rds stacked. To tell the kinds apart, count the keys **in between**, black and white, that you do not play: root to 3rd, then 3rd to 5th. Those two numbers name the kind, and its sound.

THE SECRET

Count the keys between: 3 + 2 is major, 2 + 3 is minor.

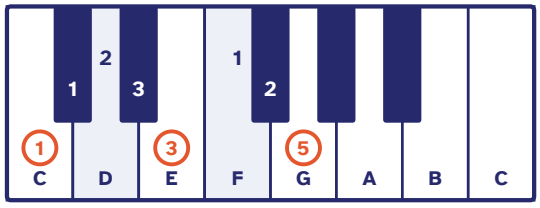


Count the keys between: 3 + 2 is major, 2 + 3 is minor

KIND	KEYS BETWEEN	ON C	CHORD NAME	FIRST MET
major	**3 + 2**	C E G	C	Prelim
minor	**2 + 3**	C E♭ G	Cm	Grade 2
diminished	**2 + 2**	C E♭ G♭	C° or Cdim	Grade 5
augmented	**3 + 3**	C E G♯	C+ or Caug	Grade 6

Chord names: a letter alone means major (C); m means minor (Cm). You see them above the melody in songbooks and lead sheets: C | Am | F | G. In interval names, 3 keys between is a major 3rd and 2 is a minor 3rd (p. 45).

Count the keys in between



Play C and E and count the keys you skip, black and white: C♯, D, D♯ is **3**. Then E to G: F, F♯ is **2**. **3 + 2 is major.** Any root works the same way: from D, skip 3 to F♯, then 2 to A: D F♯ A, D major.

PART V · CHORDS · 2 · CONTINUED

The seven white-key triads, sorted



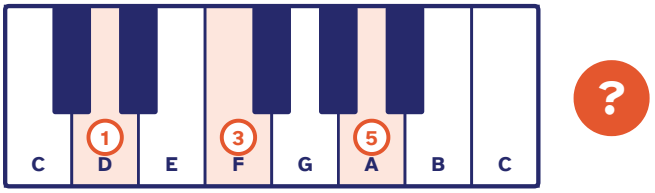
Always the same on the white keys: **three major** (C, F, G), **three minor** (D, E, A), **one diminished** (B), no augmented. Which ones belong to a key is the next chapter (p. 116).

How they sound

KIND	SOUNDS	HEARD IN
major	bright, settled, open	most cheerful tunes, fanfares
minor	darker, softer, sadder	lullabies, laments, film tension
diminished	tense, unstable, wants to move	suspense, spooky scenes
augmented	floating, dreamy, unsettled	dream scenes, a passing colour

EXAMPLE 1

Major or minor? D F A



1. **Root to 3rd:** count the keys between D and F, black and white.
2. **3rd to 5th:** count the keys between F and A.
3. **3 + 2 or 2 + 3?**

D to F has 2 between, F to A has 3: **2 + 3**, so D F A is **D minor** (Dm).

GAME

Which kind?

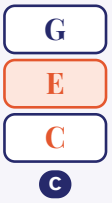
1	2	3
G♭	A	B♯
E♭	F♯	G♯
C	D	E

Count the keys between: 3 + 2 major, 2 + 3 minor, 2 + 2 diminished, 3 + 3 augmented.

Answer: 1 diminished · 2 major · 3 augmented.

PART V · CHORDS · 2 · CONTINUED

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

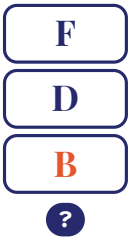


C E G, then C E♭ G, then C E♭ G♭.

Bright, dark, tense. Only the middle layer moves first, then the top one. Listen for the change each time.

EXAMPLE 2

What kind is the triad on B?
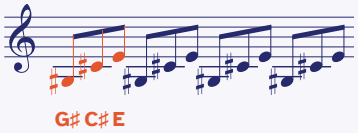


1. **Skip a letter:** B, D, F.
2. **Count the keys between** B and D, then D and F.
3. **Which kind has those two numbers?**

2 + 2: B D F is **B diminished** (B°), the only diminished triad on the white keys.

YOU KNOW THIS

Beethoven, Moonlight Sonata (first movement)



The famous slow triplets are the notes of a **C♯ minor triad**: C♯, E and G♯, rocking gently. Minor is why it sounds so dark and sad.

THINK OF IT Two gaps in the cake: a wide one (3 keys between) and a narrow one (2). Major: wide, then narrow, 3 + 2. Minor: narrow, then wide, 2 + 3. Diminished: two narrow, 2 + 2. Augmented: two wide, 3 + 3.

TRAP

- × Counting the keys you play: count only the keys in between, black and white.
- × Forgetting that in diminished and augmented triads the 5th changes too.
- × Spelling with the wrong letter: a triad skips one letter, so C minor is C E♭ G, never C D♯ G.

SEE ALSO
Chords and triads p. 110 · Major, minor and perfect p. 45

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 3–4 · Online: Library › Chords

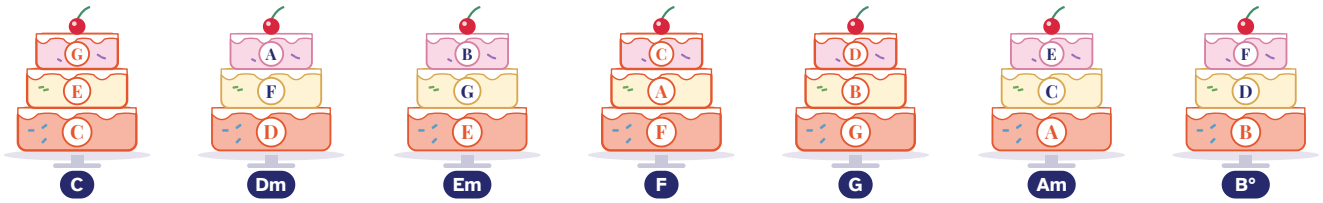
PART V · CHORDS · 3

Chords in a key
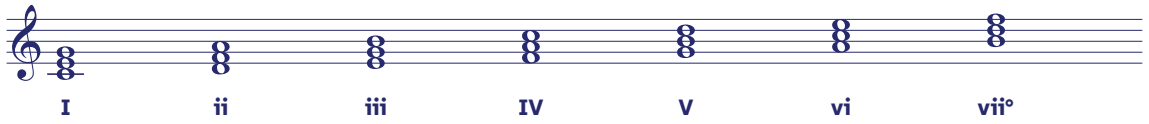
Build a triad on every note of a scale and you have the chords of that key. **Roman numerals** name each one by its place in the scale: I on the 1st note, IV on the 4th, V on the 5th. Capitals are major, small numerals are minor, and small with ° is diminished.

THE SECRET

Build a cake on every note of the scale: I, IV and V are the strongest.



One cake on every note: I, IV and V do most of the work



The seven chords of C major. Only white keys, so the kinds come out as on p. 114.

NUMERAL	NAME	KIND	KEYS BETWEEN	IN C	IN G
I	tonic	major	3 + 2	C	G
ii	supertonic	minor	2 + 3	Dm	Am
iii	mediant	minor	2 + 3	Em	Bm
IV	subdominant	major	3 + 2	F	C
V	dominant	major	3 + 2	G	D
vi	submediant	minor	2 + 3	Am	Em
vii°	leading note	diminished	2 + 2	B°	F♯°

The same in every major key: I, IV and V are major; ii, iii and vi are minor; vii° is diminished. First met: I, IV and V at Grades 1–2; the other chords from about Grade 4.

The three primary chords
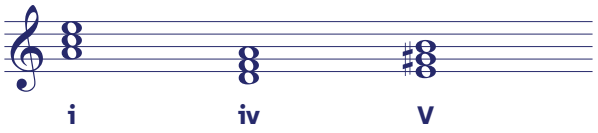
I, IV and V are the strongest chords of a key. Between them they hold **every note of the scale**: C E G, F A C, G B D. That is why so many tunes need only these three.

THINK OF IT I is the key's own chord. IV and V are its two big neighbours. Between the three of them, every note of the scale has a chord to sit in.

PART V · CHORDS · 3 · CONTINUED

In a minor key

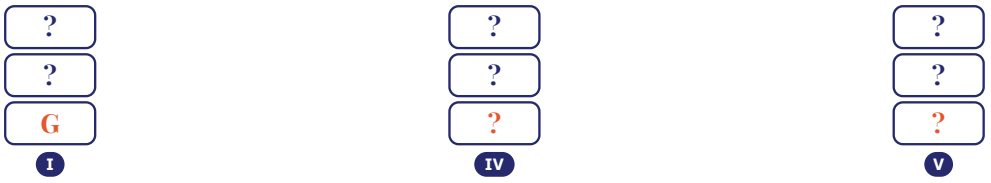
In A minor the three main chords are **i** (A minor), **iv** (D minor) and **V**: E G♯ B, made major by the **raised 7th** of the harmonic minor (p. 96), G♯. Check: E G♯ B is 3 + 2, major.



A minor: i, iv and V. The G♯ makes V major.

EXAMPLE 1

Find I, IV and V in G major



1. **Count up the scale** from G: which notes are 1st, 4th and 5th?
2. **Build a cake on each,** using the key signature (one sharp: F♯).
3. **Check the keys between:** are all three 3 + 2?

In G major: **I = G** (G B D), **IV = C** (C E G), **V = D** (D F♯ A), all major.

GAME

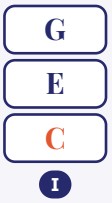
Which numeral?



All in C major. Count up the scale from C to find each chord's number.

Answer: 1 IV · 2 V · 3 vi · 4 ii.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



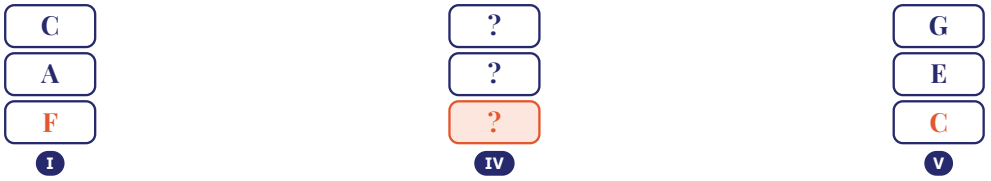
Left hand: C, F, G.

Play the cakes of I, IV and V in C major, then sing any nursery tune over them: these three fit almost every note.

PART V · CHORDS · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Find IV in F major



1. **Count up the scale** from F to the 4th note. Watch the key signature: one flat.
2. **Build the cake** on that note.
3. **Check the keys between.**

IV in F major is **B♭**: B♭ D F, 3 + 2, major.

EXAMPLE 3

Find V in D minor



1. **The 5th note** of D minor is A: build A C E.
2. **The 7th note** of the D minor scale is C. In the harmonic minor it is raised: to what?
3. **Put it in the middle layer.** What kind is the chord now?

C becomes **C♯**: V in D minor is A C♯ E, **A major**.

EXAMPLE 4

The chord on note 6 of C major



1. **Build the cake on A:** skip one, take the next, twice.
2. **Count the keys between:** major or minor?
3. **Note 6 of the scale:** which numeral, capital or small?

A C E, 2 + 3: **A minor**, numeral **vi** (small, because it is minor).

TRAP

- × Writing every numeral big: ii, iii and vi are minor, so they are written small.
- × Forgetting the raised 7th in a minor key: V in A minor is E G♯ B, not E G B.

SEE ALSO
Four kinds of triad p. 113 · Major scales p. 93 · Inversions p. 119

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 5–6 · Online: Library › Chords

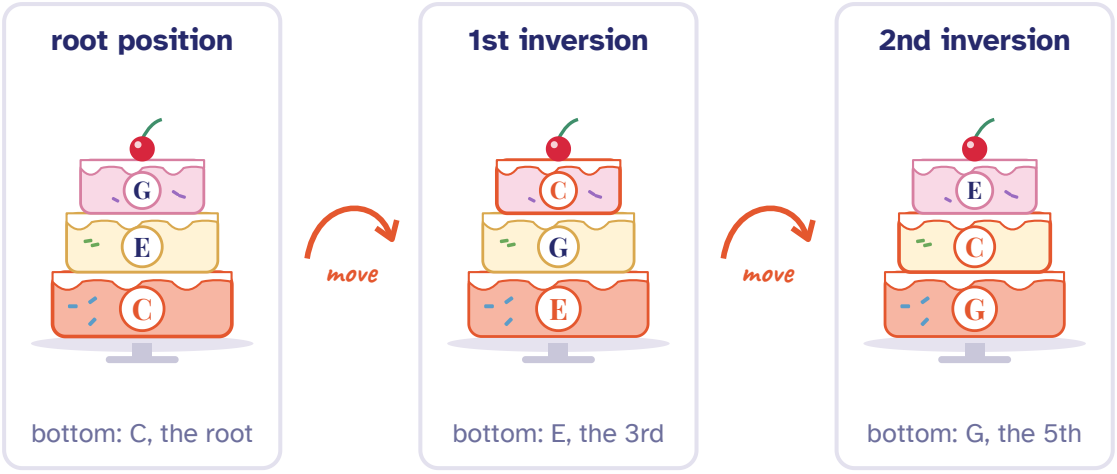
PART V · CHORDS · 4

Inversions
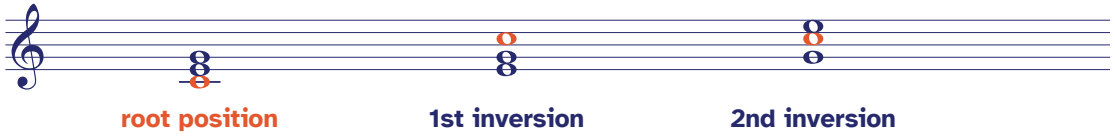
Same three notes, a different one at the bottom. The chord keeps its name; only the bass changes. The red layer is the root, C: watch it travel.

THE SECRET

Move the bottom note to the top: same chord, new bass.



1. Start with the cake **C E G**: root at the bottom.
2. Move the bottom layer to the top: **E G C**. That is the 1st inversion.
3. Move it again: **G C E**, the 2nd inversion. Still **C major**.



The same three chords on the staff; the red note is the root, C. To find the root, restack the notes every other letter (like C E G): then the bottom layer is the root.

Why inversions?

They let your hand **move as little as possible**: keep any note two chords share, and move the others to the nearest note of the next chord. Left-hand accompaniments and hymn parts are written this way.

GAME

Which position?

1	2	3
C E G	E G C	G C E

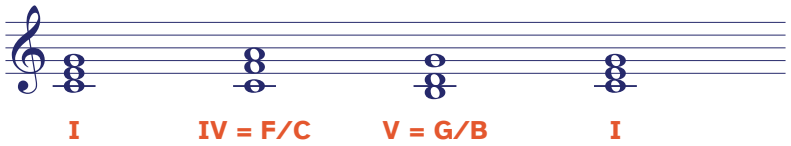
Same three notes. Look at the bottom one: root, 3rd or 5th?

Answer: 1 root position · 2 first inversion (E at the bottom) · 3 second inversion (G at the bottom).

PART V · CHORDS · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Move as little as possible: C, F, G, C



1. **I:** C E G. **IV:** keep C, move E up to F and G up to A: C F A.
2. **V:** no shared note. C steps down to B, F down to D, A down to G: B D G.
3. **I again:** B up to C, D up to E, G stays: C E G.

F stands on C, G stands on B: **inversions** keep the hand in one place.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Climb the chord.

Play C E G, then E G C, then G C E, then C E G an octave up. Same cake, changing its bottom layer as it climbs.

EXAMPLE 2

Write F major in first inversion



1. **Build F major** in root position first.
2. **First inversion:** which layer goes to the bottom, the 3rd or the 5th?
3. **Stack the other two** above it, in order.

The 3rd, A, goes to the bottom: **A C F**.

EXAMPLE 3

Find the second inversion of G



1. **Build G major:** skip one, take the next, from G.
2. **Second inversion:** the 5th goes to the bottom.
3. **Stack the other two** above it.

The 5th, D, at the bottom: **D G B**.

PART V · CHORDS · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 4

Find the root of E G C



1. **Restack the notes** so that each skips one letter: try starting on each note.
2. **Which order works?** C E G, E G C or G C E?
3. **The bottom layer** of that stack is the root.

C E G works: the root is **C**. E G C is C major, 1st inversion.

EXAMPLE 5

Which position? A D F
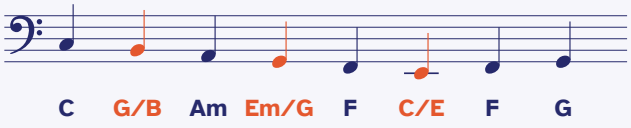


1. **Restack it** so each note skips one letter.
2. **Find the root** (the bottom layer of the stack) and the kind.
3. **Which layer is at the bottom** of A D F: root, 3rd or 5th?

Restacked: D F A, **D minor**. A, the 5th, is at the bottom: **2nd inversion**.

YOU KNOW THIS

Pachelbel's Canon, the bass (here in C)



In the popular version the bass walks **straight down the scale**: C B A G F E. It can, because some chords are **inversions**: G stands on B, Em on G, C on E.

Try it. Play the bass slowly and hum the famous violin tune over it.

TRAP

- × Naming a chord from its bass note: in an inversion the bass is not the root. Restack it in 3rds first.
- × Thinking an inversion is a new chord: E G C is still C major.

SEE ALSO

Chords and triads p. 110 · Chords in a key p. 116 · Slash chords p. 131

PRACTISE IT

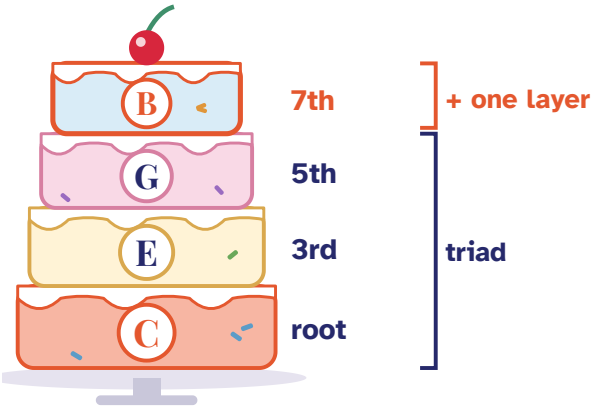
Workbook pp. 7–8 · Online: Library › Chords

PART V · CHORDS · 5

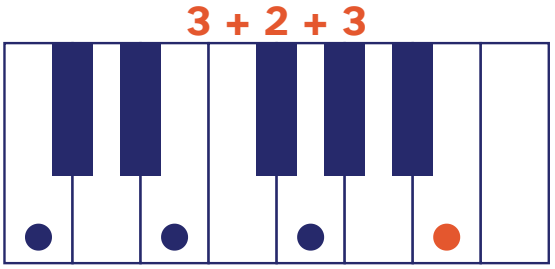
Seventh chords

Three notes make a plain chord. Add one more note on top and it can sound dreamy, bluesy or spooky. The new note is the **7th**.

THE SECRET
One more layer on the cake and the chord changes colour.

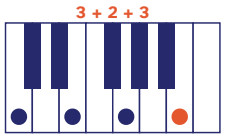


1. Build the triad: **C E G**.
2. Skip one, add the next: **B**.
3. Count the keys between: **3 + 2 + 3**. That is **Cmaj7**.



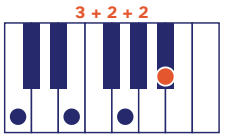
Five flavours, all on C

Cmaj7



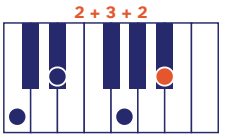
C E G B
dreamy
bossa nova, film

C7



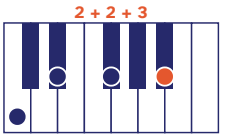
C E G B♭
bluesy
the blues

Cm7



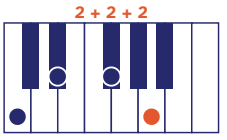
C E♭ G B♭
mellow
soul, jazz ballads

Cø7



C E♭ G♭ B♭
searching
jazz, film noir
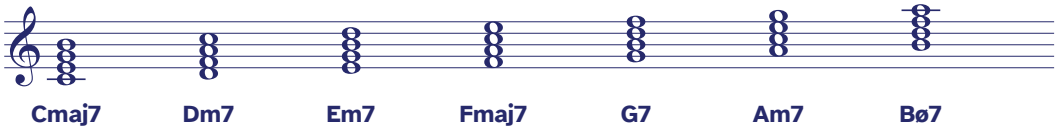
C°7



C E♭ G♭ B𝄫
spooky
old film villains

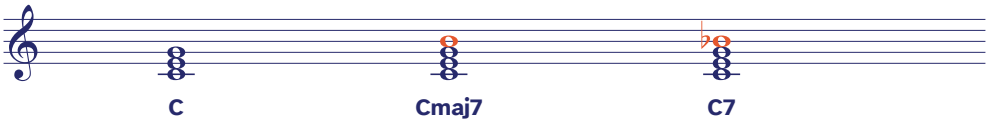
How the names work: major triad + major 7th = **maj7** · major triad + minor 7th = **7**, the **dominant 7th** (C7 is said “C seven” or “C dominant seventh”: in a key it sits on the 5th note, the dominant, as V7) · minor triad + minor 7th = **m7** · diminished triad + minor 7th = **ø7** · diminished triad + diminished 7th = **°7**.

A seventh on every note of C major



Only white keys: count the keys between to name each one.

PART V · CHORDS · 5 · CONTINUED

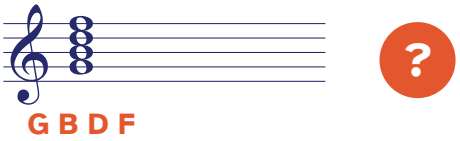


One note decides: B makes Cmaj7, B♭ makes C7. Everything below stays the same.

Spot the difference

EXAMPLE 1

Which seventh is it? G B D F



1. **Count the keys between** each layer: G to B, B to D, D to F.
2. **Which of the five flavours** has those three numbers?
3. **The root is G.** Name the chord.

3 + 2 + 2, the bluesy one, on G: **G7**.

GAME

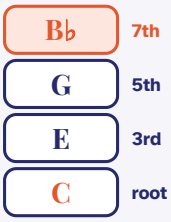
Which seventh?

1	2	3
F A C E	C E G B♭	D F A C

A cake with one more layer. Name each chord.

Answer: 1 Fmaj7 · 2 C7 · 3 Dm7.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Play C7, then Cmaj7.

C E G B♭, then C E G B. One key changes the top layer: bluesy, then dreamy.

PART V · CHORDS · 5 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Cmaj7 or C7: which note changes?

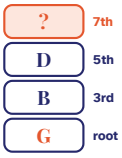


1. **Both start with C major:** C E G.
2. **Compare the top layers.** Which one note is different?
3. **Count the keys between** G and the top layer in each.

Only the top layer changes: **B** (3 between) is Cmaj7, **B♭** (2 between) is C7.

EXAMPLE 3

Build G7

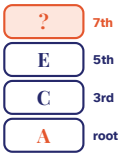


1. **Build G major:** G B D.
2. **Skip one more letter** above D: which?
3. **Count the keys between** D and it: 2 (the bluesy 7) or 3 (maj7)?

G B D **F**: 3 + 2 + 2, so it is **G7**.

EXAMPLE 4

Build Am7



1. **Build A minor:** A C E (2 + 3).
2. **Add the next letter** but one above E.
3. **Count the keys between** E and the new layer.

A C E **G**: 2 + 3 + 2, so it is **Am7**.

TRAP

- × Writing C7 when you mean Cmaj7: "7" alone means the bluesy one, with B♭.
- × Stacking the 7th from the wrong note: count a 7th up from the root, not from the 5th.

SEE ALSO
Four kinds of triad p. 113 · Chords in a key p. 116

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 9–10 · Online: Library › Chords

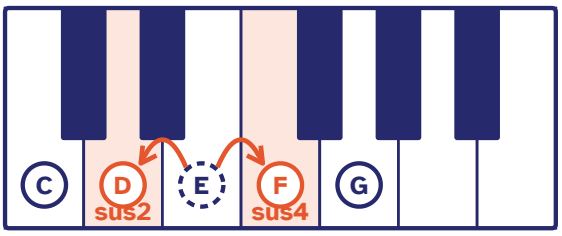
PART V · CHORDS · 6

Colour chords

The 3rd is the chord's mood switch: major or minor, happy or sad. But chords have more colours than happy and sad.

THE SECRET

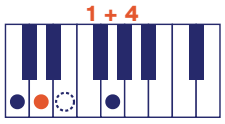
Move the 3rd, take it away, or add one note: five new colours.



1. Start from **C E G**. The **E** (the 3rd) makes it major.
2. Slide the E up to the next letter, **F**: **Csus4**.
3. Or down to the letter below, **D**: **Csus2**. With no 3rd, the chord is neither major nor minor: it **hangs in the air**.

Five colours, all on C

Csus2

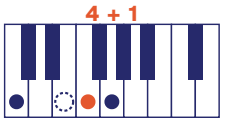


C D G

open

the 3rd steps down

Csus4

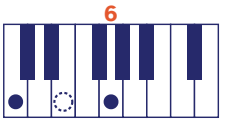


C F G

floating

the 3rd steps up

C5

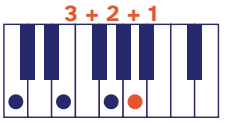


C G

strong

no 3rd at all

C6

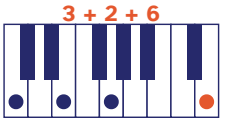


C E G A

warm

add the 6th

Cadd9

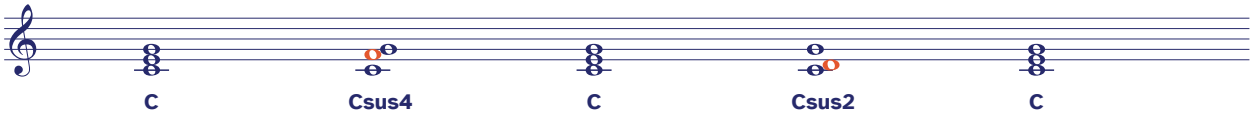


C E G D

sparkly

add the 9th on top

Lean, then slide back



The red note leans, then slides back to E: F steps down, D steps up. Play it slowly: C, Csus4, C, Csus2, C. Guitarists love this shimmer.

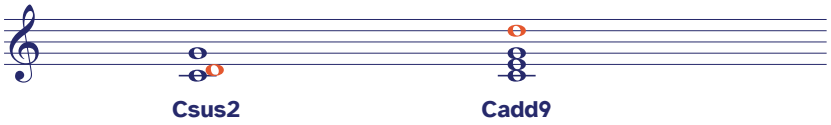
On any root, the counts stay the same

COLOUR	KEYS BETWEEN	ON C	ON G	ON F	ON D
sus2	1 + 4	C D G	G A D	F G C	D E A
sus4	4 + 1	C F G	G C D	F B♭ C	D G A
5	6	C G	G D	F C	D A
6	3 + 2 + 1	C E G **A**	G B D **E**	F A C **D**	D F♯ A **B**
add9	3 + 2 + 6	C E G **D**	G B D **A**	F A C **G**	D F♯ A **E**

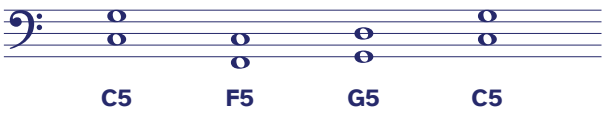
PART V · CHORDS · 6 · CONTINUED

sus: the 3rd held up or down · **5**: no 3rd at all · **6** and **add9**: one note added on top. Csus means Csus4.

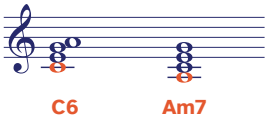
Spot the difference



The same red D, two jobs. Csus2 throws the E out; Cadd9 keeps the E and puts the D on top.



The power chord: just the root and the 5th, played low in the left hand. With no 3rd it is neither happy nor sad, only **strong**: the sound of rock guitar. Play C5, F5, G5, C5 and drum the rhythm.



C6 or Am7? The same four notes, C E G A. The red bottom note decides: C at the bottom is **C6**; A at the bottom is **Am7**. More on the bass note in Slash chords, p. 131.

EXAMPLE 1

Which colour is it? G C D



1. **Count the keys between:** G to C, then C to D.
2. **Find the card** with the same two numbers.
3. **Is there a 3rd (B)?** What has taken its place?

4 + 1, no B: G C D is **Gsus4**. Swap the C for **B** and you have G major.

GAME

sus2, sus4 or add9?

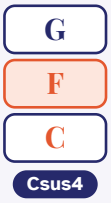
1	2	3
C D G	C F G	C E G D

In a sus chord the 3rd has moved; in an add chord nothing moved and a note was added.

Answer: 1 Csus2 · 2 Csus4 · 3 Cadd9.

PART V · CHORDS · 6 · CONTINUED

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

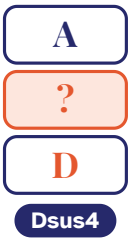


Csus4, then C.

Play C F G, then C E G. No 3rd, then a 3rd: floating, then bright.

EXAMPLE 2

Build Dsus4

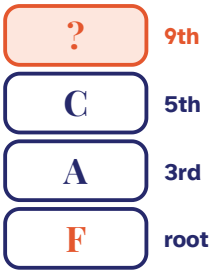


1. **Start with D major:** D F♯ A.
2. **sus4:** move the middle layer up to the next letter.
3. **Which key is it?**

F♯ moves up to **G**: Dsus4 is **D G A**.

EXAMPLE 3

Build Fadd9



1. **Start with F major:** F A C, and keep every note.
2. **The 9th** is the 2nd, an octave up: which letter comes just after F?
3. **Put it on top.**

Fadd9: F A C **G**. Nothing moved; one note was added.

THINK OF IT Decorating the cake: a ribbon (the 6th) or a candle (the 9th) and it is still the same cake. Sus moves its middle layer; a power chord takes the middle layer out.

TRAP

× Calling Cadd9 a ninth chord: C9 also has the 7th (B♭). Add9 is just the triad plus the 9th (D on C), nothing else (The tower, p. 128).

SEE ALSO
Four kinds of triad p. 113 · Seventh chords p. 122

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 11–12 · Online: Library › Chords

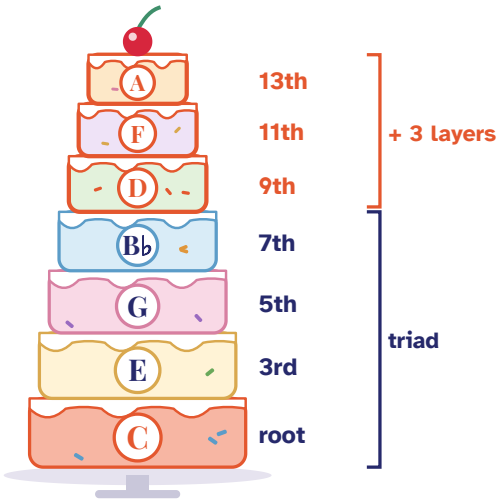
PART V · CHORDS · 7

The tower: 9, 11, 13

Why stop at the 7th? Keep stacking 3rds and the cake grows three more layers: the 9th, the 11th and the 13th. At the top you have used **all seven letters, A to G**.

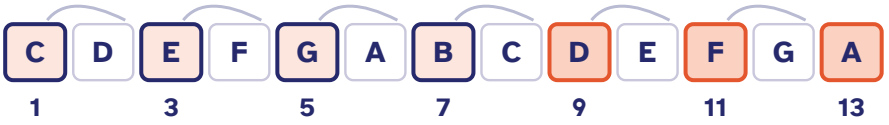
THE SECRET

Keep skipping letters above the 7th: 9, 11, 13 are 2, 4, 6 an octave up.



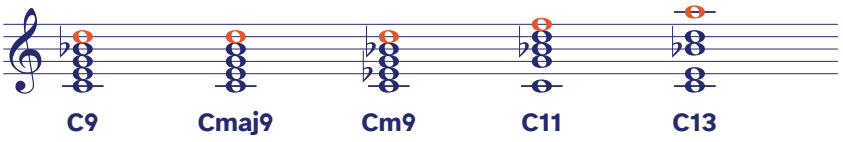
1. Build the seventh chord: **C E G B♭** (C7).
2. Keep skipping one letter: **D**, **F**, **A**. Those layers are the **9th, 11th and 13th**.
3. Take 7 away to find the letter: 9 → 2nd (D), 11 → 4th (F), 13 → 6th (A). Same letters, an octave up.

Skip a letter, all the way up



Start on C and take every other letter: C E G B D F A (letters only: in C7 the B is B♭). After the 13th comes C again: the tower is full.

Five tall chords on C

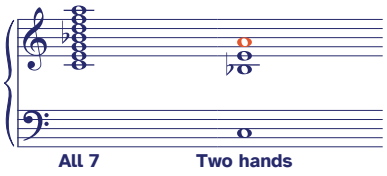


The red note is the top layer that gives each chord its name. C11 and C13 leave some notes out: see p. 129.

CHORD	BUILT AS	NOTES	SOUNDS	HEARD IN
C9	C7 + 9th	C E G B♭ **D**	soulful	funk, soul
Cmaj9	Cmaj7 + 9th	C E G B **D**	dreamy	film, ballads
Cm9	Cm7 + 9th	C E♭ G B♭ **D**	smooth	neo-soul, R&B
C11	C9 + 11th, no 3rd	C G B♭ D **F**	airy	gospel, pop
C13	C7 + 13th	C E B♭ (D) **A**	rich	jazz, blues endings

PART V · CHORDS · 7 · CONTINUED

Too many notes? Leave some out



All seven notes sound muddy. Two hands play C13 with four: C in the left hand, B♭ E A in the right.

Ten fingers, seven layers: you choose. **Keep** the 3rd and the 7th (they say what kind of chord it is) and the red top note (its colour). **Leave out** the 5th first. The right hand can drop the root too, when the left hand or a bass player plays it.

With a major 3rd, the 11th (F) rubs against E. So C13 leaves out the F. C11 does the opposite: it keeps the F and leaves out the E.

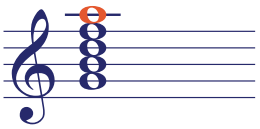
6 or 13? add9 or 9?

SAME TOP NOTE	WITHOUT THE 7TH	WITH THE 7TH (B♭)
A on C	**C6**: C E G A	**C13**: C E B♭ A
D on C	**Cadd9**: C E G D	**C9**: C E G B♭ D

Look for the 7th. No 7th: a colour chord (p. 125). A 7th: a tower chord.

EXAMPLE 1

Name this tall chord: G B D F A



G B D F A

1. **Find the root:** each note skips one letter, so the bottom note is the root.
2. **The first four layers:** count the keys between. Which seventh?
3. **The red top layer:** which number is it above G?

G7 (3 + 2 + 2) with A, the 9th, on top: **G9**.

GAME

Which floor?

1 — the 9th of C

2 — the 11th of C

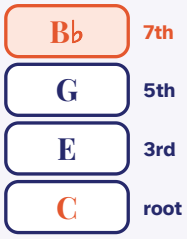
3 — the 13th of C

Build C7 (C E G B♭), then keep skipping one letter above the B♭.

Answer: 1 D · 2 F · 3 A.

PART V · CHORDS · 7 · CONTINUED

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

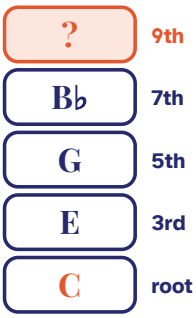


Play C7, then add one more.

Left hand C E G, right hand B♭, then add the next letter but one above it. You just built a tall chord.

EXAMPLE 2

Build C9



1. **Build C7:** C E G B♭.
2. **Skip one more letter** above B♭: which letter?
3. **Five notes:** share them between the hands if you need to.

C9: C E G B♭ **D**, one layer above the 7th.

HOW TO

Build any tall chord

1. **Start on the root** and skip one letter each time: 1 3 5 7 9 11 13.
2. **Stop** at the number in the name.
3. **Leave out** the 5th first; in a 13th chord, the 11th too, when it is too many notes for your hands.

THINK OF IT You don't need every layer. Keep the 3rd and the 7th, which say what kind of chord it is, and the top layer, which gives it its colour.

TRAP

- × Hunting far up for the 9th: it is just the 2nd, an octave higher (D on C).
- × Calling C13 a C6: the 13th chord has the 7th (B♭) as well.
- × Playing F and E together in C13 or C11: they clash. C13 drops the F; C11 drops the E.

SEE ALSO
Seventh chords p. 122 · Colour chords p. 125

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 13–14 · Online: Library › Chords

PART V · CHORDS · 8

Slash chords

C/E means one chord with a chosen bass note: play a C chord, with E as the lowest note. It is not a fraction, and not two chords.

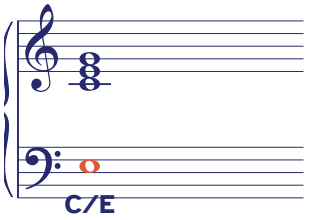
THE SECRET
Chord before the slash, bass note after it.

C/E

the chord
right hand

the bass
left hand, lowest note

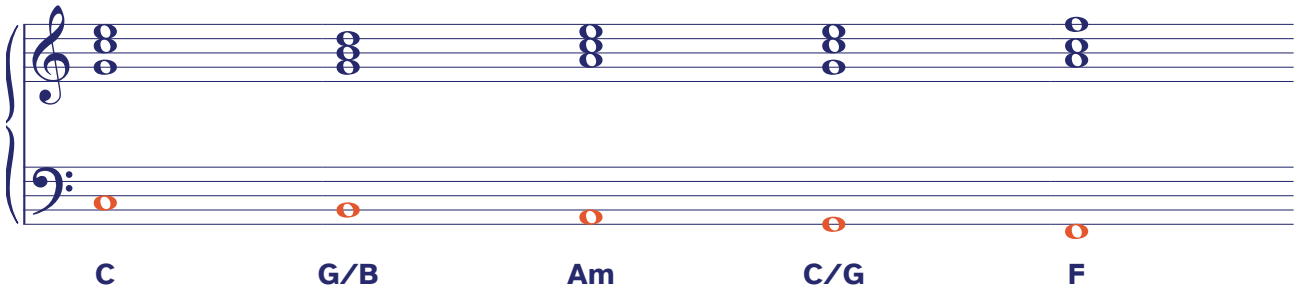
1. Before the slash: the **chord**. C means C E G, in the right hand.
2. After the slash: the **bass**. E goes in the left hand, below everything.
3. Play them together: **C/E**, “C over E”.



Four jobs for a slash chord

JOB	EXAMPLE	THE BASS NOTE IS	WHAT YOU HEAR
Inversion	C/E · C/G	a note of the chord	smoother changes (p. 119)
Walk-down	C · G/B · Am	one step down each time	a bass line that walks down
Pedal	F/C · G/C	the same note, held	the chords change above it
Colour	F/G · D/C	not in the chord	open, modern: pop, gospel

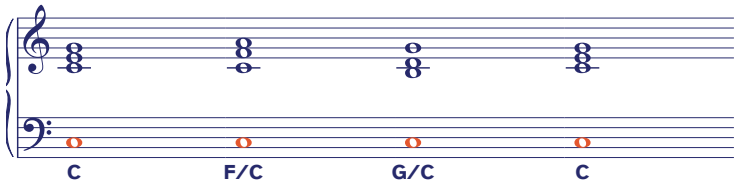
Job 2: a bass that walks down



The red bass walks straight down, C B A G F, while the right hand moves a step at most. G/B and C/G make the steps possible.

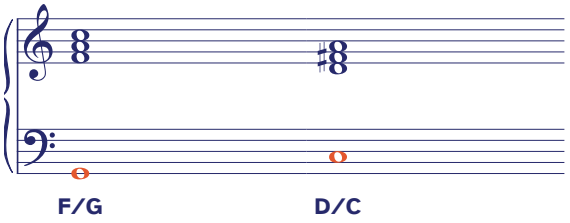
PART V · CHORDS · 8 · CONTINUED

Job 3: a pedal, one bass under everything



The bass holds C while the chords change above it: C, F/C, G/C, C. The chords change while the C stays. (It is called a pedal after the organ's foot pedals, which hold long low notes.)

Job 4: a bass from outside the chord

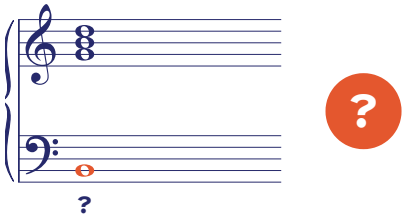


F/G: F A C over a G. G is not in the F chord, so it floats, open and unfinished. Pop and gospel players love it.

D/C: D F♯ A over a C. The C is not in the D chord, so it rubs against the chord.

EXAMPLE 1

Name the slash chord



1. **The right hand:** which chord is G B D?
2. **The lowest note:** which note is in the left hand?
3. **Write chord, slash, bass.** Is the bass in the chord?

It is **G/B**, "G over B": B is in the G chord, so it is the 1st inversion.

GAME

Read the slash

1	2	3	4
G/B	C/G	F/A	Am/C

Before the slash: the chord. After it: the bass note. Which note goes in the left hand?

Answer: 1 B · 2 G · 3 A · 4 C.

PART V · CHORDS · 8 · CONTINUED

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

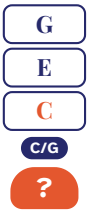


Right hand C, left hand E.

Play C E G in the right hand and a low E in the left: C/E. Now try a low A under it: what would you call that?

EXAMPLE 2

C/G: which note goes in the left hand?

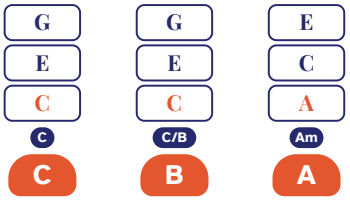


1. **Before the slash:** the chord. Which three notes go in the right hand?
2. **After the slash:** the bass. Which note goes low in the left hand?
3. **Play them together.**

Right hand C E G, left hand a low **G**: the C chord standing on G.

EXAMPLE 3

Walk the bass down: C, C/B, Am



1. **Right hand** holds C E G for two chords.
2. **Left hand** walks down: C, then B.
3. **Then A**, under A C E: Am.

The bass walks **C B A**, one step at a time, while the chords hardly move.

THINK OF IT A cake and the plate it stands on: the slash says which cake (the chord) and which plate (the bass). Same cake, new plate, new view.

TRAP

- × Writing it back to front: the chord comes first, the bass second. E/C would be an E chord over C.
- × Letting the right hand dip below the bass: the letter after the slash must be the lowest note you play.
- × Forgetting the chord itself: in C/E the right hand still plays the whole C chord, C E G, not just C.

SEE ALSO
Inversions p. 119 · Colour chords p. 125

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 15–16 · Online: Library › Chords

PART V · CHORDS · TIPS

When a chord sounds wrong

A chord that sounds wrong usually has one small slip. Name the slip, fix that one note, and the chord comes right.

TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
A chord sounds dark when it should be bright	**the kind**: keys between, 3 + 2 or 2 + 3	p. 113
Your hand jumps all over	**an inversion**: keep the shared note still	p. 119
A big chord sounds muddy	**leave notes out**: drop the 5th first	p. 128
A seventh chord sounds wrong	**the 7th**: G7 adds F, a 7th above G (9 keys between)	p. 122
A sus chord sounds unfinished	**the 4th**: the middle layer moved up a letter	p. 125
The bass note sounds odd	**the slash**: the letter after it is the lowest note	p. 131

Four ways to learn chords fast

1. **Build, then play**
   Say the cake (C E G) before your fingers go down.

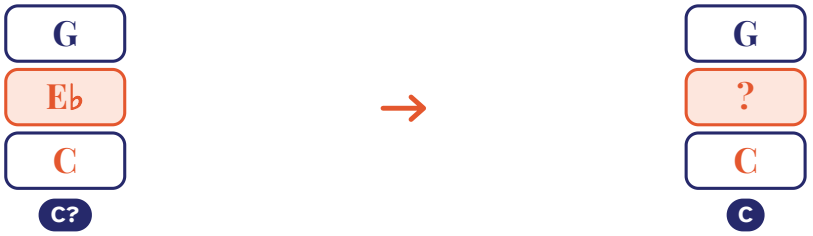
2. **Hands alone first**
   Left hand chords alone, then the tune alone, then together.

3. **One cake, three keys**
   Build the same kind of chord on C, G and F.

4. **Listen for the kind**
   Play major and minor side by side: bright, then dark.

EXAMPLE

Fix a dark chord



1. **It sounds dark**, but the music wants a bright C chord.
2. **Count the keys between:** C to E♭, then E♭ to G. Which kind is that?
3. **Move one note** so it becomes 3 + 2. Which layer, and to which key?

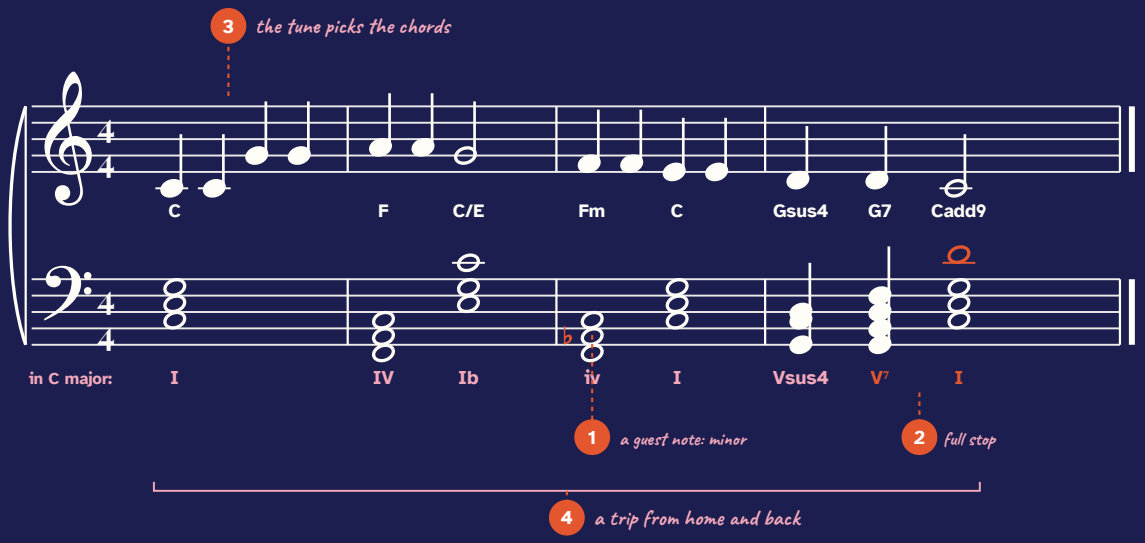
Move the middle layer from E♭ up to **E**: 3 + 2, bright C major again.

THINK OF IT Like a mechanic: one odd sound points to one part. Fix that part and the engine runs smoothly.

PART VI · PUT THEM TO WORK

Harmony in music

A melody is the singer; harmony is the band behind it. Here the chords start moving: guests from outside the key, endings, chords under a tune, and the trips every song takes. All of it is in the same four bars.



1 **Chords from outside the key** p. 136
a guest note: A♭ in C major

2 **Cadences** p. 139
V to I ends a phrase like a full stop

3 **Chords under a melody** p. 142
the tune's main notes pick the chord

4 **Progressions everywhere** p. 144
the same few trips, in every song

★ **Tips: when harmony goes wrong** p. 146

PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 1

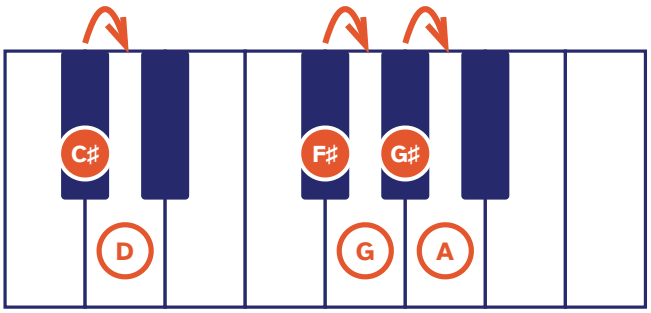
Chords from outside the key

In C major, home is the white keys, so a black key in a chord is a **guest**. Guests never stay: each one moves to the **very next key** (no key between), and shows you where the music goes next.

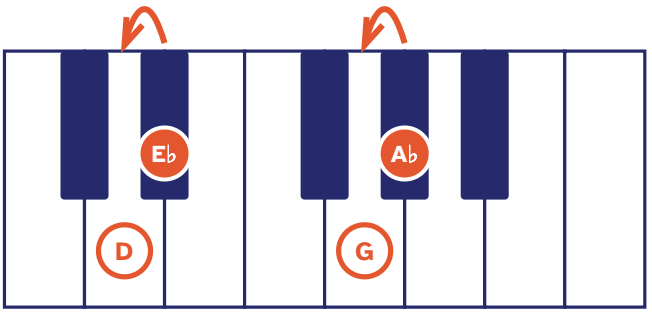
THE SECRET

Sharp guests push up, flat guests sigh down: follow them one key and you find the next chord.

Sharp guests push up

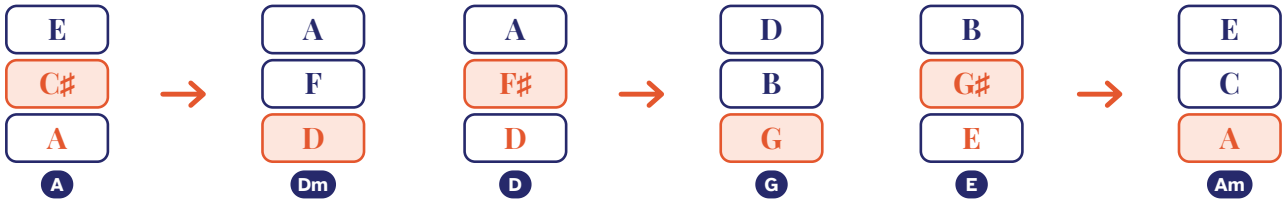


Flat guests sigh down

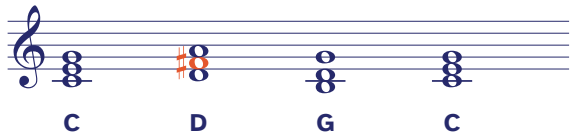


1. Find the **black key** in the chord: that is the guest.
2. A **sharp**? Go **up** to the very next key. A **flat**? Usually **down** to the very next key.
3. You have found a note of the **next chord**. Play it and hear it land.

Sharp guests: up one key names the next chord

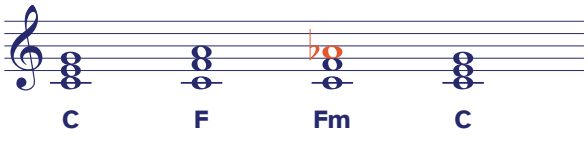


C♯ goes up to **D**, so the next chord is D minor. F♯ goes up to **G**: G. G♯ goes up to **A**: A minor.



Try it in a song: C, D, G, C. The **F♯** pushes up into G, then G leads home to C.

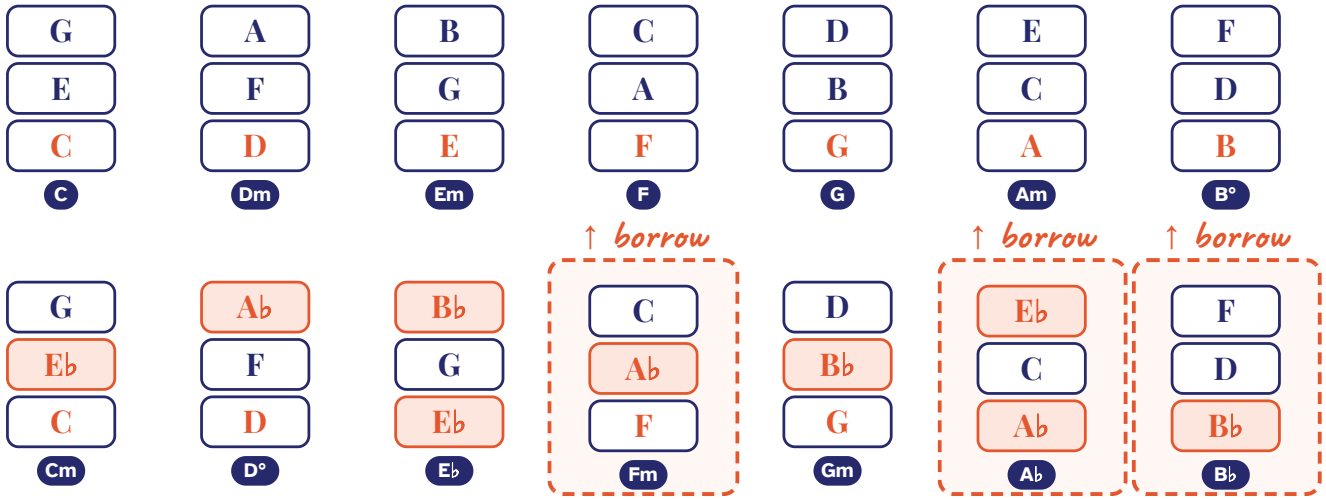
Flat guests: borrowed from the twin, they sigh down



C major and C minor are **twins** (the parallel minor): the same home note, C, in different clothes. A flat guest is one piece of the twin's outfit. In C, F, Fm, C the **A♭** sighs down to G.

PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 1 · CONTINUED

C major *at home*



C minor *the twin: same home note, darker clothes*

Their names, for later

GUEST	NOTES	MOVES	NEXT CHORD	ITS NAME
sharp guest	D F♯ A	F♯ up to G	G	V of V
sharp guest	A C♯ E	C♯ up to D	Dm	V of ii
sharp guest	E G♯ B	G♯ up to A	Am	V of vi
flat guest	F A♭ C	A♭ down to G	C	borrowed iv
flat guest	A♭ C E♭	A♭ down to G	G or C	borrowed ♭VI
flat guest	B♭ D F	B♭ on to C	C	borrowed ♭VII

B♭ is the flat guest that walks **up** instead, on to C (one key between: a tone): the rock and film ending B♭ → C.

EXAMPLE

Where do the guests go? B D♯ F♯ in C major



1. **Find the black keys:** there are two guests here.
2. **Both are sharps:** move each up to the very next key. Where do they land?
3. **Which cake in C major** holds both landing notes?

D♯ goes up to E, F♯ up to G: both live in **E minor** (E G B). B D♯ F♯ leads to Em.

PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 1 · CONTINUED

GAME

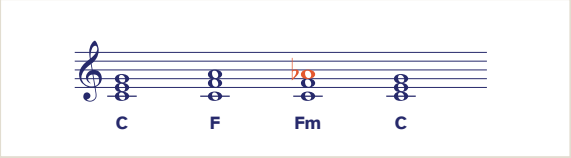
Where does the guest go?

1	2	3
E	E♭	A
C♯	C	F♯
A	A♭	D
A	A♭	D

In C major: find each guest, follow it one key, and write the chord that comes next.

Answer: 1 C♯ up to D: D minor · 2 A♭ down to G, E♭ down to D: G · 3 F♯ up to G: G.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Play C, F, Fm, C slowly.

Hear the A♭ sigh down to G? Now play C, D, G, C: the F♯ pushes up instead. One sighs, one pushes.

THINK OF IT A surprise guest at dinner: one new face changes the whole conversation, and then everyone goes home.

TRAP

- × Following a sharp downwards: sharps push **up**, flats usually sigh **down**.
- × Calling every black key a guest: in G major F♯ is at home. A guest is a note from outside the key you are in.
- × Learning the names first: play it, hear where the guest goes, then name it.
- × Mixing up the relatives: C minor is C major's twin (same home note). A minor is its neighbour (same key signature). We borrow from the twin.

SEE ALSO

Chords in a key p. 116 · Slash chords p. 131 · Cadences p. 139

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 17–18 · Online: Library › Chromatic chords

PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 2

Cadences

A phrase is a musical sentence, and it needs punctuation. The last two chords of a phrase are its **cadence**. They tell you: finished, taking a breath, or surprise!

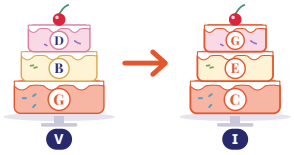
THE SECRET

Music has full stops and commas too: listen to the last two chords of a phrase.

.

Perfect

V → I

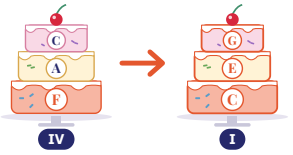


Home. The end.

Amen

Plagal

IV → I

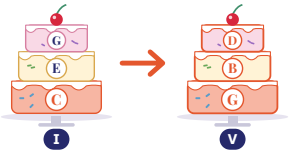


A soft, gentle end.

,

Imperfect

… → V

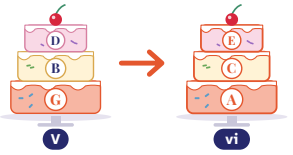


To be continued…

?!

Interrupted

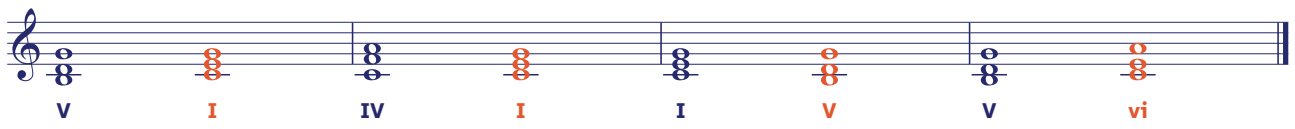
V → vi



Surprise! Not home.

1. Find the end of a phrase: often a long note, or a breath.
2. Name its **last two chords** with numerals: V I, IV I, anything then V, or V vi.
3. Match the punctuation: full stop (.), Amen, comma (,) or ?!

The four cadences in C

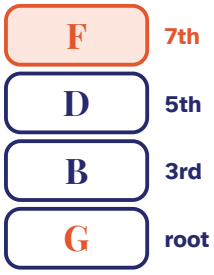


Perfect, plagal, imperfect, interrupted. The red chord is where each one lands.

CADENCE	CHORDS	FEELS LIKE	ALSO CALLED
Perfect	V → I	a full stop: finished	authentic, full close
Plagal	IV → I	the “A-men” sung at the end of a song in church	Amen cadence
Imperfect	any → V	a comma: waiting	half close, half cadence
Interrupted	V → vi	a surprise: not home yet	deceptive

PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 2 · CONTINUED

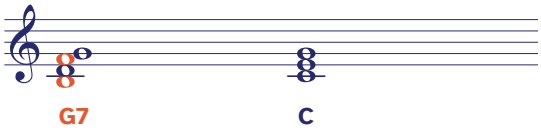
Why G7 pulls home



Add the 7th to V and the full stop gets stronger.

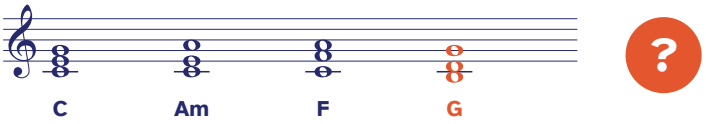
In **G7** two notes lean towards C major. The **B** rises to **C**, the **F** falls to **E**: each to the very next key, no key between. Two tiny steps, and you are home (Seventh chords, p. 122).

It works like a guest: B pushes up, F sighs down (p. 136).



EXAMPLE 1

How does this phrase end? C Am F G

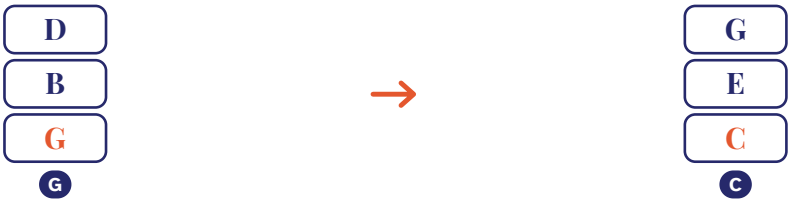


1. **Find the last two chords** of the phrase.
2. **Turn them into numerals** in C major.
3. **Which punctuation card** ends that way?

F then G is IV → V: it lands on V, the comma. An **imperfect cadence**.

EXAMPLE 2

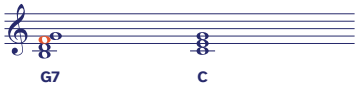
How does Twinkle end?



1. **The last two chords** of Twinkle in C are G, then C.
2. **Turn them into numerals.**
3. **Which card** goes from that chord to that chord?

V → I: a **perfect cadence**, the full stop. That is why Twinkle sounds finished.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Play G7, then C. The end!

Now play G7, then A minor: “huh?!” That is the interrupted cadence. Then play F, then C, and sing “A-men”.

PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 2 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

Surprise! G7, then A minor

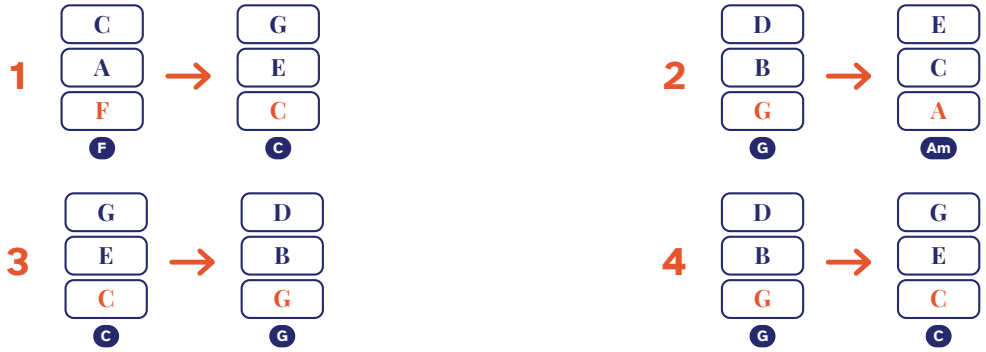


1. **G7 leans towards home**: you expect C.
2. **But the next chord is A minor.** Which numeral is it in C?
3. **V → that numeral:** which card?

V → vi: an **interrupted cadence**. The music was heading home, then turned the corner.

GAME

Punctuate the phrases



Each pair ends a phrase in C major. Turn the letters into numerals first (C is I, F is IV, G is V, Am is vi), then write full stop, comma, Amen or ?! beside each.

Answer: 1 Amen (plagal), 2 ?! (interrupted), 3 comma (imperfect), 4 full stop (perfect).

THINK OF IT Punctuation in a sentence: a full stop ends it, a comma makes you wait, and a surprise makes you gasp. Music ends its phrases the same way.

TRAP

- × Calling every ending on I (C) perfect: a perfect cadence comes **from V**. F to C is plagal.
- × Mixing up imperfect and perfect: imperfect **ends on** V; perfect **starts on** V and lands on I.

SEE ALSO

Chords in a key p. 116 · Seventh chords p. 122 · Chords under a melody p. 142

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 19–20 · Online: Library › Cadences

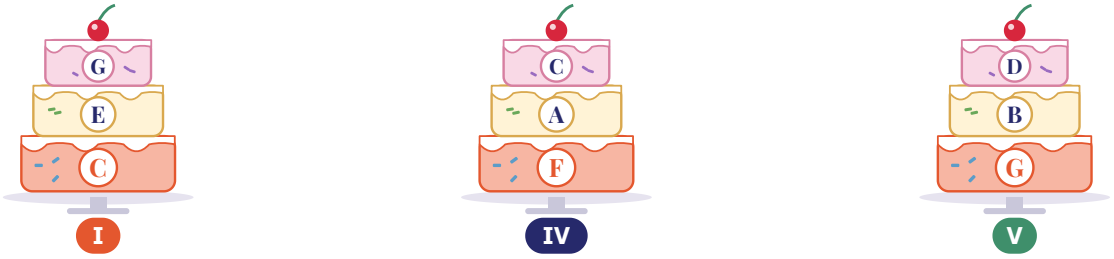
PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 3

Chords under a melody

The melody is the singer; the chords are the band. A good band plays chords that hold the singer's main notes.

THE SECRET

Look at the melody's main notes, then pick the cake that holds them.



C	D	E	F	G	A	B
I, IV	V	I	IV	I, V	IV	V

Which cake holds the tune's main notes?

Every note of C major lives in I, IV or V. C and G live in two: let your ear choose.
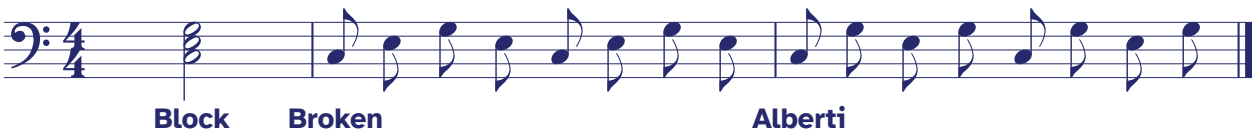
1. Look at the **main notes** of the bar: the long ones, and the ones on beats 1 and 3.
2. Find the cake that holds them: **I, IV or V**.
3. Play that chord in the left hand while the right hand plays the tune.

Twinkle, Twinkle, with its chords



C C G G sit in I (C); A A in IV (F), then G in I; F F in IV, E E in I; D D in V (G), and the last C in I. The chord changes halfway through bars 2, 3 and 4.

Three ways to play the chord in the left hand



Block: all three at once. Broken: one at a time, up and down. Alberti: low, high, middle, high, named after Domenico Alberti, who loved it.

PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE

Choose the chord: E D C D | E E E

E D C D | E E E

red = beats 1 and 3

1. **Bar 1:** which notes fall on beats 1 and 3 (red)?
2. **Which cake** holds both of them: I, IV or V?
3. **Bar 2:** E E E. Which cake holds E?

E and C both live in **I**, and so does E: both bars take **I** (C). That is the start of Mary Had a Little Lamb.

GAME

Pick the cake
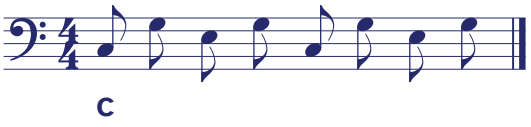
F A F A D B G B G E C E

1 2 3

Each bar is in C major. Which cake holds its notes: I, IV or V?

Answer: 1 IV (F A C) · 2 V (G B D) · 3 I (C E G).

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Left hand: C G E G, over and over.

That is the Alberti bass on the C chord. Keep it going while you hum Twinkle, then try it on F (F C A C) and G (G D B D).

YOU KNOW THIS

Mozart, Sonata in C, K. 545: the left hand



The opening left hand is an **Alberti bass**: C G E G is just the C chord, broken into low, high, middle, high; D G F G is G7 (G B D F, without the B). Mozart wrote it an octave higher, starting on middle C.

Try it. Play this left hand alone, then add the famous tune: C, E G, B, C D C.

THINK OF IT Like picking a coat for the weather: when the tune changes, change the chord.

TRAP

- × Choosing a chord for a passing note: use the main notes (strong beats, long notes).
- × Playing the left hand louder than the tune: the melody is the star, the chords are the stage.

SEE ALSO

Chords in a key p. 116 · Cadences p. 139

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 21–22 · Online: Library › Chords

PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 4

Progressions everywhere

A **progression** is a trip from chord to chord. A handful of trips turn up in song after song. Learn them by their numbers and you can play them in any key.

THE SECRET
Most songs take the same few trips: home, away, a pull, and home again.

I home · vi iii home's cousins · IV ii away · V the pull back home

The pop four
countless pop songs and ballads

I C → V G → vi Am → IV F

The fifties
old rock 'n' roll and doo-wop

I C → vi Am → IV F → V G

The jazz three-step
jazz standards (as ii7, V7, Imaj7)

ii Dm → V G → I C

The canon
Pachelbel's Canon and its many children

I C → V G → vi Am → iii Em → IV F → I C → IV F → V G

1. Learn the trip by **numbers**: I V vi IV.
2. Pick a key and turn the numbers into chords: in C, **C G Am F**.
3. Play it round and round. Change key: the numbers stay the same.

Same trip, any key

The pop four	I	V	vi	IV
in C	C	G	Am	F
in G	G	D	Em	C
in F	F	C	Dm	B♭
in D	D	A	Bm	G

The twelve-bar blues

I C	I C	I C	I C
IV F	IV F	I C	I C
V G	IV F	I C	V G

The most famous trip of all is twelve bars long and uses only **I, IV and V**. Almost every blues, and a lot of rock 'n' roll, follows it. Play it in C with one chord per bar, four beats each.

Make it bluesy: turn every chord into a seventh (C7, F7, G7, p. 122).

PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE

Play the pop four in A major

I ? → V ? → vi ? → IV ?

1. **Write the A major scale** (three sharps) and number the notes.
2. **Find notes 1, 5, 6 and 4.**
3. **Build each cake:** which one is minor?

A, E, F♯m, D: **the pop four in A.** Same trip, new key.

GAME

Name the trip

1 C · Am · F · G

2 Dm · G · C

3 C · G · Am · F

All in C major. Turn each into numbers, then name the trip: the pop four, the fifties or the jazz three-step.

Answer: 1 the fifties (I vi IV V) · 2 the jazz three-step (ii V I) · 3 the pop four (I V vi IV).

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

I C → V G → vi Am → IV F

Play C, G, Am, F, four beats each.

Go round four times without stopping. The left hand plays the chord's name note (C for C, A for Am), right hand the whole cake. Hum any tune you like over it.

TRAP

× Mixing up the pop four and the fifties: same four chords, different order. Listen to which chord comes second.

SEE ALSO

Chords in a key p. 116 · Cadences p. 139 · Chords under a melody p. 142

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 23–24 · Online: Library › Chords

PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · TIPS

When the harmony goes wrong

Every chord can be right and the music still sound wrong: the ending will not close, or the left hand fights the tune. The slip is in how the chords move. Find which move it is, then fix that one.

TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
The end does not feel finished	**the cadence**: end with V → I	p. 139
A sharp or flat surprises you	**a guest**: sharps go up, flats go down, one key	p. 136
The left hand fights the tune	**the main notes**: pick the cake holding them	p. 142
A new song feels hard to learn	**the trip**: find I, IV, V and vi by number	p. 144

Four ways to hear the harmony

1 Hum the bass
Sing the lowest notes: they show where the chords move.

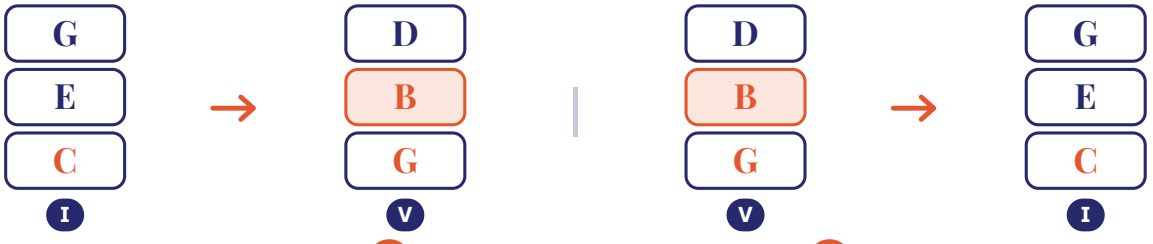
2 Tick the full stops
Mark every V → I in your piece with a red tick.

3 One trip, three keys
Play I–V–vi–IV in C, G and F: same numbers, new letters.

4 Chord a tune you know
Pick I, IV or V for each bar of Twinkle or Happy Birthday.

EXAMPLE

Fix the ending



1 The piece stops, but it does not feel finished. Look at the last two chords.

2 Name them: C then G is I → V. That is a comma, not a full stop.

3 Swap the order: G then C is V → I. The red B climbs one key to C, and the music lands.

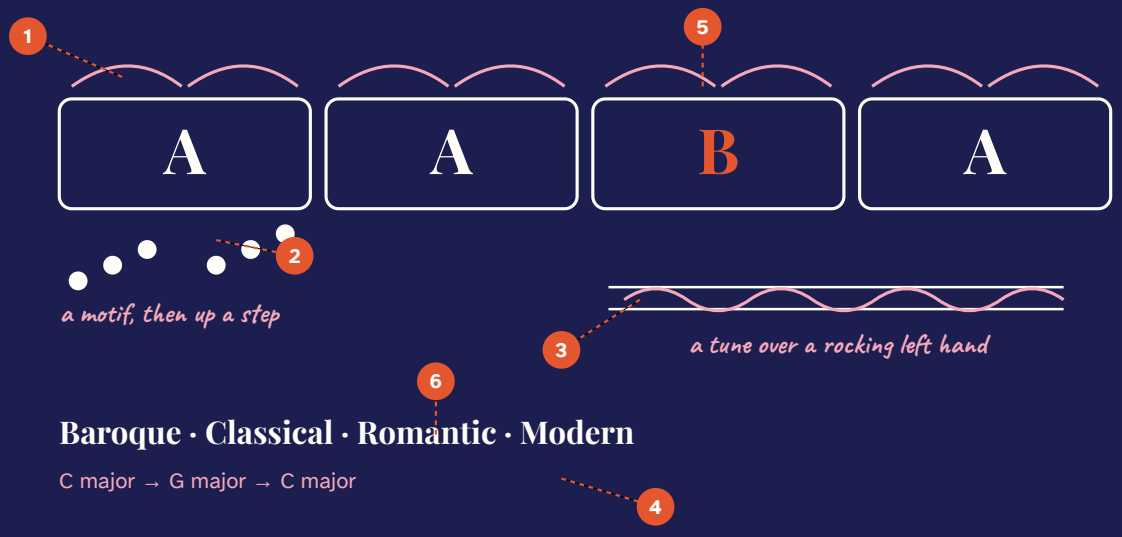
A strong ending needs **V → I** (IV → I for a soft Amen): the last two chords are the full stop.

THINK OF IT Like a road trip: once you know where home is, every detour makes sense, and every road leads back to I.

PART VII · HOW MUSIC IS BUILT

Shape and style

Step back from the notes and see the building: small ideas, repeated and moved, in sections that come and go, in the style of their time. Everything in this part is on this map.



1 **Motifs and phrases** p. 148
small ideas build sentences: question and answer

2 **Repetition and sequence** p. 150
say it again, higher, in another voice, or something new

3 **Texture** p. 152
one line, a tune with chords, or tunes woven together

4 **Changing key** p. 154
a new sharp that keeps coming back: a new key

5 **Form** p. 156
the map of a piece: AB, ABA, ABACA, variations

6 **Styles through time** p. 159
Baroque, Classical, Romantic and Modern

★ **Tips: when a piece goes nowhere** p. 161

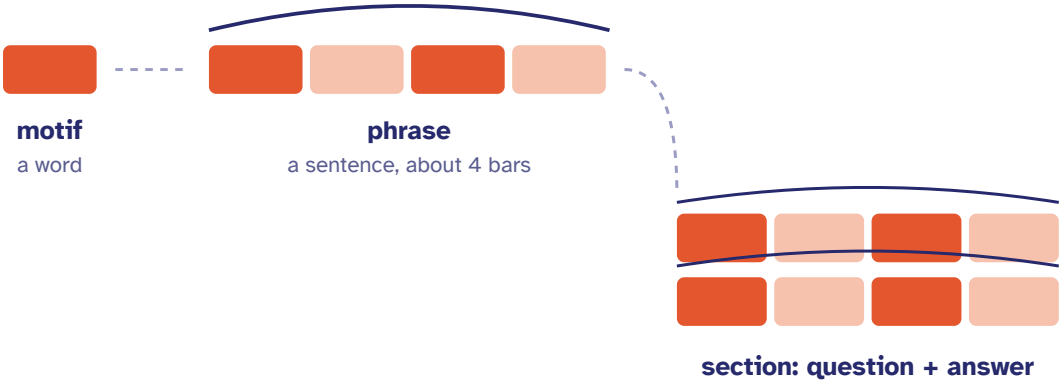
PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 1

Motifs and phrases

A tune is built like a story. A tiny idea, the **motif**, grows into a **phrase**, a musical sentence; two phrases make a question and its answer. Spot the building blocks and a page of notes turns into a few ideas.
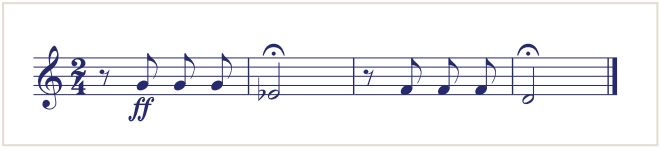
THE SECRET

A motif is a word, a phrase a sentence: a question ends away from home, an answer comes home.
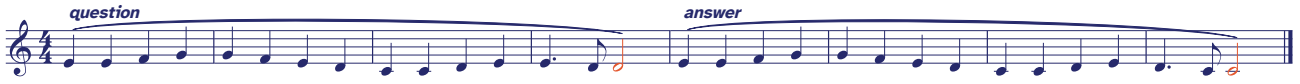


Words, sentences, paragraphs

A motif



Four notes, short-short-short-long: Beethoven builds the whole first movement of his Fifth Symphony from them. A motif is short (2 to 6 notes) and easy to recognise: its **rhythm** and its **shape** come back again and again.

Phrases: question and answer



Ode to Joy: two 4-bar phrases. The first ends on D, away from home (a question); the second comes home to C (an answer).
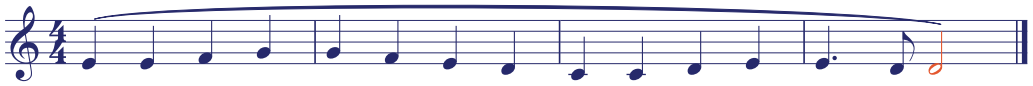
THE RULE

Most phrases are 4 bars long. A question phrase ends away from the key note; the answer comes home to it.

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Question or answer?
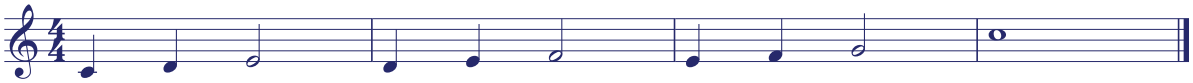


1. **The key is C major.** What is the home note?
2. **The last note** of this phrase is…?
3. **Is it home?**

It ends on D, not C: a **question**. The answer phrase that follows ends on C.

EXAMPLE 2

Find the motif



1. **Look at bar 1:** what shape and rhythm?
2. **Bars 2 and 3:** the same shape?
3. **Where** does each start?

Step, step, long: three notes. It comes **three times**, each a step higher.

GAME
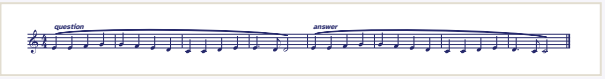
How many phrases?

1	2	3
8 bars	12 bars	16 bars

Each phrase is 4 bars long. How many phrases in a tune of…

Answer: 1 two · 2 three · 3 four.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS
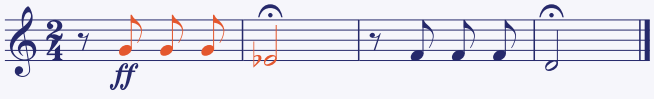


Sing a question, then an answer.

Sing the question and stop on the D: it hangs in the air. Now sing the answer and land on C.

YOU KNOW THIS

Beethoven, Symphony No. 5



"Da-da-da-**DUM**": the most famous motif ever written. Listen to the first minute and count how many times it comes back.

Try it. Tap the rhythm on the lid, then sing it a step lower.

TRAP

× Playing every note the same: each phrase has one high point to grow towards.

SEE ALSO

Slurs and phrases p. 80 · Cadences p. 139

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 1–2 · Online: Library › Phrases

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 2

Repetition and sequence

Composers make one idea go a long way. Learn the four ways they do it, and a new piece starts to look familiar.
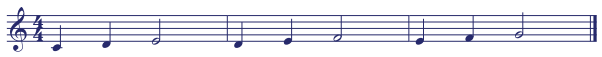
THE SECRET

Again, again higher, again in the other hand, or something new.
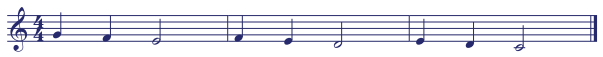


Four ways to use one idea

NAME	WHAT HAPPENS
repetition	the same notes again
sequence	the same shape, starting higher or lower
imitation	another hand or voice copies the idea
contrast	something new: a different shape or rhythm



A rising sequence: C D E, D E F, E F G.

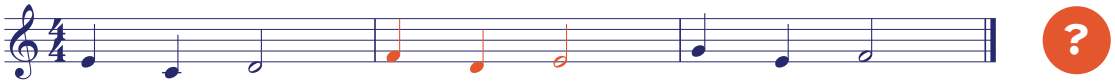


A falling sequence: each step one note lower.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Take any three-note motif and play it as a sequence, starting on every white key from C up to the next C, then back down.

EXAMPLE 1

Repetition or sequence?
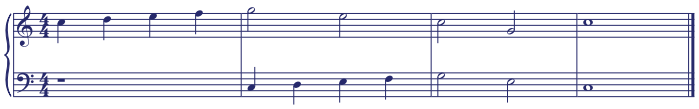


1. **Bar 1:** which notes?
2. **Bar 2:** the same notes, or the same shape on new notes?
3. **Bar 3?**

Same shape, a step higher each bar: a **sequence**.

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 2 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Which hand copies?
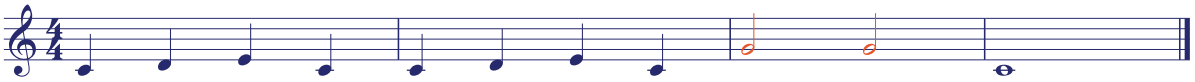


?

1. **The right hand** starts with C D E F G E C.
2. **The left hand** waits a bar. Then?
3. **Same notes**, how many octaves lower?

The left hand **imitates** the right one bar later, two octaves down.

EXAMPLE 3

Where is the contrast?



?

1. **Bars 1 and 2:** same or different?
2. **Bar 3:** what changes, the notes or the rhythm?
3. **Bar 4?**

Bars 1–2 repeat; **bar 3** brings something new: long notes on G.

GAME

Which way?

1 same notes

2 one step up

3 left hand copies

4 new rhythm

Name each one.

Answer: 1 repetition · 2 sequence · 3 imitation · 4 contrast.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS
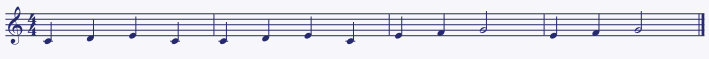


Make a sequence.

Play C D E, then D E F, then E F G with fingers 1 2 3. Now go down: G F E, F E D, E D C.

YOU KNOW THIS

Frère Jacques



Every bar is said **twice**: repetition. Sung as a round, each voice enters two bars after the last: imitation.

Try it. Sing it as a round with a friend.

TRAP

× Calling any repeat a sequence: a sequence moves to new notes.

SEE ALSO
Motifs and phrases p. 148 · Texture p. 152

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 3–4 · Online: Library › Patterns

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 3

Texture

Listen to a piece and ask: how many lines are sounding at once, and how do they fit together? That is its **texture**.

THE SECRET

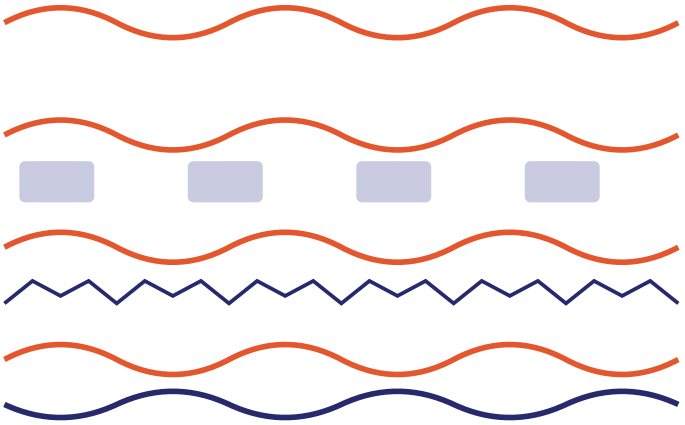
Count the lines: one alone, a tune with chords, or tunes woven together.

one line
monophony

a tune with chords
melody and accompaniment
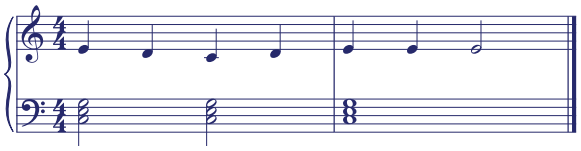
a tune over broken chords
Alberti bass, arpeggios

two tunes at once
polyphony
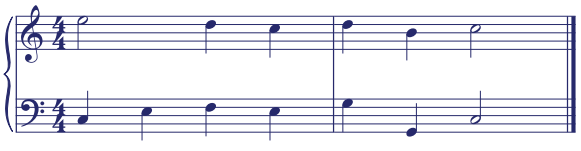


Thin or thick: count the threads

WORD	WHAT YOU HEAR
monophonic	one line alone, or in octaves (unison)
homophonic	a tune with chords underneath: melody and accompaniment
polyphonic (contrapuntal)	two or more tunes at once, each its own
Alberti bass	a broken chord rocking low–high–middle–high
block chords	all the chord notes struck together



Melody and block chords.



Polyphony: two tunes, each with its own rhythm.

GAME

One line or more?

1	2	3
a tune alone	a tune and chords	two tunes at once

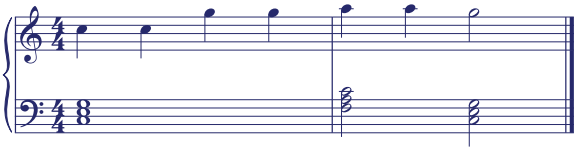
Name the texture.

Answer: 1 monophonic · 2 homophonic · 3 polyphonic.

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Name the texture
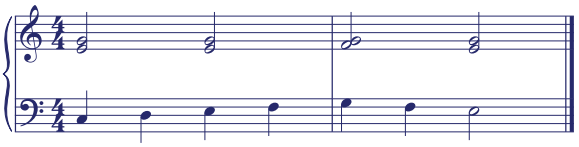


1. **The right hand:** a tune or chords?
2. **The left hand:** a tune or chords?
3. **So** which word?

A tune over chords: **homophonic**, melody and accompaniment.

EXAMPLE 2

Which hand has the tune?
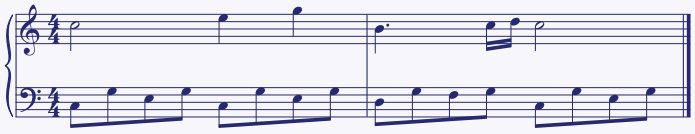


1. **The right hand** repeats two-note chords.
2. **The left hand** moves step by step.
3. **Which one** should sing out?

The **left hand** has the tune: play it louder, keep the right-hand chords soft.

YOU KNOW THIS

Mozart, Sonata in C, K. 545



The right hand sings; the left hand rocks **C G E G**: an Alberti bass, the sound of the Classical style.

Try it. Play only the left hand, softly and evenly.

TRAP

- × Letting the accompaniment cover the tune: tune louder, chords softer.
- × Losing one of two tunes: practise each hand alone and sing it.

SEE ALSO
Chords under a melody p. 142 · Styles p. 159

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 5–6 · Online: Library › Texture

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 4

Changing key

Music can travel to a new key, and it usually comes home before the end. The move itself is called a **modulation**. Learn to spot the signposts.

THE SECRET

A new sharp or flat that keeps coming back, then a cadence: you are in a new key.

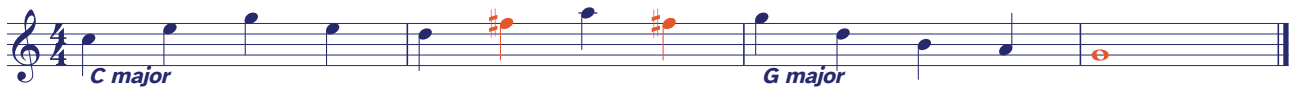


A trip away, and home again

The nearest keys

A piece in C major usually visits the keys next door on the circle of fifths (p. 105): only one note changes.
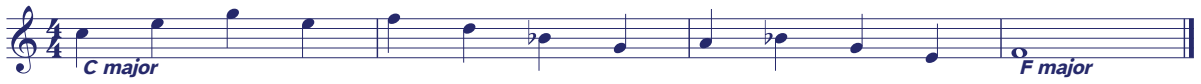
FROM C MAJOR TO	THE SIGNPOST	WHY IT IS CLOSE
G major	F♯ appears	the key a 5th up (one more sharp)
F major	B♭ appears	the key a 4th up (one more flat)
A minor	G♯ appears	the relative minor (same key signature)



Bar 1 in C major; F♯ twice in bar 2, then the phrase lands on G: now G major.

EXAMPLE 1

Where does the key change?



?

1. **Find the accidental.**
2. **Which major key** has one flat, B♭?
3. **Where** does the phrase land?

B♭ in bar 2 and again in bar 3, landing on F: **F major**.

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Which nearby key?

In G major, a C♯ keeps appearing ?

1. **G major** has one sharp, F♯.
2. **C♯ is one more sharp.**
3. **Which key** has F♯ and C♯?

D major, the key a 5th up: one more sharp.

EXAMPLE 3

A new key, or just passing?

One F♯ in a bar of C major, then F♮ everywhere after ?

1. **Does the F♯ come back?**
2. **Is there a cadence** in G?
3. **So**, a new key?

No: one passing F♯ is a decoration. A modulation **keeps** its new note and lands with a cadence.

GAME
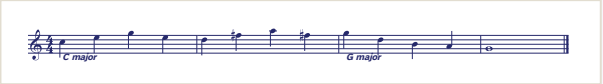
Where to next?

1. C major + F♯
2. C major + B♭
3. G major + C♯
4. F major + E♭

Which nearby key has the music moved to?

Answer: 1 G major · 2 F major · 3 D major · 4 B♭ major.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Hear the pull.

Play the four bars twice: once with F♮ in bar 2, once with F♯. With the F♯, the G at the end sounds like a new home.

THINK OF IT A modulation is a holiday: new scenery for a while, but the piece usually comes home at the end.

TRAP

- × Taking one passing accidental as a new key: it must keep coming back.
- × Missing the way home: most pieces end in the key they began in, so watch for the old note returning.

SEE ALSO

The circle of fifths p. 105 · Cadences p. 139

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 7–8 · Online: Library › Keys

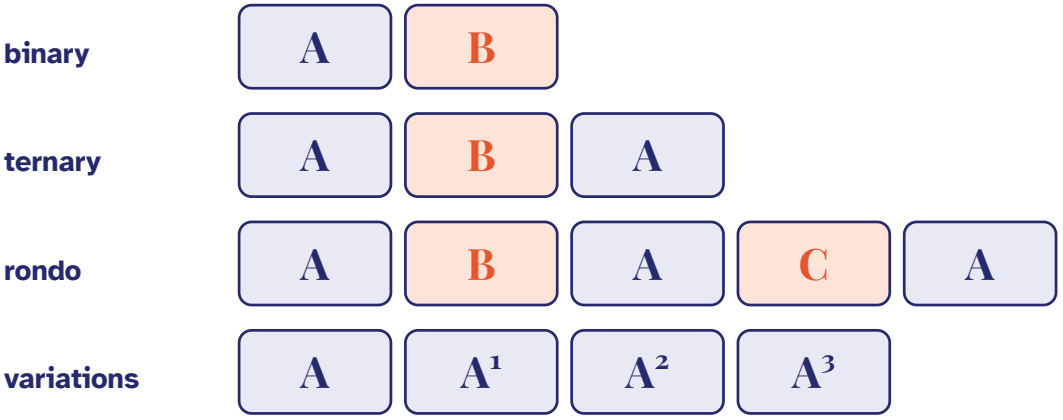
PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 5

Form

Form is the map of a whole piece: which sections come, in what order, and which come back. Letters name them: **A** for the first idea, **B** for the next new one, and so on.

THE SECRET

Same music, same letter. New music, next letter.



The map of a piece, in letters

FORM	LETTERS	SHAPE	YOU KNOW IT FROM
binary	A B	two halves, each often repeated	Baroque dances: minuets, gigues
ternary	A B A	out, away, and back	many short Romantic pieces
rondo	A B A C A	A keeps coming back between new ideas	Beethoven, Für Elise
theme and variations	A A^1 A^2 A^3	one tune, dressed differently each time	Mozart's variations on "Twinkle"
strophic	A A A	the same music for every verse	hymns, folk songs
verse and chorus	V C V C	the chorus words stay the same	pop songs

THE RULE

Same music, same letter. New music, the next letter. A little changed: add a small number (A^1).

LISTEN FOR IT

Petzold
Minuet in G (Notebook for Anna Magdalena Bach; once thought to be Bach's)
binary: two halves, each repeated

Beethoven
Für Elise
rondo: A B A C A

Mozart
Twelve Variations on "Ah vous dirai-je, Maman"
theme and variations, on the tune of Twinkle

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 5 · CONTINUED

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Sonata form

The big first movements of sonatas and symphonies: an **exposition** (two themes, the second in a new key), a **development** (the themes taken apart and moved through keys), and a **recapitulation** (both themes again, now at home).

EXAMPLE 1

Which letter makes it ternary?



1. **A B** alone: two sections.
2. **Ternary** goes out, away and...?
3. **Which letter** fills the box?

A. A B is binary; A B **A** is ternary.

EXAMPLE 2

Which form?
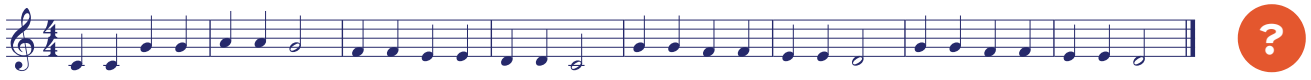


1. **Count the sections.**
2. **Which one keeps coming back?**
3. **What comes between?**

A returns between two new ideas: a **rondo**.

EXAMPLE 3

Map Twinkle



1. **Bars 1–4:** call them A.
2. **Bars 5–8:** new or the same?
3. **The last four bars** (not shown) repeat bars 1–4.

Bars 5–8 are new: B. Then A again: **A B A**, ternary.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



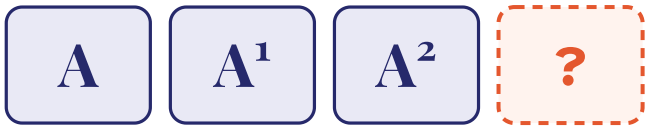
Map a piece you play.

Give every 4-bar phrase a letter. Same music, same letter. What form is it?

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 5 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 4

What comes next?



1. **A** is the theme.
2. **A¹ and A²**: the same tune, dressed differently.
3. **The next one** is called...?

A³: a third variation. Theme and variations keep one tune and change its clothes.

GAME

Name the form

1	2	3	4
A B	A B A	A B A C A	A A¹ A² A³

Name each map.

Answer: 1 binary · 2 ternary · 3 rondo · 4 theme and variations.

HOW TO

Learn a piece by its map

1. **Letter the sections** in pencil.
2. **Learn A first**: it comes back, so it pays twice.
3. **Then the new sections**, and practise the joins between them.

YOU KNOW THIS

Beethoven, Für Elise



The famous opening tune is **A**. It is heard three times, with two new sections in between: a rondo.

Try it. Listen and raise your hand every time A returns.

THINK OF IT Form is the floor plan of a house: once you know the rooms, you never get lost in it.

TRAP

- × Giving every phrase a new letter: same music, same letter.
- × Counting a repeat as a new section: A played twice is still A.

SEE ALSO
Repeats and road signs p. 71 · Changing key p. 154

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 9–10 · Online: Library › Form

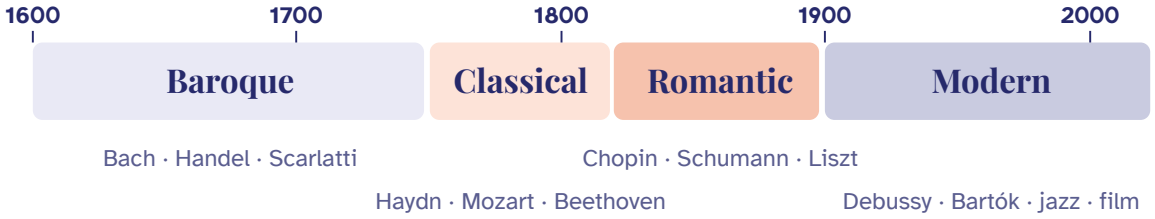
PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 6

Styles through time

Music changes with its time, like clothes and buildings. Four big periods cover most piano music. Each has a sound you can learn to recognise, and a way it likes to be played.

THE SECRET

Listen for the texture, the ornaments and the pedal: they tell you the century.



Four centuries, four sounds

PERIOD	LISTEN FOR
Baroque 1600–1750	harpsichord and organ; two or more tunes woven together; many ornaments; loud or soft in blocks; a steady beat throughout
Classical 1750–1820	the new piano; a clear tune with an Alberti bass; tidy 4-bar phrases; crescendos and contrasts
Romantic 1820–1900	big feelings; rich chords and the pedal; rubato; the whole keyboard, from very soft to very loud
Modern 1900–today	new scales and harmonies, surprising rhythms; impressionism, jazz, minimalism, film music

Playing in style

	PEDAL	TIME	TOUCH
Baroque	little or none	steady	clear, often detached
Classical	light	steady	neat, even, singing tune
Romantic	rich	rubato	deep, legato
Modern	as marked	as marked	whatever the music asks

LISTEN FOR IT

Notebook for Anna Magdalena Bach
Minuet in G (Petzold)
two lines, a steady dance

Mozart
Sonata in C, K. 545
Alberti bass, clear phrases

Chopin
Nocturnes
a singing tune, rubato, pedal

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · 6 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Which period?

A tune over an Alberti bass, tidy 4-bar phrases ?

1. **Alberti bass:** which period did it belong to?
2. **Tidy phrases**, question and answer.
3. **So?**

Classical: think Mozart.

EXAMPLE 2

Which period?

Two equal tunes, many trills, written for harpsichord ?

1. **Two tunes woven together**: which texture?
2. **Harpsichord**, before the piano.
3. **So?**

Baroque: think Bach.

EXAMPLE 3

Which period?

Rubato, rich pedalled chords, huge leaps across the keyboard ?

1. **Rubato**: time stretched for feeling.
2. **Rich chords** held in the pedal.
3. **So?**

Romantic: think Chopin.

GAME

Who belongs where?

1	2	3	4
Bach	Mozart	Chopin	Debussy

Match each composer to a period.

Answer: 1 Baroque · 2 Classical · 3 Romantic · 4 Modern.

TRAP

- × Pedalling Bach like Chopin: Baroque music needs little or no pedal.
- × Romantic rubato in Mozart: keep Classical time steady.

SEE ALSO
Ornaments p. 88 · The pedals p. 85

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 11–12 · Online: Library › Styles

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · TIPS

When a piece goes nowhere

Every note can be right and the piece still wander. The fix is to see the shape: where the phrases go, what comes back, and where the high point is.

TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
Every bar sounds the same	**the phrases:** where does each one grow?	p. 148
It feels like a list of notes	**the motif** and its sequences	p. 150
The tune is lost	**the texture:** which line sings?	p. 152
A passage suddenly feels strange	**a new key:** look for the new accidental	p. 154
You lose your place	**the form:** letter the sections	p. 156
It sounds out of style	**the period:** pedal, time and touch	p. 159

Four ways to find the shape

1. **Pencil the phrases**
   Draw a curve over each phrase and mark its high point.
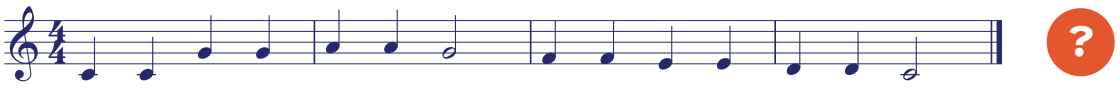
2. **Letter the sections**
   Write A, B, A in the margin. Practise each section on its own.

3. **Sing the tune**
   Sing the top line while you play the rest softly.

4. **Listen to a recording**
   Follow the score and hear the shape before you play it.

EXAMPLE

Where is the high point?



1. **Sing it.**
2. **Which note** is highest?
3. **Grow to it**, then let the phrase fall.

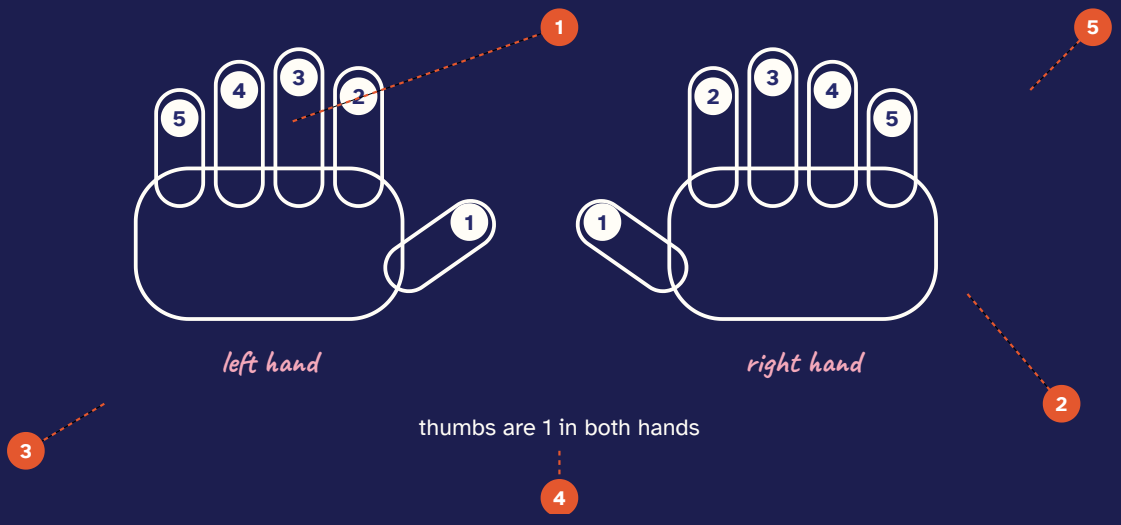
The **As in bar 2**: grow to them, then fall home to C.

THINK OF IT A map does not make the journey, but it stops you getting lost.

PART VIII · AT THE PIANO

Playing and listening

Everything before this page is knowledge. This part turns it into playing: the right fingers, practice that works, reading at sight, a trained ear, and the calm to perform.



1 **Fingering** p. 163
finger numbers, five-finger positions, thumb under

2 **Practising well** p. 165
slow, small chunks, then put it back together

3 **Sight-reading** p. 167
scan first, keep going, read ahead

4 **Listening** p. 169
clap it back, high or low, major or minor

5 **Performing** p. 171
warm up, start calmly, keep going after a slip

★ **Tips: when practice isn't working** p. 173

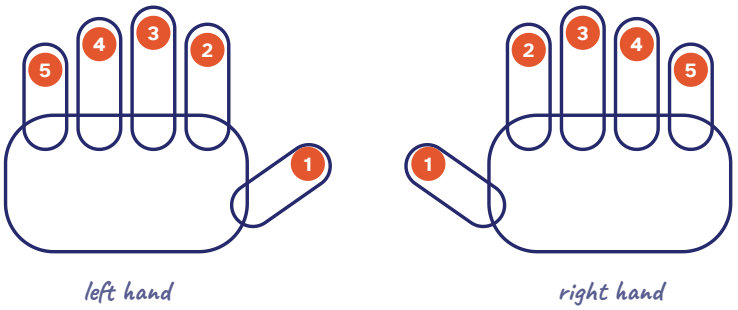
PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 1

Fingering

Good fingering makes hard passages easy and keeps your hand relaxed. It is planned, not guessed, and the plan starts with a number for every finger.
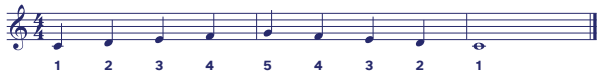
THE SECRET

Thumbs are 1 in both hands. Choose a fingering once, write it in, keep it.
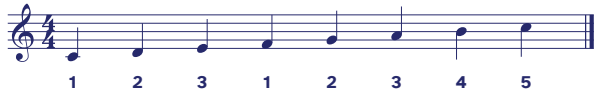


Thumbs are 1 in both hands

Five-finger position
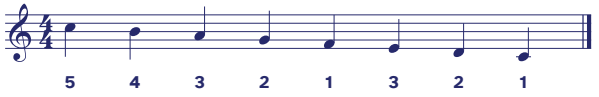


Thumb on C, one finger on each key up to G: five notes without moving the hand. Many first pieces stay in one position.

Thumb under, finger over



Up the scale: 1 2 3, thumb under to F, then 1 2 3 4 5.



Down: 5 4 3 2 1, then 3 crosses over the thumb.
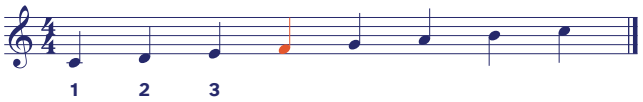
TWO-MINUTE DRILL Play C D E F G with each hand, saying the finger numbers: right 1 2 3 4 5 up, left 5 4 3 2 1 up. Then both hands together.

Left hand, C major up: 5 4 3 2 1, then 3 crosses over to A, then 2 1. **Down:** 1 2 3, thumb under to G, then 1 2 3 4 5.

PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Which finger plays the F?



?

1. **C D E** are 1 2 3.
2. **The F:** finger 4, or the thumb tucked under?
3. **Then** how do you reach the top C?

The **thumb** passes under to F; then 2 3 4 5 reach the top C.

EXAMPLE 2

Which finger plays G?

Right hand, thumb on C ?

1. **Thumb on C** is 1.
2. **Count up** one finger per key: D, E, F, G.
3. **So G** is…?

Finger **5**: C D E F G is 1 2 3 4 5.

GAME
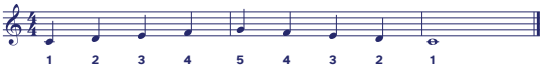
Name the finger

1 thumb	2 index
3 middle	4 little

Give the finger number.

Answer: 1 one · 2 two · 3 three · 4 five.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Five fingers, five keys.

Right hand on C D E F G. Play up and down, saying the finger numbers aloud. Then the left hand: 5 4 3 2 1 from C up.

TRAP

- × Changing fingering every time you play: choose one, write it in, keep it.
- × Landing heavily on the thumb as it passes under: let it glide.

SEE ALSO

The keyboard p. 22 · Major scales p. 93

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 1–2 · Online: Scales with fingering

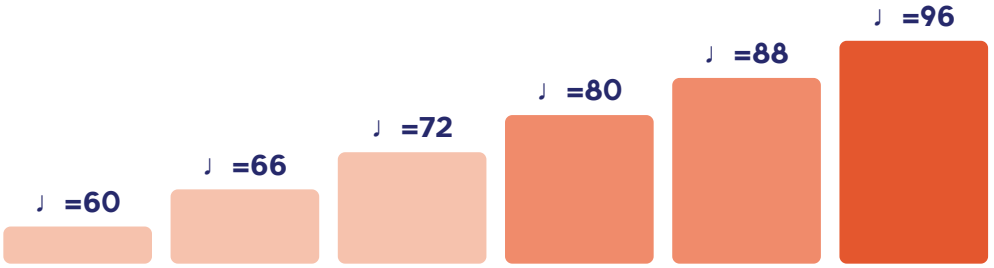
PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 2

Practising well

Practice is not playing a piece again and again from the top. It is fixing the hard bits, slowly and correctly, then joining them back together.

THE SECRET

Slow, small, and correct; then a little faster; then join the pieces.



three correct times at one speed, then one step up

Slow and correct, one step at a time

A fifteen-minute plan

TIME	WHAT YOU DO
2 min	warm up: a scale or five-finger exercise
5 min	the hardest bars, slowly, hands separately
5 min	join the bars, hands together, still slow
3 min	play the whole section; mark what slipped

Four tools

TOOL	HOW
small chunks	one bar, or two, plus the first note of the next
hands separately	each hand alone until it is easy, then together
slow, then faster	the metronome ladder: three correct times, then one notch up
count aloud	say the beats: it keeps the rhythm honest

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER
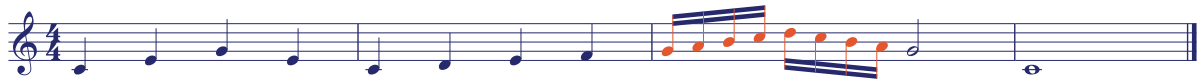
Practise in rhythms

For a run of even quavers, play it long–short, then short–long, slowly. When you go back to even notes, the run is suddenly easier: every note has been the “long” one.

PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 2 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Which bar first?



1. **Play it through once.** Where did it slip?
2. **The semiquavers** in bar 3: hardest?
3. **Start there**, slowly.

Bar 3, the semiquavers: practise the **hardest bar first**, slowly, then join bars 2–4.

EXAMPLE 2

When do you speed up?

♩ =60: right, right, wrong ?

1. **How many correct** in a row do you need?
2. **After a mistake**, start counting again.
3. **Then** one notch up.

Not yet: three **correct** in a row at 60, then try 66.

GAME

Good habit or not?

1	2
from the top	hardest first
3	4
faster to fix	slow, correct

Which help?

Answer: 2 and 4 help; 1 and 3 waste time.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

60 → 66 → 72

Climb the ladder.

Pick one hard bar. Play it three times correctly at a slow speed, then one notch faster. Stop when it slips twice.

HOW TO

Keep a practice log

1. **Write the date** and what you practised.
2. **Note one thing** that got better and one that did not.
3. **Start tomorrow** with the one that did not.

THINK OF IT Practice is like building a wall: lay each brick straight and the wall stands on its own.

TRAP

- × Practising mistakes: playing fast and wrong teaches your fingers the wrong notes.
- × Only playing what you already know: spend most time on the hard bits.

SEE ALSO
Speed words p. 82 · Fingering p. 163

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 3–4 · Online: Metronome · Practice log
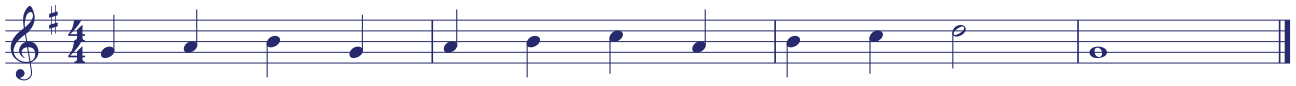
PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 3

Sight-reading

Sight-reading is playing music you have never seen. The secret is a short look first, then keeping the beat going whatever happens: a wrong note passes, a stop is heard by everyone.

THE SECRET

Look before you play, then never stop: the beat matters more than any note.



Thirty seconds first: one sharp (G major), 4/4, starts on G, steps up in a pattern.
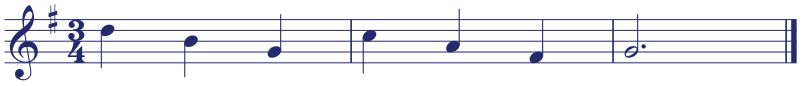
Look first, then never stop

The thirty-second scan

CHECK	LOOK FOR
1 key	sharps or flats at the start
2 time	the time signature: count a bar before you start
3 clefs and notes	the first note in each hand; the lowest and highest
4 rhythm	the trickiest rhythm: tap it
5 patterns	steps, skips, repeats, sequences
6 marks	dynamics, slurs, speed words

EXAMPLE 1

What do you check first?



?

1 **The key:** how many sharps? 2 **The time:** how many beats? 3 **The F in bar 2:** F or F♯?

G major, 3/4. The F in bar 2 is **F♯**, from the key signature. Count “1 2 3” and go.

EXAMPLE 2

A wrong note in bar 2: now what?

Stop and fix it, or keep going? ?
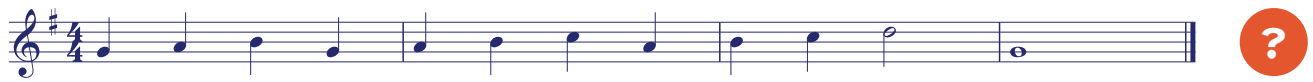
1 **Is the beat** still going? 2 **What does a listener** notice more? 3 **So?**

Keep going: catch the next beat. A stop is heard far more than a wrong note.

PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

Spot the pattern



1. **Bar 1:** what shape?
2. **Bar 2:** the same shape, where?
3. **So**, how much do you really need to read?

A **sequence**: bar 2 is bar 1 a step higher. Read the shape, not every note.

GAME
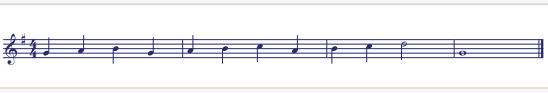
Scan order

1 rhythm	2 key
3 time	4 patterns

Put the four checks in the order of the scan.

Answer: key · time · rhythm · patterns.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



One new piece a day.

Pick something easy: scan for thirty seconds, then play it once, slowly, without stopping. Only then go back.

HOW TO

Read ahead

1. **While you play** one bar, let your eyes move to the next.
2. **Practise it:** cover each bar with a card as you play it.
3. **Read shapes** (steps, skips, chords), not single notes.

THINK OF IT Sight-reading is like reading aloud: you look a few words ahead, and if you trip on one, the sentence goes on.

TRAP

- × Choosing a speed you cannot keep: sight-read slowly.
- × Looking down at your hands: keep your eyes on the music.
- × Skipping the scan: thirty seconds of looking saves many wrong notes.

SEE ALSO
Reading the notes p. 32 · Repetition and sequence p. 150

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 5–6 · Online: Sight-reading trainer

PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 4

Listening

Your ear is a musical instrument too. Train it in small steps: clap a rhythm back, sing a tune back, then hear whether music goes up or down, is major or minor, and whether it has finished.
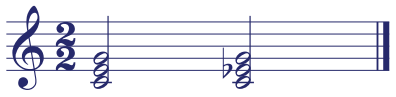
THE SECRET

Sing it back first: if you can sing it, you can play it.



Questions for your ear

Major or minor?



C E G, then C E♭ G: bright, then darker.

Only the middle note changes. Major usually sounds bright and open, minor darker or sadder. Sing the middle note of each and hear it drop.

Intervals by song

INTERVAL	THE FIRST TWO NOTES OF…
major 2nd	Frère Jacques (Frè-re)
major 3rd	Oh When the Saints (Oh when)
perfect 4th	Amazing Grace (A-ma)
perfect 5th	Twinkle (twin-kle **TWIN**: the 2nd to the 3rd note)
major 6th	My Bonnie (My Bon-)
octave	Somewhere over the Rainbow (Some-where)

HOW TO

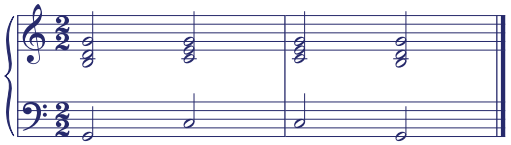
Clap it back

1. **Someone claps** a rhythm of two bars.
2. **You clap it back** straight away, keeping the beat.
3. **Then sing back** a short tune, then find it on the keys.

PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Finished or not?

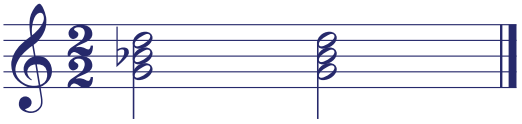


1 **Bar 1** ends on which chord? 2 **Bar 2** ends on which chord? 3 **Which ending** sounds finished?

Bar 1 ends **home** on C (a perfect cadence: finished); bar 2 stops on G (imperfect: not finished).

EXAMPLE 2

Major or minor?



1 **Play the first chord.** Bright or dark? 2 **The second?** 3 **Which note** changed?

First **minor**, then **major**: only the middle note moved, B♭ up to B.

GAME

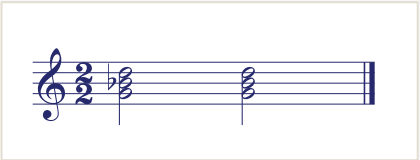
Which song?

1	2	3
5th up	octave up	4th up

Name a song with that leap near the start.

Answer: 1 Twinkle · 2 Somewhere over the Rainbow · 3 Amazing Grace.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Bright or dark?

Ask someone to play major or minor chords in any order. Say “bright” or “dark” for each. Ten in a row?

TRAP

× Guessing from the hands: close your eyes and listen.

SEE ALSO
Intervals p. 45 · Cadences p. 139

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 7–8 · Online: Ear trainer

PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 5

Performing

Playing for others is a skill you can practise, like scales. Nerves are normal: they mean you care. A routine before you start and a plan for slips make them much smaller.

THE SECRET

Breathe, feel a bar of the beat, then begin. After a slip, catch the next beat.



Four steps to the first note

WHEN	WHAT YOU DO
Before	warm up your hands; practise starting, not only the whole piece; play it to a friend or family first
At the piano	adjust the bench; feet flat; breathe out; feel one bar of the beat in your head
If you slip	keep the beat going; catch the next beat or the next phrase; never go back
After	hands in your lap for a moment, stand, bow, smile

THE RULE

The listener follows the beat and the mood. Keep both going and a slip is forgotten in a second.

TWO-MINUTE DRILL Every day this week, play your piece once from the start without stopping, whatever happens, as if someone were listening.

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Playing from memory

Learn it in sections and know where each starts. Memory works best when it is **four kinds at once**: the sound, the feel in your fingers, the look of the page, and knowing the chords and the form.

HOW TO

Practise performing

1. **Choose three starting places** in your piece and practise starting from each.
2. **Play it through once a day** without stopping, whatever happens.
3. **Play to someone**: a friend, family, a phone camera.

PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 5 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

How do you start?

You sit down.
Your heart is racing. ?

1. **The bench:** right height, right distance?
2. **Your breath:** in, then out slowly.
3. **The beat:** what do you hear first?

Adjust, breathe out, and **feel one bar** of the speed in your head. Then the first note.

EXAMPLE 2

You slip in bar 5: what now?

Bar 5: a wrong note, and your hand freezes ?

1. **Do you stop** and start again?
2. **Where is the beat** now?
3. **Where can you rejoin?**

Keep counting and come back in on the **next beat**, or at the start of the next phrase. Never go back.

GAME

Help or not?

1 going back

2 breathe first

3 keep the beat

4 rush to finish

Which help a performance?

Answer: 2 and 3 help; 1 and 4 do not.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

breathe · beat · play · bow

A one-minute concert.

Choose eight bars. Walk to the piano, sit, breathe, feel a bar, play, bow. Do it for someone today.

THINK OF IT The audience wants you to do well: they are on your side from the first note.

TRAP

- × Starting before you are ready: breathe and feel the beat first.
- × Apologising with your face after a slip: keep going and nobody minds.

SEE ALSO
Practising well p. 165 · Expression p. 76

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 9–10 · Online: Practice log

PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · TIPS

When practice isn't working

You practise every day and it is not getting better. Usually the practice, not the player, needs fixing: too fast, too long, or always from the top.

TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
You stumble in the same place every time	**the fingering:** write one in and keep it	p. 163
It is fine slowly, wrong at speed	**the ladder:** three correct, then one notch up	p. 165
You play it from the top every time	**small chunks**, hardest first	p. 165
New pieces take forever to learn	**the scan:** key, time, rhythm, patterns	p. 167
You cannot hear your own mistakes	**listening:** record yourself, sing it	p. 169
It falls apart in front of people	**a routine** and practising starts	p. 171

Four ways to unstick practice

1. **Halve the speed**
   Whatever speed you use, try half. Correct and slow beats fast and wrong.

2. **Shorten the chunk**
   If two bars fail, try one. If one fails, try one beat.

3. **Take a break**
   Ten short sessions beat one long one. Your brain keeps learning between them.

4. **Ask a question**
   Write down what goes wrong, and take it to your teacher.

EXAMPLE

Ten minutes left: what do you play?

One bar you keep missing, and a whole piece you know ?

1. **Which needs the time more?**
2. **How many minutes** on the hard bar?
3. **And** the last minutes?

About **seven minutes** on the hard bar, slowly, then play the whole piece once at the end, for joy.

THINK OF IT Practice does not make perfect: perfect practice does. Slow and correct is the fastest way.

PART IX · BEYOND THE LEVELS

Going further

The notes that decorate a tune, the scales older and newer than major and minor, and moving a whole piece into another key. Read them when your pieces ask for them.

IN THIS PART

Notes outside the chord 175
Modes and other scales (coming) .....
Transposition (coming) .....

PART IX · GOING FURTHER · 1

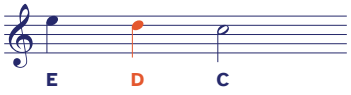
Notes outside the chord

Under a tune, the chord holds the main notes. The other notes of the tune are **non-chord notes**: they lean on the chord for a moment, then step back into it. Name them, and you know which notes to shape and which to rest on.

THE SECRET

A note outside the chord moves by step: into the chord, out of it, or both.

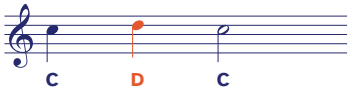
Passing note



over C

steps **between** two chord notes

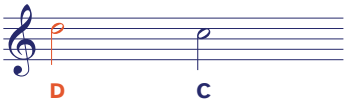
Auxiliary note



over C

steps **out and back** to the same note

Appoggiatura



over C

leans on the beat, then steps into the chord

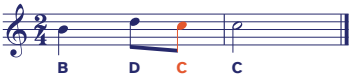
Suspension



F chord, then C

is **held over** from the last chord, then falls

Anticipation



G chord, then C

arrives **early**, before its chord

Five ways out of the chord and back. Red: outside the chord.

1. Name the **chord** under the bar: its three notes.
2. Mark every tune note that is **not** one of them.
3. Look how it **moves in and out**: that gives its name.
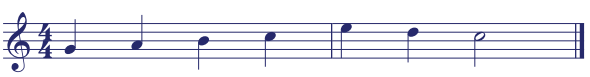
The five at a glance

NAME	HOW IT MOVES	BEAT	ALSO CALLED
Passing note	steps between two chord notes, going the same way	usually weak	—
Auxiliary note	steps away from a chord note and back to it	usually weak	neighbour note
Appoggiatura	lands on the strong beat and leans, then steps into the chord	strong	from Italian *appoggiare*, to lean
Suspension	held over from the last chord, then falls by step	strong	prepared, held, resolved
Anticipation	a note of the next chord, sounded early	weak	—

PART IX · GOING FURTHER · 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE

Which notes are outside the chord? The chord is C



1 **The chord is C**: C, E and G.
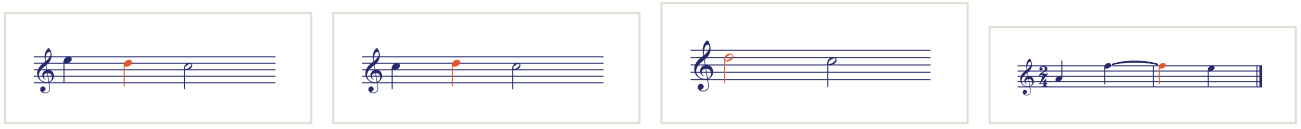
2 **Mark every note** that is not C, E or G.

3 **How does each one move?**

A and B: two passing notes from G up to C (B falls on beat 3, and still passes). In bar 2, D passes from E down to C.

GAME

Name it

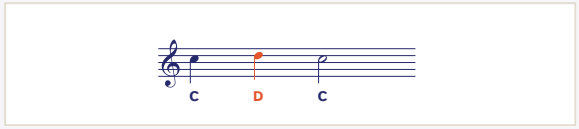


1 2 3 4

Passing, auxiliary, appoggiatura or suspension? The chord is C (in 4: F, then C).

Answer: 1 passing · 2 auxiliary · 3 appoggiatura · 4 suspension

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Play C D C, then C B C, over a C chord.

Out and straight back: two auxiliary notes.

YOU KNOW THIS

Ode to Joy (Beethoven)



Bar 1 sits on C (C E G). The **F** steps from E up to G: a **passing note**.

Try it. Play bar 1 with a C chord in the left hand and hear the F slip between E and G.

THINK OF IT Stepping stones in a stream: the chord is the bank. Step onto a stone for a moment, then land on the bank again.

TRAP

× Calling a note outside the chord a mistake: it is the tune's colour. It almost always moves by step.

× Choosing a chord for a passing note: choose for the main notes.

SEE ALSO

Chords under a melody p. 142 · Chords in a key p. 116 · Ornaments p. 88

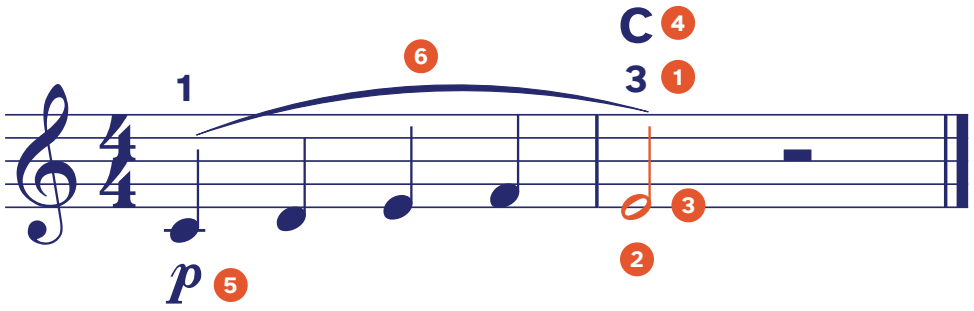
PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 1–2 · Online: Library › Non-chord notes

PUTTING IT TOGETHER · 1

Everything one note tells you

Look at the red note. It carries six pieces of information at once, and each one can be read straight off the page. Read all six and the note is right; miss one and it is only nearly right.



1 The finger number

3: the middle finger plays it. Fingering is planned, not guessed.

PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · P. 163

2 The beat

Beat 1 of bar 2, and it is held for **two beats**.

PART II · TIME · P. 50

3 The note name

E: the white key just right of the two black keys.

PART I · PITCH · P. 22

4 The chord

The **C** above the staff: this E belongs to the C major chord.

PART V · CHORDS · P. 110

5 The marks

p and the slur: play it softly and smoothly.

PART III · EXPRESSION · P. 76

6 The phrase

The slur ends here, so the note lands gently, like the end of a sentence.

PART VII · SHAPE AND STYLE · P. 148

THE SAME SIX, IN ANY MUSIC

A CLASSICAL SCORE
Most of it is written in: finger numbers, dynamics, slurs. Your job is to read every one.

A POP LEAD SHEET
A melody and chord names only. You choose the fingers, the marks and the shape yourself.

A JAZZ CHART
Chords and a style word such as Swing: the beat and the shape are yours to feel.

Try it on any piece: point to one note and find all six. Finger numbers count as much as the note name.

THINK OF IT A note is like a word said aloud: its spelling, its timing, its tone of voice and its place in the sentence all change what it means.

PUTTING IT TOGETHER · 2

When a passage won't come right

Name the problem first, then fix that one thing. Most hard bars are hard for one reason, and the six things a note tells you point straight to it.

TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
You stumble in the same place every time	**the finger number**	Part VIII · Playing and listening
It rushes, drags or the counting slips	**the beat**	Part II · Time
A note sounds wrong	**the note name** and the key	Part I · Pitch, Part IV · Scales and ke
A chord sounds odd or thin	**the chord**	Part V · Chords
It is correct but flat and dull	**the marks**	Part III · Expression
It does not seem to go anywhere	**the phrase**	Part VII · Shape and style

Six ways to fix a hard bar

1. **Slow it right down**
   Slow enough to be right three times in a row, then a little faster.
2. **Hands separately**
   Each hand on its own until it is easy, then together, slowly.
3. **Start from the end**
   Play the last beat, then the last two, then three: you always finish on what you know best.
4. **Practise the join**
   The last note of one bar and the first of the next: most slips live there.
5. **Climb the metronome**
   Three correct times at one speed, then one notch up; if it falls apart, go back down.
6. **Put it back**
   Play two bars before and two after, so the fixed bar lives inside the music again.

Before you play a new piece: a thirty-second look

Key signature
Which sharps or flats, all the way through?

Time signature
How many beats in a bar, and which note is one beat?

Tempo and mood
The words at the top: how fast, what character?

Patterns
Bars that repeat or nearly repeat: learn them once.

THINK OF IT Like a doctor: name the symptom first, then treat that one thing. Practising everything harder rarely fixes the one bar that is wrong.

GLOSSARY

Glossary

Every musical word in the Handbook, in one line, with the page where it is explained.

8va (ottava) play the notes under the dotted line an octave higher p.36

a tempo back to the speed before p.82

accelerando (accel.) gradually faster p.82

accent a > over a note: start it more strongly p.79

acciaccatura a tiny note with a slash, crushed in as fast as possible p.88

accidental a sharp, flat or natural written before a note; it lasts until the bar line p.39

Adagio slow, at ease p.82

Alberti bass a broken chord in the left hand: low, high, middle, high (C G E G) p.152

Allegro fast and lively p.82

anacrusis an upbeat: notes before the first full bar p.65

Andante at a walking pace p.82

appoggiatura a tiny note without a slash; it leans, taking half the main note's time. Also a note outside the chord that leans on the beat (p. 175) p.88

articulation how notes are joined or separated: slurs, staccato, tenuto, accents p.79

augmented triad a triad with 3 + 3 keys between p.113

bar a group of beats between two bar lines p.50

Baroque music of about 1600–1750: Bach, Handel p.159

bass clef the F clef: its two dots hug the line for bass F p.27

beam a thick line joining quavers or semiquavers into a beat p.65

beat the steady pulse you count p.50

binary form two sections, A B p.156

broken chord the notes of a chord played one after another p.110

cadence the last two chords of a phrase: musical punctuation p.139

cantabile in a singing style p.79

chord three or more notes played together p.110

circle of fifths the keys in a circle: go right, one more sharp; go left, one more flat p.105

Classical music of about 1750–1820: Haydn, Mozart p.159

clef the sign at the start of the staff that names one line p.27

coda an ending section; jump to it at "To Coda" p.71

compound time each beat is a dotted note and divides into three (6/8, 9/8, 12/8) p.62

crescendo (cresc.) getting louder, little by little p.76

crotchet a note worth one beat in 4/4 p.53

da capo (D.C.) "from the head": go back to the beginning p.71

dal segno (D.S.) "from the sign": go back to the segno p.71

diminished triad a triad with 2 + 2 keys between p.113

diminuendo (dim.) getting softer, little by little p.76

dolce sweetly p.79

dominant the 5th note of the scale, and the chord built on it (V) p.116

dot adds half the note's value p.56

duplet two notes in the time of three p.65

dynamics the signs for loud and soft: pp p mp mf f ff p.76

GLOSSARY · CONTINUED

enharmonic two names for one key, such as F♯ and G♭ p.39

fermata a pause: hold the note longer than written p.82

Fine "the end": after a D.C. or D.S., stop here p.71

five-finger position one finger on each of five keys in a row p.163

flat (♭) the very next key to the left p.39

form the plan of a whole piece, in letters p.156

forte (f) loud p.76

grand staff treble and bass staves joined by a brace p.27

hairpin a crescendo or diminuendo sign that opens or closes p.76

hemiola two bars of three felt as three bars of two p.68

homophonic a tune with chords underneath p.152

imitation another hand or voice copies the idea p.150

imperfect cadence ending on V: a comma p.139

interrupted cadence V to vi: a surprise p.139

interval the distance between two notes p.42

inversion a chord with a note other than the root at the bottom p.119

key the scale a piece is built on, and its home note p.99

key signature the sharps or flats at the start of every line p.99

Largo very slow and broad p.82

leading note the 7th note of the scale, one key below home p.93

ledger line a short line for a note above or below the staff p.36

legato smoothly joined p.79

major scale tone, tone, semitone, tone, tone, tone, semitone p.93

major triad a triad with 3 + 2 keys between p.113

metronome mark ♩ = 76: 76 beats in a minute p.82

mezzo (m) "half": mp half soft, mf half loud p.76

Middle C the C nearest the middle of the keyboard, on a ledger line between the staves p.22

minim a note worth two crotchets p.53

minor scale the major scale on the same note with 3, 6 and 7 one key lower p.96

minor triad a triad with 2 + 3 keys between p.113

Moderato at a moderate speed p.82

modulation changing key during a piece p.154

monophonic one line alone p.152

mordent the note, its neighbour above (or below), the note p.88

motif a short idea of 2 to 6 notes that comes back p.148

natural (♮) cancels a sharp or flat p.39

octave from one note to the next of the same name: 11 keys between p.45

ornament a small sign for a quick group of notes around the main note p.88

pedal (sustain) the right pedal: notes keep ringing until you lift it p.85

perfect cadence V to I: a full stop p.139

phrase a musical sentence, often 4 bars p.148

pianissimo (pp) very soft p.76

piano (p) soft p.76

plagal cadence IV to I: the "Amen" p.139

polyphonic two or more tunes at once p.152

Presto very fast p.82

progression a trip from chord to chord p.144

GLOSSARY · CONTINUED

pulse the steady beat underneath the music p.50

quaver half a crotchet p.53

rallentando (rall.) gradually slower p.82

relative minor the minor key with the same key signature, a minor 3rd below p.99

repeat sign two dots and a double bar: play the bars again p.71

rest a silence of a set length p.53

ritardando (rit.) gradually slower p.82

Romantic music of about 1820–1900: Chopin, Schumann p.159

rondo A B A C A: the first idea keeps coming back p.156

root the note a chord is built on and named after p.110

rubato time stretched and given back, for expression p.68

scale the notes of a key in order, up or down p.93

semibreve a whole note: four crotchets p.53

semiquaver half a quaver p.53

semitone the very next key: no key between p.22

sequence the same shape repeated higher or lower p.150

seventh chord a triad with one more 3rd on top p.122

sforzando (sfz) one note made suddenly strong p.76

sharp (♯) the very next key to the right p.39

sight-reading playing music at first sight p.167

simple time each beat divides into two (2/4, 3/4, 4/4) p.59

slash chord C/E: the chord, then the bass note p.131

slur a curve over different notes: join them p.79

staccato a dot: short, detached p.79

staff the five lines and four spaces music is written on p.27

subdominant the 4th note of the scale, and the chord built on it (IV) p.116

swing pairs of quavers played long–short p.68

syncopation the stress falls off the beat p.68

tempo the speed of the beat p.50

tenuto a line: hold the note its full length p.79

ternary form A B A: out, away and back p.156

texture how many lines sound at once, and how they fit p.152

theme and variations one tune, changed each time it returns p.156

tie a curve joining two notes of the same pitch: one longer sound p.56

time signature top: how many beats; bottom: which note gets one beat p.59

tone two semitones: one key between p.22

tonic the 1st note of the scale: home p.93

treble clef the G clef: it curls round the line for treble G p.27

triad three notes stacked: play one, skip one, play one p.110

trill the note and its neighbour above, back and forth quickly p.88

triplet three notes in the time of two p.65

turn above, the note, below, the note p.88

twelve-bar blues I I I I · IV IV I I · V IV I I (or V in the last bar, to go round again) p.144

una corda (u.c.) the left (soft) pedal p.85

upbeat see anacrusis p.65

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